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Loudoun County School Board, 4th Tuesday School Board Meeting, Tuesday, March 24, 2026

Date	Tuesday, March 24, 2026
Place	Loudoun County Public Schools / School Board meeting (see BoardDocs / LCPS-TV)
Length	6h 22m (video)
- Official meeting video (Vimeo / LCPS-TV): https://player.vimeo.com/video/1176666991?rel=0 - BoardDocs (School Board): https://go.boarddocs.com/vsba/loudoun/Board.nsf/Public	

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Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-10. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:03:37] afternoon everyone i call to order this march 24th 2026 loudon county school board meeting the first item on our agenda we'll start this afternoon with item 2 the approval of the consent agenda board members are there any changes to be made to the consent agenda madam chair yes ms mccarty thank you so much i would move i'd like to remove the um the minutes from the march 5th meeting of this special school board session thank you um we will move that item to action it will be the first action item of the meeting oh i'm sorry was there a second

[00:04:15] thank you that um well so to any school board member can move an item off the agenda without a second but um i did hear it and say it so now we're all clear um so miss ricardi's item will be moved to the action agenda and it will be the first item on action for this evening with that before we vote on the consent agenda we have several proclamations to read the first proclamation recognizes march 2026 as developmental disability awareness month this proclamation will

[00:04:50] be read by vice chair donahue thank you madam chair whereas loudon county public schools is committed to fostering an inclusive equitable and supportive learning environment in which every student is valued respected and empowered to thrive and whereas march is nationally recognized as Developmental Disabilities Awareness Month established to increase public understanding of developmental disabilities and to celebrate the many contributions of individuals with developmental

disabilities in our schools and communities, and whereas students and community members with developmental disabilities enrich Loudoun County with their talents, perspectives, creativity, and determination, strengthening our schools and contributing

[00:05:29] to a more vibrant, diverse, and compassionate community, and whereas Loudoun County Public schools recognizes the ongoing need to expand access reduce barriers and ensure that individuals with developmental disabilities have equitable opportunities to learn grow and participate fully in academic social and extracurricular life and whereas educators families support staff and community partners work collaboratively to promote acceptance inclusion and high expectations for all students including those with developmental disabilities and whereas honoring developmental disabilities awareness month affirms our commitment to building a school system and community where every individual regardless of

[00:06:08] ability has the opportunity to thrive and pursue their goals. Now therefore be it resolved that the Loudoun County School Board formally recognizes March 2026 as Developmental Disabilities Awareness Month and encourages our schools and communities to support awareness and activities that celebrate our students. Thank you. The next proclamation recognizes April 2026 as Autism Acceptance Month.

[00:06:35] This proclamation will be read by Ms. LaBelle. Thank you, Madam Chair. Whereas the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention made note that 1 in 31 children have been identified with Autism Spectrum Disorder, or ASD, with 1 in 20 males and 1 in 70 females, And whereas most recent statistics from the Virginia Department of Education in December of 2024 reported 33,742 students with autism as their primary disability in the Commonwealth.

[00:07:13] And in December of 2025, Loudoun County Public Schools, LCPS, reported that 2,361 students with a primary disability category of autism are served in LCPS. And, whereas the increase of numbers of students with ASD in Virginia mirrors national statistics and is the subject of research to better understand the causes of autism and factors contributing to the rise in the number of children diagnosed.

[00:07:44] And, whereas LCPS celebrates autism acceptance by wearing red to support LCPS students with autism and their families on Monday, April 6th, 2026, World Autism Day, celebrated globally on Thursday, April 2nd, 2026, and supports school-based efforts to provide special events promoting autism acceptance, and whereas LCPS empowers all students through inclusive and meaningful learning opportunities with exemplary staff and recognizes that an engaged community,

[00:08:21] including families and caregivers, is a part of a valuable collaboration with LCPS staff and whereas LCPS supports open communication and respectful relationships resulting in positive outcomes for all involved and will continue to provide support and training to students, staff, and their families.

[00:08:45] Now, therefore, be it resolved that the Loudoun County School Board formally recognizes April 2026 as Autism Acceptance Month in Loudoun County Public Schools. Thank you. The third proclamation recognizes April 2026 as the month of the military child.

[00:09:04] This proclamation will be read by Ms. Chernoff. Thank you, Madam Chair. Whereas April is the month of the military child, a special month to recognize and pay tribute to the military families and their children for their daily sacrifices, their commitment and courage, and their support to our armed forces.

[00:09:21] And whereas the Commonwealth of Virginia is home to more than 80,000 children whose parents serve in the military. And whereas military families and employees in Loudoun County include active duty service members in the Air Force, Army, Coast Guard, Marine Corps, Navy, and Space Force, and as members of the Reserves and the National Guard.

[00:09:40] And whereas LCPS has 2,004 self-reported military-connected students, including 1,113 students who have a parent or guardian who is on active duty, 622 students who have a parent or guardian in the reserves, and 269 students with a parent or guardian in the National Guard, and 296 employees who have self-reported as military veterans.

[00:10:04] And whereas Virginia is a proud member of the Interstate Compact and Educational Opportunity for military children, which addresses key transition issues encountered by military students, including enrollment, placement and attendance, eligibility and graduation.

[00:10:20] And whereas the children of our service members continue to make significant contributions to schools, communities, our Commonwealth and the nation, despite prolonged and repeated absences of one or both parents. And whereas military connected children demonstrate resilience, perseverance, maturity and cultural competence in the face of frequent moves, family separations through deployments, and reintegration following deployments, and whereas across the nation, individuals are encouraged to wear purple on April 15th, 2026 in celebration of Purple Up for Military Kids to show support for military-connected children

[00:10:59] and to thank them for their strength and sacrifices. Now, therefore, be it resolved that the Loudoun County School Board recognizes April 2026 as the month of the military child and encourages Loudoun County Public Schools to celebrate this recognition with activities to honor the contributions of our students from military families and be it further resolved that the Loudoun County School Board expresses its sincere gratitude to military connected students throughout Loudoun County for their service to our great nation.

[00:11:28] In witness whereof, the Loudoun County School Board issues this proclamation to honor and recognize the month of the military child. - Thank you. The fourth proclamation recognizes April 2026 as Arab American Heritage Month. This proclamation will be read by Vice Chair Donohue.

[00:11:44] Thank you, Madam Chair. Whereas the Commonwealth of Virginia is enriched by the diverse cultures, languages, faiths, and traditions that shape our communities and strengthen our public schools, and whereas April is nationally recognized as Arab American Heritage Month, a time to celebrate the history, heritage, and contributions of Arab Americans whose roots trace to 22 countries across the Middle East and North Africa, And whereas Arab Americans have made significant contributions to our nation and to the Commonwealth of Virginia in public service, education, business, medicine, science, arts, military service, and civic leadership.

[00:12:19] And whereas Loudoun County Public Schools serve students and families of Arab heritage whose languages, stories, and lived experiences enrich classroom learning and deepen global understanding for all students. And whereas, recognizing and affirming the heritage of Arab American students, staff, and families strengthens mutual respect, combats stereotypes, and promotes cross-cultural understanding.

[00:12:42] Whereas, Loudoun County Public Schools is stronger when it reflects and respects the full diversity of the school community, which enabled 96.7% of all students in LCPS to graduate in 2025. and whereas fostering a culture of belonging where every student is seen, valued, and supported is essential to academic excellence and the well-being of a diverse and thriving student community.

[00:13:05] Now, therefore, be it resolved that the Loudoun County School Board hereby proclaims April 2026 as Arab American Heritage Month and encourages all students to celebrate the contributions, cultures, and accomplishments of Arab Americans through age-appropriate educational activities and community engagement, And be it further resolved that we reaffirm our commitment to ensuring that every student in our division experiences a safe, inclusive, and welcoming learning environment where diversity is honored and belonging is a shared responsibility.

[00:13:33] Thank you. The final proclamation tonight recognizes April 2026 as National School Library Month. This proclamation will be read by Dr. Rasheed. Thank you, Chair. Whereas April 2026 marks the 41st annual National School Library Month, a time to recognize the essential role of school librarians and the library programs they create to support student success.

[00:13:59] And whereas Loudoun County Public Schools libraries provide and manage the circulation of more than 1.5 million copies of print and digital materials in dynamic social learning spaces and physical learning environments in a high-tech world, including production, presentation and teaching areas and whereas certified school librarians co-teach information literacy and reading and consult with teachers and students to make the library a place of learning that embraces and promotes deeper learning through authentic challenging experiences with problem solving critical thinking and collaboration and whereas these school

[00:14:37] librarians work in collaboration with educators to further students literacy skills, digital citizenship, and information fluency, preparing them for lifelong learning. And whereas school libraries provide inclusive, student-centered learning to foster a love of reading through a wide range of books and digital resources aligned with students' interests, abilities, and learning needs.

[00:15:04] And whereas school libraries support instructional goals by providing high-quality resources, technology, and research tools that enhance curriculum and deepen student engagement. And whereas school librarians curate materials and reflect the experiences, perspectives, and contributions of all communities, ensuring equitable access to knowledge and accurate information.

[00:15:27] And whereas school libraries promote intellectual freedom by encouraging open inquiry, respectful discourse, and access to multiple viewpoints. Now, therefore, be it resolved that the Loudoun County School Board formally recognized april 2026 as school library month across loudon county public schools thank you i'll now entertain a motion to approve the consent agenda vice chair donahue i move to approve the consent agenda as amended is there a second second all right we have a motion by vice

[00:16:03] chair donahue and it has been properly seconded by mr svensson at this time we'll take a vote to approve the consent agenda clerk please open the vote board members please record your vote clerk please close and display the vote.

[00:16:24] That motion passes with seven members voting yes, including Ms. Riccardi, Mr. Svensson, Ms. Chernoff, myself, Vice Chair Donahue, Dr. Rasheed, and Ms. LaBelle, Mrs. Griffiths abstaining, and Mr. Pepper absent for the vote.

[00:16:41] With that, let's move on to our Administrative Advisory Committee update. Tonight, we'll be hearing from our Head Start Policy Council, which will be presented by Miss Alexis Duffin, our Head Start and Step Supervisor, and Hannah Bugg, our Policy Council Chairperson and Parent Representative. Welcome. It's so nice to have you both here. The floor is yours.

[00:17:05] Thank you so much for having us. We are thrilled to be here tonight to talk about Head Start. I feel like I've been here a few times, but I'm talking about starting towards excellence in preschool, the STEP program, so it's really cool to be able to sit down and really focus on Head Start. And I'm really going to narrow that focus today to talk about our Head Start Policy Council. And the only way that makes sense to have a parent-led policy council is to co-present with a parent. Yay! So I am thrilled. I have Hannah Bug here. She is our chairperson for our Head Start Policy Council. So my plan today is to really

[00:17:41] just go through and talk about the structure of our Head Start Policy Council, what it works, What do we do? What are the roles? And then I'm going to pass it to Hannah, and she's really going to be talking about experience and impact. My clicker's not clicking. There we go. I don't know if I did that or somebody else. Okay. So this is our snapshot. So I like just to kind of take a step back and talk about Head Start. What does that mean? Head Start is our preschool program through Loudoun County Public Schools that is federally and locally funded. We have 100 students in our

[00:18:20] Head Start program, which means we have six classrooms spread all throughout Loudoun County Public Schools. We are using the Tools of the Mind curriculum that is new this year and it is fantastic because it matches with our STEP program along with early childhood special education and just on Thursday for our county-wide PD day we had an amazing collaborative curriculum-led PD session. Another piece about our Head Start program is that we provide comprehensive services.

[00:18:47] So instead of just providing education to the student, we provide comprehensive services for the entire family. And then also we have a parent-led policy council, which is our focus for tonight. Next slide. It is important to note where those locations are.

[00:19:04] So I stated that we had six Head Start classrooms, and here's where they are. And you'll notice that we're in a lot of high schools. So we partner with the Early Childhood Education Program at high schools, and a lot of our programs reside inside the preschool lab. It's a beautiful partnership where preschoolers have an amazing space in high-quality education, but we're also partnering with our high school students that get to experience what it looks like to be a part of an early childhood education class.

[00:19:29] Next slide. So we're going to talk about our policy council. So the reason this is, we're here tonight, is really to talk about its distinctive shared governance model. So I'm going to talk about what that looks like, but it's where our parents and our guardians, they are the ones who are actively participating.

[00:19:47] It is parent-led. Our Head Start staff, we are there to provide information, but all of the decisions are ultimately made through the policy council process. Next slide. So what is shared governance? It is when we have collaborative decision-making.

[00:20:03] So we have our governing body, which is you. You oversee our legal and our fiscal responsibilities. And we have our policy council, which is not just parents, but it's also our community input. It. So we have community representatives and we have parent representatives that provide the vote for all of the policies and procedures that we put in place. And we have the Head Start staff as a part of it. So we are the ones who bring the information forward. We know those Head Start regulations inside and

out. So knowing those regulations, we bring the information and we say, hey, this is what we're being asked to do. We need to create an attendance policy. Here are some ideas. And then we ask for feedback through our policy council practice. And that just ensures

[00:20:42] that we have our parents and our community members. They're the ones who are helping to shape the program and the design, and it's a partner. So everybody's a key partner in their child's education. Next slide. Oh, and here's a diagram. I love a good visual. So you can see that in orange we have our policy council. That's our people. Who's involved? Policy council, Head Start staff, and our school board. And I'm going to talk more about what that looks like. And then what are the responsibilities? It's program design and operation. It's creating procedures to implement those federal standards to make sure that we are constantly compliant. We call that review ready.

[00:21:16] And it's also to make sure that we're understanding our program goals, and we're changing our goals, and we're meeting our program goals. Next slide. So the role of the Policy Council is really to help determine program design and operation in defining long-term and short-term goals and objectives.

[00:21:34] So we have something called School Readiness Goals that we put together that's very educationally based, and we track how we're doing within that year. But also Head Start says you need to have a five-year goal. So we have larger program goals where we're really focusing on that bigger picture, but also those more narrow ones as well.

[00:21:53] We create policies and procedures. If it's not in writing, it doesn't exist, right? So we make sure everything is put down in writing, and it really guides our program on what do we need to be doing? How can we stay compliant with all of our federal regulations? And then we like to reflect on quality of services offered through self-assessment, and this is something that's very exciting, and it's happening next month.

[00:22:15] It happens every year with our program where we take a step back and we say, how are we doing? And we look at every single service area for Head Start, which is education, it's enrollment, it's eligibility. We're looking at health and nutrition, mental health. And we ask everybody, Head Start staff, we talk to our families, we talk to our community members, and we say, what's going well, what's not going well?

[00:22:37] And then we make adjustments. So our Head Start program has been in Loudoun County Public Schools for 32 years, we don't do things just because that's the way we've been doing them so we really take that self-assessment process to reflect on how we're doing and make changes for the following year so our policy council is a part of that along with a broader community just to gain some input on really defining what our program looks like next slide the responsibilities of a policy council member is to work in partnership with our head start staff and the school board to develop and review all of those policies and procedures to ensure that

[00:23:13] we're compliant and we we know that's a lot it's a lot of information so we put a little picture in here of our shared governance packet and that's where we provide all of the information so we give this to all of our policy council members before the meeting to kind of help digest that so we're not just coming at the meeting with hey we're going to talk about recruitment strategies and then expect some decisions to be made we understand that that takes time and information needs to be digested. So we share all of that relevant information ahead of time. And again, that's our role as staff to provide information to help parents and community members make the best

[00:23:50] decisions for our program. Next slide. And we can't do that without parents, so we have to recruit them. So we do that in a fun way. We call it our fall family night, and we do this every September. And we have a new policy council, for the most part, every year because we have new students.

[00:24:07] Hannah's the exception to the rule because she had a three-year-old last year, and that child is now four. So she's a returning parent. And every fall, we're usually starting with a blank slate. So we're retraining our policy council. We're showing them how this works and showing them how we make these big decisions. So we have to recruit. So we recruit in the fall with our fall family night. We open it to every enrolled family in our program. And we have dinner. We have some kind of activity for kids.

[00:24:35] And then we educate families. So we say, this is what our policy council does. This is the impact you can have. This is how you can be a key player in your child's education. And that's how families join our policy council. And the best part of this year's fall family night was having our previous parents speak to the upcoming parents and say, this is why you should be a part of the Head Start Policy Council. And it was the most impactful way to recruit. And Hannah, of course, was a part of that. Next slide. So one thing I think that we've really been working on over the past several years is that constant flow of communication.

[00:25:13] So we wanted to make this diagram because I'm a visual person and I love how this all fits together. So policy council's in the middle. That's the meeting that we've just been talking about. But on top you'll see a school board and you notice that those gears are all connected. And below it we have family committee meetings.

[00:25:28] And these three pieces help with this constant flow of communication to ensure that everybody's voice is heard. Next slide. So now I'm gonna break it down. So here we're gonna talk about just the policy council piece, middle gear we are focusing on making sure that all of our members receive training on how to have the meeting what are what are the procedures we use Robert's rules so we need to make sure we go through how to run the meeting we elect officers and we discuss key head start topics we actually have a training plan I did not include the whole thing because it is quite cumbersome but that little snippet is just March so that's what we're planning

[00:26:06] to do or we did actually for our March there it is we were just talking like Like, what do we, there's our March Policy Council meeting. So you can see what we just did last Wednesday. But we have a plan. So we train parents. So I presented information on what the self-assessment process looks like.

[00:26:23] And then we talk about items that need approval, like our budget planning for program expenses. So we had somebody speak to that after providing all that relevant information. So some of those topics include those program goals, ongoing monitoring, budget development, recruitment, and enrollment priorities.

[00:26:40] and our policy council this information is handed out monthly so we meet eight times a year but no matter what month it is the information is always being provided and you'll notice that as a school board the shared governance packet is shared with you every single month. Next slide. So this bottom gear is our family committee meeting and this is the piece that I feel like we have really perfected over the last few years on ensuring that even if a parent isn't a part of policy council they still have the opportunity to have their voice heard so what happens is that there is a virtual family committee meeting for each one of our classrooms so there's six meetings that happen each month

[00:27:19] this is held by our family and community partnership coordinator and what she does is she brings all of the information that will be discussed at the next policy council meeting and says hey this month they're going to talk about these procedures or these policies and she presents them and ask for feedback. So that action is done before our meeting, our policy council meeting happens. And then when we meet as a policy council, we go through all those comments. So we look for trends and themes and we're able to bring that information from all six classrooms, which we've noticed that sometimes you get different information from different classrooms and it's very important

[00:27:55] to hear all of those voices. But we get those parent voices, we bring them into the policy council picture which then connects to my final gear which next slide is the school board so we were then able to share all of this information so all of these pieces are connected and they move together we're very fortunate that we have a school board liaison so Ms. Chernoff serves as our liaison and attends our monthly meetings so she's there hearing that parent feedback real time so it connects the parent voice to the school board within our policy council we make sure that that information is shared monthly with our school board and you do

[00:28:33] have that is shared and in June is when we ask for approvals so instead of coming every month because we have to split it up for all of the approvals and policy council to make sure we aren't having a 10-hour meeting one day so we split it up across the year but for you we just bring it to you in June for approval that makes the most sense so the policy council's already approved it and then it comes to you for additional approval. And then at the end of the day, the school board is the final piece in any decision-making process. Next slide. So I've talked a lot about the structure. So what does it look like? What are the roles? How do we make this work in Loudoun

[00:29:12] County? But now I'm going to turn it over to Hannah. I asked Hannah to come tonight and I said, hey, I think it would be really great if we could hear that parent piece. So I asked her just to talk about, you know, what does it mean to be a part of our Head Start Policy Council and what kind of impact has that had? So I'm going to turn it over to Hannah. Thank you for having me here to share my experience with you guys today. So my first time joining the policy council as a family representative member was in the fall of last school year, which was also my son's first year of Head Start. It was all new to me. I had just given birth to my second son as well. So I was a

[00:29:47] little nervous to try and get involved, but I saw it as a great opportunity to learn about the program and to be involved and volunteer as much as I could. I very quickly made connections with other parents involved and it instantly felt like I became a part of a community full of support.

[00:30:06] The staff showed and still does show so much support to the Head Start families. As I mentioned when I first joined I had just had my second child and was pretty apprehensive to participate but the Head Start staff made it very accommodating for me and others to bring their children along to the meetings and the other events that they host. Learning how the program operates felt intimidating at first too, but once we dived into the meetings, like she was talking about the shared governance and everything, it was, it's all clear in black and white. I absolutely love how transparent the

[00:30:40] program is. We discussed where all the money comes from, all of the expenses and purchases being made and the roles that every last staff member plays in the program. So from there, like I was very interested in becoming part of the budget committee as well. So after learning about everything and how

it works, it just felt like a perfect way to be involved as a parent and to give my personal feedback and perspective on what we could do more for our families. The Head Start program already

[00:31:15] values making sure families are supported in many ways and making sure all the needs are met from within the program, as well as partnering with local agencies in the community. So I myself already felt very, you know, overwhelmed with gratitude that my family could be a part of the program. It's helped us tremendously. My son has been so supported and he's shown so much progress since being a part of the program. So even when I needed advice on parenting or even things like mental health they were always there and never have I felt embarrassed about my situations

[00:31:51] they truly were angels to me as like I said I was deep in postpartum trenches I didn't have to worry about anything with all the support that was shown and given so joining the the policy council and budget committee you know the question that came to mind was excuse me but can we what can we come up with to use these funds that we have so we can continue to support our families, even when it seems like the program has everything covered.

[00:32:21] So teaming up with the best group of moms who were on the committee, a part of the program, and having staff support to teach us and guide us to bring our ideas into reality was an amazing experience. Having already felt so blessed by the program, it felt good to be a part of the process.

[00:32:38] So last year, we decided to use the funds for our parent empowerment program or our workshop, and we wanted to create that workshop to be a safe space and a learning experience for parents to really talk about, you know, what they go through and struggle with on a day-to-day basis when being parents.

[00:32:59] We all know that parenting is not a breeze, and it can be very difficult, especially, you know, when you don't know how to deal or recognize your child's emotions or your own emotions. A lot of us have children with behavioral issues that we don't know how to take on. A lot of us have no outlet to discuss or to seek advice about these things. So creating that space to get everyone together to share and to learn and to be more conscious about parenting, learning new strategies, pointing our families in the right directions for support, I thought it was

[00:33:35] a very great turnout. The parents were super engaged and, you know, took home a lot of information and great tools. Aside from the workshop, we were also able to have amazing community volunteers to entertain the kids while parents were in the breakout sessions. They had a blast with all the activities planned, and they were also able to take home many raffle prizes, which is always a fun thing that we are able to do. So it's not just for the parents, it's a whole family event as well.

[00:34:11] Just a night of fun, food, learning, connection with one another. We're also able to use funds for teacher appreciation as well. We thought it was important to include the ones who teach and care for our children day in and day out because as parents in the program, we're technically not allowed to give gifts, you know, Teacher Appreciation Week and things like that, so to show them appreciation in this way on behalf of the whole community was great. So yeah, and now as we've entered the new school year, we've been planning a new event and new ideas, and I really look forward

[00:34:47] to that. So in closing, just being a part of the Policy Council and Budget Committee, it has absolutely helped me step outside of my comfort zone. I'm usually a behind-the-scenes type of person and with participating in these things it has made me think more out loud and use my voice and opinions to

achieve a goal with the team i've also become chairperson for policy council and that has helped me a lot with public speaking um it has truly been a great experience to be a part of so thank you for letting me share so that that's why we're here tonight so we just wanted

[00:35:24] to hear from hannah and her experience and this parent empowerment workshop that was put on last year was just phenomenal. So our federal regulations say that we need to have a budget committee that decides on an event that educates Head Start families. So that was their task. You have \$1,200 and it's from the federal, like that is our regulation, \$1,200 has to be spent on a parent education event decided on by families. And they did this. And it was just so awesome to see them come together and have an event that was truly meaningful for all Head Start families. But that's

[00:35:58] why it's a parent-led committee. It is for them to decide what do we need and how can we do that. So being a part of this and really just being the guiding force of this is what you have, here's what the regulations say, what do you guys want to do? So last year was extremely successful and we're just thrilled that Hannah's back and now she's our chairperson. But, you know, we're here tonight to talk about what it looked like, but really we're here tonight to hear from Hannah. And that's all we have. Thank you both so much for the presentation. It's so nice to see you, Ms. Stephan, and Ms. Bugg, it is so incredibly impactful to hear about your experience and

[00:36:35] all of the wonderful things that you've experienced, not only as chair, but as a parent on the Head Start Policy Council. I do miss you guys a lot, but I know you're in good hands with Ms. Chernoff. So thank you so much. And with that, I'll open the floor to questions.

[00:36:53] Oh, yes, Dr. Rasheed. Thank you, Chair, and thank you for the presentation, the slew of information, and the reflection as well. I was just wondering if parents can return to the policy council even if they don't have a child in the Head Start program, like even in a training capacity or advising capacity, because it seems like training every year might be a heavy lift.

[00:37:15] Great question. Yes. So they can come back as community members. And we actually encourage our families. So if you've had this great experience, you don't have a child in Head Start, that's okay. Come back as a community member. Thank you. That's reassuring. Thank you. Ms. Chernoff?

[00:37:32] Thank you, Ms. Chandler, and I do greatly thank you for trusting me with being the liaison. I don't know how you parted with it because it is one of the favorite mornings of my month. I didn't really know what to expect walking in, but I think the word family is really what it is.

[00:37:49] It's about family. It's for families. It's with families. I'm so glad you mentioned the kiddos running around because them playing with toys around us and their laughter and their coloring. And it just, it really is work with kids for kids.

[00:38:04] And it's really beautiful. And it is possibly the most grassroots committee experience for sure that I've had, just hearing from the different committees and their ideas. And you really get a sense for how engaged the families are in the learning process.

[00:38:22] They want more out of it. They have great suggestions. They're not afraid to speak up. And, you know, Hannah, I'm just, I'm so grateful for your leadership. It's so evident that it has grown under you, even just coming in. And so I'm thankful to you too, Alexis, for all that you do and for the team.

[00:38:40] But it really is a really unique committee that we have. And I'm really just grateful to be a part of it. So thank you so much for all you do for our kids. I'm seeing no further questions.

[00:38:55] Thank you so much. Yeah. The next item on our agenda is our work session, item 4.01, the Department of Academic Strategic Planning Update. Tonight this will be presented by Dr. Ellis and Anna Singel and we have Dr. Blakelock. The floor is

[00:39:33] yours whenever you're ready. Okay good afternoon Chair Chandler and school board members. Today I am joined by Dr. Anna Singel, Supervisor of Strategic Planning and Continuous Improvement and Dr. Dave Blakelock, supervisor of research and this afternoon our goal is to provide you with an update on the strategic plan development progress since the last time we were with you in December our goals are specifically to share data and

[00:40:11] feedback we've received and to showcase how those data points will be taken into account when developing the priorities of our next strategic plan we will also seek your feedback on the draft revision I'm sorry draft revised vision mission and core values. And you have a document in front of you for that discussion at the end.

[00:40:30] And now I'll turn it over to Dr. Singel to share about the work that she's been leading over the past few months. Thank you, Dr. Ellis, and good afternoon. On this slide, you're looking at the progress for all four phases of the strategic plan development. We have closed out phase one, which is the input phase, and have started phase two, which is the development phase.

[00:40:51] We will share the results of phase one with you this afternoon, and we'll begin discussions around phase two, which is the revisions and the developments of the plan components. To ground the next phase of a strategic plan in a meaningful stakeholder insight, we launched a multi-layered engagement effort.

[00:41:09] A division-wide survey in November gathered broad input from all stakeholder groups. January focus groups added rich qualitative perspectives. We also received detailed feedback from LCPS departments and principles on current goals, implementation progress, and emerging priorities.

[00:41:25] In February, the strategic planning team brought this feedback together to shape proposed updates to the vision, mission, and core values for the board's review. We'll start our discussion with the results of the strategic plan survey. You'll first see the survey data originally presented in December, which we're bringing back today to help illustrate the overall landscape of the feedback that we have received.

[00:41:48] To supplement the slides, three detailed analyses are available in board docs, strategic plan survey results, strategic plan survey themes, and strategic plan survey visualizations. This slide highlights the key themes that emerged from the survey across all stakeholder groups.

[00:42:06] Respondents emphasized the importance of engaging classroom instruction that prepares students for both academic and real-world skills. They also underscored the need to support student wellness and a strong sense of belonging through positive learning environments. Staffing priorities centered on ensuring an excellent teacher in every classroom, supported by competitive compensation and strong recruitment, development, and retention practices.

[00:42:31] Safety and security surfaced as the top operational priority, and families consistently noted the importance of clear, effective communication between schools and home to support student success.

Before we dig into the survey themes, I will turn it over to Dr. Blayclough to remind us about how the net promoter score was used to create themes for promoters, passives, and detractors.

[00:42:54] Thank you, Dr. Singel. Just a quick overview of the net promoter score itself. It is used to measure the overall perception of the division and is based on a single survey question, which is, how likely are you to recommend this division to a friend or colleague? The answers range from 0 to 10, with 0 being not at all likely and 10 being extremely likely.

[00:43:14] The scores are broken into categories, with 0 to 6 being considered detractors, 7 to 8 being passives, and 9 to 10 being promoters. The score is calculated by subtracting the percentage of detractors from the percentage of promoters. These data represent the results from the Family Strategic Plan survey that was conducted in the fall.

[00:43:33] We added this question in the survey to provide the ability to disaggregate and compare the results based on stakeholders' overall perception of the division. We did this to make sure the voice of one group did not dilute the voice of others. You will see there are themes that are specific to each group, but also themes that are consistent across groups.

[00:43:52] I'll now turn it back to Dr. Singel to share the disaggregated themes. This slide summarizes what our promoters told us through the open-ended questions in the survey. Across all groups, we heard a clear desire for strong, high-quality core instruction.

[00:44:08] Promoters emphasized the focus on reading, writing, math, and science, along with practical, real-world learning, such as career pathways, trades, life skills, and financial literacy. While technology and AI are seen as important for future readiness, respondents stress the need for responsible and age-appropriate technology use.

[00:44:28] Student wellness emerged as another major priority. Promoters want schools where students feel safe, supported, and a true sense of belonging. This includes access to mental health resources, clear behavioral expectations, consistent discipline, and learning environments that are inclusive, respectful, and free from bullying or violence.

[00:44:46] We also heard strong support for investing in our people. Promoters consistently highlighted the importance of competitive compensation, meaningful professional development, and supportive leadership to attract and retain high-quality teachers and staff, particularly in hard-to-staff areas.

[00:45:03] Operationally, respondents emphasize modern, well-maintained facilities, equitable access to technology and resources across schools, and strong safety and security measures. They also value learning environments that prepare students for life beyond graduation. Finally, promoters reinforce that student success is strengthened through strong family and community partnerships.

[00:45:23] They want clear, consistent communication opportunities for meaningful engagement, and schools that serve as trusted hubs for their communities. When we look at the passive group, feedback reflected both shared priorities and differing perspectives. Respondents called for more engaging, relevant learning that prepares students for multiple pathways while also emphasizing foundational skills and appropriate use of technology.

[00:45:47] Student wellness emerged as a key concern with strong interest in mental health supports, inclusive school environments, consistent discipline, and student voice. Operational feedback focused on

safety, facilities, and transparency with a desire to direct resources more closely to schools and classrooms.

[00:46:04] Families emphasize stronger communication, meaningful engagement, and responsiveness to feedback alongside support for diverse communities. Finally, hiring and retention surface is critical with calls for competitive compensation, better working conditions, relevant professional learning, and recognition of staff.

[00:46:27] Across all groups, detractors voiced strong concern the school division has drifted away from its core academic mission. There was a consistent call to refocus on reading, writing, math, and science, and to reduce what many perceive as political or ideological influences in school. Respondents frequently raised concern about grading practices, instructional rigor, and a desire for more practical life skills, including financial literacy, career planning, and vocational pathways.

[00:46:52] Technology use was a particularly contentious issue. Many detractors expressed frustration with the extent of screen time, especially in elementary grades, and called for more hands-on instruction, traditional learning tools, and developmentally appropriate practices. Student wellness and safety were also prominent concerns.

[00:47:11] Respondents emphasized the need for stronger mental health supports, clearer behavioral expectations, and more consistent accountability for student conduct, safety issues, including bullying, harassment, and privacy. And with regard to staffing, detractors strongly emphasize the importance of competitive compensation and better working conditions to retain high-quality educators.

[00:47:33] Many noted that inadequate pay, insufficient support for managing student behavior, and administrative burdens contribute to burnout and turnover. There were also concerns about the quality of hiring, leadership effectiveness, and whether resources are being directed to classrooms rather than administrative overhead. Operationally, detractors expressed significant concern about fiscal management and decision-making. A recurring theme was the perception that the central office is disconnected from school-level realities with calls for greater transparency, accountability, and alignment of resources with academic excellence and student well-being.

[00:48:06] And finally, family and community engagement emerged as an area of deep frustration. Many respondents reported feeling unheard or excluded from decision-making and called for more transparent, responsive communication and a renewed focus on the needs and values of families.

[00:48:21] Next, I will share the key themes that emerged from our focus groups. These sessions were conducted in January and included participants from across the division, so students, families, teachers, administrators, and operational staff. Four broad areas were emphasized, student success, which is further broken down into academic performance and mental health, high-quality staff, operations and family, and community engagement.

[00:48:48] At the core, participants emphasized that student success depends on clear expectations and accountability, strong foundational instruction, and early intervention. Teachers and school leaders highlighted the importance of literacy, curriculum coherence, and consistent progress monitoring, particularly for English language learners and students with disabilities.

[00:49:07] There was also strong support for expanding alternative pathways including career and technical education to meet the diverse goals of students. When discussing work and life skills,

participants consistently pointed to skills students need to navigate an increasingly complex world.

[00:49:22] These include critical thinking, problem solving, communication, collaboration, and persistence. as well as executive functioning skills like organization, planning, and self-efficacy. Digital literacy emerged as essential with a strong emphasis on responsible AI use, digital citizenship, and the ability to evaluate information critically.

[00:49:44] Financial literacy was also identified as a key life skill. Mental health and social-emotional learning were viewed as foundational to academic success. Participants emphasized the need for consistent, division-wide STL approach, Implement it with fidelity, alongside early screening and intervention, access to counselors, psychologists, and behavior support staff was seen as critical, as was fostering a positive school climate where students feel safe, supported, in a sense of belonging, and where they trust their peers and adults.

[00:50:13] Supporting student success also requires a high-quality, well-supported staff. Participants emphasize appropriate staffing levels, manageable workloads, competitive compensations, and schedules that allow for planning time. Just as important were supportive leadership, positive work culture, and professional development that is relevant and practical.

[00:50:33] Participants also identified effective operations as a key inhibitor of success. They called for clearer and more streamlined communication, improved usability of technology use, consistent policy implementation, and thoughtful planning before launching new initiatives. Finally, strong family and community engagement was seen as essential.

[00:50:53] Participants emphasize timely, clear, and accessible communication across multiple channels. Opportunities for two-way feedback and school surveys as welcoming spaces for family and community members. We will now turn our attention to principal and central office department feedback.

[00:51:15] Principal feedback was gathered in March at a principal meeting. Principals were asked to review the goals in the current strategic plan and discuss them in their high school cluster. They were given prompts to engage in the discussion, start what might be missing from the current strategic plan, and continue what we want to hold on to and continue focusing on.

[00:51:36] As you can see on this slide, there are several crossovers between the previous feedback that I shared, but I want to point your attention to what was particularly different from the feedback that we received from principals. One of the most important points was the call out for instructional framework to make sure that the language in the new strategic plan aligns with the instructional framework and the work that has been done there.

[00:52:00] In addition to in the staffing column, we can see that one of the differences is the onboarding process, so ensuring that all staff members are onboarded appropriately and given the support as they begin their career in LCPS.

[00:52:17] Under the division column, ensuring that we continue with the life cycle planning that we have started in our previous plan. And then the similarities are pretty visible with the family engagement, communication, staffing models, so on and so forth.

[00:52:38] Similarities can be seen also under the department feedback. So I met with all of the different departments to gather feedback, particularly on the implementation component of the current strategic

plan. They also called out the instructional framework, but they focused a little bit more on the the five Cs and ensuring that our strategic plan embeds the five Cs under the student section, whatever they might look like, that we, under the staffing section, eliminate silos so there's more collaboration within and between departments, and that we continue with a culture of continuous improvement.

[00:53:14] We have started that mindset with our current strategic plan as it is currently one of our core values and also that we ensure that our decisions have feedback loops so when we engage our community in providing us with feedback through surveys that we share with the community how their feedback was implemented and how we take that into consideration now I want to share a brief overview of the strategic planning team's work over the past several months the team is intentionally broad and inclusive representing students teachers and principals from all levels department leaders school board representatives

[00:53:52] community and business partners, and members of the school board organizational committees. At our February 5th meeting, the strategic planning team began by grounding itself in the current strategic plan and the goals of the planning process. The group then analyzed stakeholder input on the vision, mission, and core values and worked together to refine each of these components.

[00:54:13] The meeting closed with a review of broader educational and social trends, both within K-12 and beyond. You will have an opportunity this afternoon to look at the recommendations for the revisions, and then provide us with additional feedback. The strategic planning team reconvened on March 18th for its second meeting.

[00:54:33] Team members were divided into groups to examine several key data sets that you can see on the slide. Using these insights, each group developed potential goals and strategies. The team will meet again in May and September, and we will continue to keep the group or the board updated with the group's progress.

[00:54:53] And so shifting our attention to the vision, mission, and core values, In September of 2025, we first saw your input on the current vision, mission, and core values. And then we combined your feedback with the other stakeholders' feedback and had the strategic planning team analyze all sources of feedback to revise the vision, mission, and core values.

[00:55:16] And as Dr. Ellis mentioned earlier, this afternoon we are seeking your thoughts on the revisions. I will briefly go over the draft revisions, but I do want to point your attention to the handout that has been provided to you with the two columns side by side so you can see the current strategic plan components and the proposed so a vision states who we aspire to be as an organization the strategic planning team recommends the following revision to the vision every student is inspired equipped and prepared for learning work in life and part of the revisions that were taken into or

[00:55:54] part of the feedback that was taken to the account is that our stakeholders felt like the current vision is a little bit disconnected from the realities of what happens in schools. And so it's shifting our attention to the mission. A mission describes what an organization does. The strategic planning team recommends preparing all students with the knowledge and skills to be life-ready and contribute meaningfully to their communities and beyond. The feedback that we received on the current mission is that there needs to be a little bit more meat to it. It's very lofty, but people can misunderstand what really the goal of the

[00:56:32] mission is based on the wording of it. And now I'll briefly go over the recommended revised core values. Just as a reminder, an organization's core value answers the following questions. What do we as LCPS stand for? Or what do we as an organization stand for? They are guiding principles that shape how an organization behaves, make decisions, and interacts with the people.

[00:56:56] The revised core values and the definitions are support and success. We ensure equitable access to resources and support so every student and staff member can thrive now and in the future. Belonging. Every student and staff member feels safe, supported, and deeply connected.

[00:57:15] Collaboration. We partner with students, staff, families, and the community to strengthen student success through shared voice, collaboration, and action. Students first. Every decision and action is driven by what most effectively advances student learning, well-being, and future readiness.

[00:57:33] Continuous improvement, we commit to growth and learning so that our actions support success for all. I just want to point your attention to that the intent of the current core values is not lost. The stakeholders recommended that we move some of them to our goals and strategies rather than being a core value.

[00:57:51] So, for example, rigor, teaching and learning. Some of those components still will most likely be included as part of our next strategic plan. They just felt like it wasn't a core value. It was more of a strategy or goal. And now I will turn it over to Dr. Ellis to guide the board's discussion. Thanks, Dr. Singel.

[00:58:08] So, Ms. Chandler, I think it might be helpful if before I facilitate a discussion about the vision, mission, and core values, we pause to see if you all have any questions about the content that Dr. Singel and Dr. Blakelock shared, and then we can shift to the activity. Does that work?

[00:58:24] Absolutely. Okay. Thank you all for the presentation. So I'll open the floor to questions. School board members, do you have any questions at this time? Sure. Go ahead, Ms. Chernoff. Thank you, Madam Chair, and thank you to the team. I just, I found, I find this work fascinating. I think we've established that, and again, I'm part of the focus, the group that's reviewing, so it's been really enlightening, but I just, I always want to kind of pull out, this was all going on when I was sort of really engaging with the school board before I was a school board member.

[00:58:57] the strategic plan that we're you know hinged to now and I remember these conversations at a larger level and there's just something about some of these themes that I'm seeing that I think might be important for the public to kind of understand or at least understand how I'm seeing it because I think when you talk about I'm gonna go to the promoter score when you start talking about things in terms of promoters passives and then detractors obviously we have people that love and support our division and all the things that we do. We have people that you know are maybe more middle ground and then we are always going to have people that are challenging some of the things that we

[00:59:35] do. These are really good perspectives. I think all three are valuable. I think all three are really important. I'm so glad to see all three of them shared here because what's really been interesting in the work behind the scenes is sort of and this is I might sound strange and it's a way I certainly didn't see it before, is the unity of the conversation that's coming from those three places, and what I mean by that is that when you really break these down, and you look at promoters are saying something we do well is core academic instruction, and then you look at, you know, passives are engaging, and they

[01:00:10] want, you know, kids to engage in relevant curriculum, and then the detractors want us to focus on core academics, to me those are all going in the same direction. That says the value system, and Dr. Spence has really guided us in this work, so I'm kind of, you know, stealing his thunder. He's not even here to do it tonight, but that framing of let's look at what the value is. The value is we all want our kids to have their needs met at school, and we want them to learn. That's a very simplified version of what we're talking about here, and I'm not trying to dumb it down, but I think if we can find that foundational common ground no matter which angle it's

[01:00:48] coming from I think we have a real chance at building something that is responsive to all three of those perspectives and those needs and something I'm starting to kind of reflect on and think about is how do we how do we learn from those different perspectives why they feel that way about those core academics or why they feel that way you're gonna hear it digital you know literacy and AI but also are we having too much screen time right like those themes are coming up and it's really about appropriateness for kids how do we get those different perspectives in the same room and say our foundational values are actually the

[01:01:24] same we believe the same thing and so for me that's really empowering in this work and so I think we're driving from a really exciting place and I actually think we're driving from a unifying place even though the perspective to get there is a little bit different so I really appreciate you bringing that today I know that that can feel a little vulnerable to put ourselves out there in terms of saying, you know, there's some people that really just have some challenges. And, you know, there's some people that maybe are disengaged. So to me, that's a real strength of where we're leading from. And I'm just very appreciative for you bringing that to the presentation.

[01:02:00] Thank you. Mr. Svensson. Thank you, Chair Chandler. I had a question. Dr. Single started answering. And I just wanted if you all could elaborate a bit further, because I was looking at the values and thinking about rigor and whether, you know, where that fit in among the values. And And I am curious to hear a little bit more about how it fits under strategy and whether you see that kind of falling under the existing value buckets that are in here, because it seems like that's a common theme from folks who are, you know, whether they're detractors or promoters, they're focused on the core academic instruction and bringing that rigor into the classroom, and maybe that looks different depending on the learning or career pathway

[01:02:38] that a student's in, but, you know, rigor across the board is important. So just curious if you all could elaborate on how that fits in as a strategy and how that goes upstream to the values and the mission and the vision. Thank you. That's an excellent question.

[01:02:53] So when we think about the current core values of rigorous teaching and learning, individual success and holistic support, all three of those components really fit well under our current instructional framework. And so when we think about the way the instructional framework is structured with the core areas as well as the focus areas, those show up in how a teacher designs instruction, how they deliver instruction, how they collaborate with their peers, and through professional learning, ensuring that they're really making sure, you know, students at all tiers receive the instruction that's appropriate for them.

[01:03:30] So our stakeholders have not necessarily named rigor as a strategy, but they have named instructional framework as a strategy, and so all of those components will show up through the

instructional framework. We are currently in that process of developing the verbiage for the goals and the strategies, so I can't really tell you what that will look like because I really want to make sure that the strategic planning team develops that.

[01:03:59] We did start some of this conversation at our last meeting in terms of what do we all want for our children and how can we make sure that we work towards meeting the goals of the division and so I can't really say what the wording will be but I know based just on the feedback that we have received that will show up in some in some form of fashion thank you Mr. Pepper thank you Madam Chair and thank you Dr. Single and Dr. Ellis and Dr. Blacklock for this presentation very helpful um I think that I was doing something very similar to Ms. Chernoff right I'm going through and trying to figure out what are the same among all these groups

[01:04:36] And the two that, of course, jumped out at me, first and foremost, was every one of them said age-appropriate technology is, right? And I think as a parent of kids who maybe get a little too much screen time, because daddy's very busy, but I think that that's something that, as a community, we can agree on.

[01:04:55] What I find very interesting, and the other one that jumped out at me, was the compensation. But what jumped out at me, and maybe this is because a little bit like Dr. Blakelock, I see your sticker. It says data nerd. I'm a little bit of a data nerd being a science teacher, as you can imagine. The way that the different groups kind of phrase what their things are, the underlying, it's very interesting.

[01:05:18] And the one that got me of all of them was compensation, whereas the promoters increase compensation, right? We love this. Our staff deserves more, right? And I think that many of us in this room who are educators believe that educators deserve more.

[01:05:35] The passive group was very much, we need competitive, right? It's not give them more. Let's bring everyone to the table to compete. And then what I find most interesting was in the detractors, it was teachers deserve more, right? They were singling out a specific group.

[01:05:52] They weren't singling out administrators, school support personnel, ESPs, bus drivers. It was very narrow focused. And, you know, for me, I would say I, of course, find myself in the promoter category, but it's because I haven't had something to, you know, complain about yet, right?

[01:06:14] When you have a detractor, there's always something that got them, right? The kid didn't get into the program they wanted or, you know, something happened they didn't feel like was handled in an appropriate way. And so they get on, people get on issues and I get it, I get it. So a lot of what I love is this idea that when we bring these groups together, they're learning from each other, right?

[01:06:35] Our promoters are learning from our detractors. Our detractors learn from our promoters about what makes things great. And I really just love this way that, you know, we are trying to find what we all want to make an excellent school system, right? And I really enjoy the high-level work.

[01:06:52] The other thing that I found super interesting, and I only really noticed this in the department survey, was they were the only ones who mentioned sustainability. And is there a thought on that, or is it just because they're facing every day?

[01:07:08] Because I didn't see that in our public focus groups. So in terms of, just to give a little bit of context of sustainability, that meant sustainability of programs, not recycling and implementing new

initiatives every year, but making sure that we are sustained initiatives to to implement them with fidelity and we know that whenever you implement something new it takes time but also there was a call-out for sustainable practices in some of the department meetings I think I have we analyzed feedback from 152 or 159 groups and part of that feedback

[01:07:47] was the support services team and their big focus is sustainability and so part of the thematic analyses pulls some of their responses. I know that we just as a board support adding a sustainability coordinator to the district and I'm hoping that you know as I see these proposed core values where that position fits into where we are going forward and thank you for that. Ms. Riccardi. Thank you madam chair and you guys thank you so much for this work it's always super fascinating to to read through this and read through the data you know as I kind

[01:08:25] of look at this kind of from a 50 or even a hundred thousand foot perspective big picture perspective I think one of the things that I find really interesting here is we don't number one we don't use the word education in anything on the right hand side of this column which is at the end of the day our core mission is providing the highest quality education we possibly can to our students and creating an exceptional work environment for our teachers and our and our staff we've we have and again I love everything that's on the you know the new stuff that you guys have created is really fantastic but sometimes I wonder in this process if we start getting too

[01:09:03] far away from what our pure core mission is which is to educate our kids and obviously and to prepare them for the future and the things that are on here but I worry that sometimes in here we you know and when in doing this process we kind of get away from that core piece the proposed core values are fantastic I think it it sets a really nice table for the culture that we want to have in our learning environments in our schools and our facilities but you know I'm not sure that there's there's not even there's not a core value in

[01:09:40] here I guess that really targets and I would love to see one that targets our expectations from a value perspective of our students in the learning process right we've we've got some I mean these are great and again I'm not knocking any of this I just these are just some of my observations you know doing this kind work and I would love to see us perhaps even have something in here that's really focused on kind of our value expectations of our staff and adults but then also of our students in that learning process and really engaging in that learning process I think we saw something around that in another document I'll have to see if I can pull it out but I would love to see a value

[01:10:18] in here at least one that's really focused on our expectations of of our students too so and even maybe in our families and engaging in the learning learning process so just some thoughts on that thanks any further questions at this time right dr. Ellis if you'd like to lead us through the activity please sure and I think miss Riccardi's comments are an excellent segue to that so I'm gonna go back to the vision and mission for a moment and again as dr.

[01:10:47] single mentioned you do have a crosswalk of the current strategic planning the current plans vision mission and core values and the proposed and now as board members as the team who will ultimately approve this strategic plan several months from now so these these words will change when you finally approve them I'm sure they will not be what you're what you're looking at right now but I first want you to think of if you read the vision and mission and student school board representatives please feel free to participate in this conversation

[01:11:23] um is there a word in the vision or mission that really stands out to you like what jumps off the page to you that maybe represents what what you think our students need today or need us to focus on today so we'll start with that question and I think I'm facilitating so just jump in okay I can

[01:11:59] go hi um I think the word inspired to me jumps out I think a lot of the times it's kind of repetitive and so just kind of reminding students that it's good to be inspired you should be inspired and Having someone in there who inspires them or multiple people or a class inspires them I think is something that jumped out to me. That would be really nice to see awesome. Thank you for sharing miss Harry Any other words that stand out? I'll hop in. I really like the use of the word learning You know, I don't think that

[01:12:39] Our job in how we prepare our students doesn't end when they walk across the stage. What we're really doing the entire time that they're here with us in LCPS is preparing them to continuously learn and to be lifelong learners.

[01:12:56] So that aspect of learning really stands out to me. All right, anybody else? Mr. Svensson. I mean, there are a couple that I really like.

[01:13:13] I'll focus on two. So I think the words equip and prepare and life ready, that kind of category, I think really speaks to the focus on alternative career pathways and learning pathways that clearly stood out from the survey results and that folks have been focused on.

[01:13:30] So I think this is something I really like seeing in the vision and mission. And I also really like the contribute meaningfully to their communities line. And it kind of brought up for me something I was thinking about in terms of the core values, building in something around citizenship or civic contribution and building that, instilling that in our students.

[01:13:56] And so I like that it appears in the mission vision. I was thinking about ways that we can incorporate that into the value section as well. Thank you. Mr. Pepper. Thank you, Madam Chair. I like that we included knowledge and skills.

[01:14:12] And as an educator, I've seen the transition well within the last probably 10, 15 years away from knowledge and towards skills. But there's this misconception that you can apply skills if you don't have background knowledge.

[01:14:28] And you need some background knowledge to understand how the skills apply. So I just love that both of those words are in there and it's not just skills because I've seen, and I know there's the argument about AI can do, or Google can do everything, but it's not the case. If you can't understand if basic information is true or false, or, you know, whether the research is credible or not credible. It really goes a long way. So I really like that both those words are in there. Okay, I'm going to throw out another question. So just focusing on the vision statement, when you imagine LCPS five to ten years from now,

[01:15:31] how well does this vision describe that future? And if it doesn't, why not? Can you ask that again? Of course. When you imagine LCPS five to ten years from now, how well does this vision describe that future? I'll hop in. And I don't necessarily mean to disparage what was done previously.

[01:15:53] But when it comes to the vision, the current vision, what I find the idea of full potential to be undefinable. just in general it's it's a tough concept how do we know how do you measure that right like how is it even possible to assess while a student is here and so I do find that the proposed vision is more

concrete and offers more you know it's a definable these are definable terms that are accessible and easy to

[01:16:28] understand thank you I'll piggyback off of that I agree I think that was something we kind of talked about is it felt sort of fluffy I think was one of the words we used I stand by that but I I think it fits I am struggling the one thing we've talked about this in our group a little bit the one thing I'm struggling with is how and you know what Miss Riccardo you kind of hit on this a little bit it's sort of like how it's what we're going to do for kids and not necessarily what they're going to do back the vision the mission definitely addresses

[01:17:04] those things with the contributing and you know to the communities. So I think it does match, I think it's open-ended enough that it will match. I like that equipped can mean a lot of things based on the environment that you're in and so I like that that word is adaptable in that way. Preparing for learning work and life I think are always hopefully going to always be things that we value as a society. So I think it fits. I'm looking for a little bit more of that like authenticity piece of like how we do that in an authentic way that makes it meaningful but I think that that may also come from the strategies and goals piece because I

[01:17:42] think that's more than nuts and bolts and so it may just be my desire for details that makes it feel a little bit high level but I do agree I think we're in a much better direction getting away from something that was more feely to more we're gonna do this so I think it fits for five to ten years thanks anyone else before I move on to the mission? Okay, so looking at the mission statement, how clearly do

[01:18:13] you think this mission communicates why LCPS exists and who we serve?

[01:18:30] So first and foremost, it's the second word. It's the second word in the mission, all. All students, right? We serve all students. We are a public school. Whoever comes through our door, it is our job to prepare them with the knowledge and skills that they need to be successful in the future. And I love this idea of, you know, contributing meaningfully to their communities and beyond, right? What that

[01:19:08] contribution looks like for every student is unique. What that contribution looks like for every student is different, right? We are here, though, to truly educate. And like I said, it's all about that all, right? We are here to make sure that when you walk through the doors, whether you're here for one week, whether you're here for all 13 years of educational career, right?

[01:19:30] And LCPS is giving you something that is a tool to use in your future. And so I really think this, and like I said, it's that knowledge and those skills, I really like this proposed mission statement. Thank you.

[01:19:48] Any other thoughts about the mission statement? Ms. Chandler? Thanks. I would say I really love what Mr. Pepper is saying about all and totally agree.

[01:20:06] this, in comparison, I guess, to the vision, I still feel a little hesitancy about the idea of being life ready. And I'm not sure, I think there's probably just, there's something about that phrase that's just not quite there for me. I'm not, but I guess, and that may be something that I saw in the session reflected similarly as well, but that would be something that I would want to see some continuous improvement on. Thank you. All right, so now we're going to shift.

[01:20:45] Oh, I'm sorry, Ms. LaBelle. There you go. Thank you. I was kind of listening to what Ms. Chandler was saying, and I, you know, I'm a wordsmith. I can't help myself. I have respect for the revised vision I think it's good it's fine it gives the meaning that we need but again I say that the mission statement needs to be more of an action statement

[01:21:25] right now it's just almost like fluffy to use Ms. Chernoff's word if it were revised to say to prepare again the action is to prepare prepare is an action word all students with the knowledge and life skills to be ready to contribute again the action word meaningfully to their communities and I

[01:22:02] have a real hard time with the word beyond it reminds me of to infinity and beyond so if that could to their communities and the world might be a better way to say it but again like I said it's not the ideas it's it needs to be an action for a mission statement as opposed to just here's a plate yeah sorry awesome thank you that's really helpful and that your reference to Buzz Lightyear came up in the strategic planning team committee

[01:22:41] so we will certainly address that word beyond and I think fluffy is a perfectly lovely adjective to describe some of these things. Okay, we are going to, in the time remaining, spend just a few minutes on the proposed core values. So one question I have before I get to the question on the slide is thinking back to what Dr. Singel shared. In the survey data, there were lots of, there were, there was a theme about work and life skills, right? So all families, whether they were promoters or passives or detractors focused on providing their students, you know, with the best possible

[01:23:18] education for work and life skills. Do you think, and you can pick one, is there one revised core value that you think will resonate most deeply with those parents who may have emphasized work and life skills? Something I thought I'd throw in here too is I think the word that we're missing in some in at least the values piece of this is accountability we don't we need our students to be accountable to the learning process we need our teachers to be accountable to providing the best academic experience and life skills

[01:23:56] experience to our students I think there needs to be something in here about accountability I think if you think about the detractors and the promoters and as somebody that wants to help prepare you know and works with young adults in the work environment accountability is probably one of the biggest missing things that we have in general so I think we I think as a value we should really be looking at something around around that too and I think that kind of addresses I think some of the issues between those detractors and the and the promoters. Thank you. Ms. Chernoff? Yeah I'm gonna agree I don't think we've

[01:24:32] hit on necessarily that through this through the core values yet. I think we're and then I'm gonna jump ahead I know you're gonna ask another question I think we're a lot closer and I'm wondering if we don't need to reinvent the wheel with the student actions on The instructional framework the words and the act are so specific and so strong like students contribute students recognize Students communicate their learning students identify and explain connections students use academic language Students make meaningful learning choices like we've got a lot of that like nuts and bolts in the instructional framework and I find that missing in the core values.

[01:25:11] I also think we're missing the word high expectations. I think when we talk about support and success, I think a lot of people go to that idea of like people that may need support to catch up. I mean, at least I do, but it's like maybe by establishing or maintaining high expectations, kids have access to the resources and supports that they need.

[01:25:31] I don't know. I just feel like we're, this instructional framework is so strong, and we've talked about it so much. I think that a lot of what we're expecting with that accountability with students is already beautifully outlined here. Teachers are using it. So I think we're close-ish in terms of if you put them all together to getting the things that align with the instructional framework.

[01:25:53] But I think we have a lot stronger language that addresses those specifics in those actions. That's helpful. Thank you. Ms. LaBelle? I've just been thinking, talking about accountability and something that Ms. Chernoff and Ms. Riccardi had said a little while ago.

[01:26:14] Is there any place where we have that the students are also accountable for their own learning and studies? We need to have that reference. It's not just us giving out, as we had said. They have to give to themselves as well.

[01:26:32] They have to take responsibility for some of their learning, and it needs to be in there. somewhere okay thank you for that I'm thinking about your comments and reflecting on how we have those themes reflected in in the strategic plan that that's built for really for the the board and staff to lead the division forward so how do we name that in the strategic plan recognizing that recognizing who and what is driving the plan if that makes sense so that's really helpful feedback for us to to consider okay so I think we have time for just

[01:27:10] one more open-ended question about these core values are there core values in this proposed list that that you can see showing up in daily decisions teachers make and leaders make classrooms and leadership practices do any stand out to you as yes this is what we want our staff to do to work toward our proposed

[01:27:35] mission. Ms. Riccardi? Yeah, I like the student's first one. I think that was the one that probably resonated with me right away around that. And I'll just kind of say just as another thing, you know, when we're looking at that, I would love to see something a little bit more aspirational. I like the, like some of these are tactical, but I want something really aspirational.

[01:27:58] I want LCPS to be the top public school division in the Commonwealth of Virginia. I want us to be, you know, the very best in, you know, student performance, whatever that is. I think I want something that's more like yes I can get behind that and that's really exciting and it can really create that excitement for everybody that works with LCPS so I would love to see something folded in there there's also obviously measurable too but I think we need some aspirational statement in

[01:28:30] here somewhere okay thank you any other thoughts I'll add a thought here on I really like the belonging core value and I was thinking through and I think that's something that staff could use every day in the sense of you know how are they building belonging in in their classroom and I also am thinking through how that's reflected in the vision and obviously as mission offset equip and prepare kind of broad words it can kind of encompass things like belonging and I

[01:29:06] you know I don't want our vision or mission to get too fluffy but think but thinking about but thinking about how we make sure that because because the sense of belonging and support is really important to ultimate success you know in life after school so just thinking about how we connect that core that core value we do have that I like a lot and make sure that's we feel that's reflected in the vision and it may be already but yeah great thank you all right I think we are right up to our time just really

appreciative of your thoughts and feedback so this work will continue behind the scenes and in the strategic planning team and we

[01:29:45] will be back in a few months with an update for you. All right. Thank you, Dr. Ellis, Dr. Single, Dr. Blanklock for the presentation and for moderating the, oh, did you want to say one more thing? We did want to float one more idea out there. I'll be really quick, 30 seconds. So based on all of these conversations, what we have heard is that we are, all of our stakeholders across across the board including this conversation today it is clear that our core mission really must be to ensure that every student is truly life ready for whatever their life may bring them

[01:30:23] in the future it's also super clear to us that strong schools and strong communities especially in an amazing place like Loudon are inseparable right our schools and communities have to work together our collective success really hinges on that so we are floating a theme for our new strategic plan nothing's in writing yet so you won't see it in a slide but we are floating the theme of life ready community strong so just sleep on that back to you Miss Chandler right I'm gonna have to adjust all right well as we're approaching six o'clock we will recess this

[01:31:02] meeting for dinner and reconvene at 6:30 the board is now in recess the board is coming out

[02:02:42] of recess at this time we will move on to item number seven our Pledge of Allegiance and National Anthem the Seneca Ridge Middle School select chorus is a small but mighty group of seventh and eighth grade students who perform at events in our community these singers rehearse after school each week and enjoy additional performance opportunities outside of their chorus concert schedule they are under the direction of Liz Shoemaker the Seneca Ridge Chorus Director. Thank you for being here. And we are so excited that you're here with us

[02:03:15] tonight. Please stand for the Pledge of Allegiance.

[02:05:06] Thank you so much. That was absolutely incredible. We'll now move on to our recognitions. We'll start tonight with item 8.01, the 1LCPS Spotlight Department of School Leadership, Parkview High School, nationally recognized for academic achievement. Presented tonight by Ms. Rae Mitchell.

[02:05:45] Chair Chandler and members of the board. It is my pleasure to recognize Parkview High School for earning national distinction as a 2025 National ESEA Distinguished School, an honor that reflects both excellence and impact.

[02:06:04] Parkview is one of two schools in Virginia, and only 63 schools across the country, selected by the National Association of ESEA State Program Administrators for this recognition.

[02:06:20] Since its establishment in 1996, this program has highlighted schools that demonstrate exceptional progress through the effective use of federal resources, and Parkview stands among the very best.

[02:06:36] This year, Parkview was recognized in Category 2, closing the achievement gap between student groups, a testament to the school's commitment to equity and student success. Over the past two years, Parkview has achieved remarkable academic growth, particularly in mathematics.

[02:06:57] We've seen dramatic gains across multiple student groups, including a 46-point increase for unhoused students, a 45-point increase for English learners, a 44-point increase for Black students, a 36-point increase for economically disadvantaged students, and a 32-point increase for Hispanic students.

[02:07:22] Similar progress has been made in reading and science, with meaningful improvements for students with disabilities, English learners, and other student groups. These results did not happen by chance. They are the product of intentional student-centered practices, targeted instruction, expanded learning opportunities, co-taught classrooms, small group support, peer tutoring, and before and after school academic programs.

[02:07:52] Just as important, teachers work collaboratively to analyze data, refine instruction, and ensure every student's needs were met, which was supported by ongoing professional learning. This is also a school where relationships matter, where students feel seen, supported, and capable.

[02:08:12] That commitment is reflected in family feedback, with agreement that teachers care about how my child does in school, rising from 85.5% to an outstanding 96.4% in just one year.

[02:08:29] Tonight, we have a video that is a window into just some of the great work of Parkview High School. Jason Jefferson, and I'm the proud principal of Parkview High School, located in Sterling, Virginia.

[02:08:46] It is my honor to share that Parkview High School has been named a 2025 National ESEA Distinguished School. We are especially proud to represent the Commonwealth of Virginia in Category 2, closing the achievement gap between student groups. At Parkview, our mission is simple but powerful, to empower every student to reach their fullest potential in a safe, inclusive, and nurturing learning environment.

[02:09:11] we are deeply committed to academic excellence character development and cultural appreciation preparing our students not only for graduation but for life as responsible global citizens parkview serves a vibrant and diverse community and more than 70 percent of our students identify as english language learners or multilingual students we proudly serve newcomer students and families representing more than 40 countries our story of success is rooted in intentional, student-centered work over the past several years.

[02:09:46] We expanded professional learning and cultural responsive teaching, literacy across content areas, and strategies that best support multilingual learners. Through strategic use of ESEA funds, we extended learning time, expanded tutoring, strengthened family engagement, and increased access to critical academic supports.

[02:10:07] This recognition belongs to our extraordinary teachers, support staff, families, and community partners. To other schools on this journey, I encourage you to focus on relationships, clarity, and collaboration. When students feel seen and educators work together with purpose, transformation is possible.

[02:10:26] On behalf of the entire Parkview High School community, thank you for honoring our school and our students. We are proud to represent Virginia and to share our story of success. Tonight we celebrate not only this national recognition, but the students, staff, and families who made it possible.

[02:10:54] At this time, I invite Principal Dr. Jason Jefferson to come forward so that we may congratulate him on this outstanding achievement. We're going to invite Dr. Bergen, who is standing in for Dr. Spence and board members, to come take a picture with Dr. Jefferson.

[02:11:22] Thank you.

[02:12:44] Thank you so much for that presentation. We'll move on now to item 8.02, the Department of Communications and Community Engagement School Business Partnership 2026, Virginia School Board Association Honor Roll. Tonight, this item will be presented by Ms. Renee Dawson and Ms. Mitchell.

[02:13:06] Evening, Dr. Bergen, Chair Chandler, school board members, and the Loudoun community. I am Susan Mitchell, the CEO of Athari Biosciences, and I'm honored to serve as chair of the School Business Partnership Council. The LCPS School Business Partnership Executive Council was established by the school board action in 1990. For over 20 years, its primary mission has been to strengthen connections between businesses, industries, and the school division while connecting between businesses, industries, and recognizing business partners who are dedicated

[02:13:44] to shaping Loudoun's future through their support of today's classrooms. Through initiatives such as Job for a Day, which provides students with real-world career experiences, the School Business Partnership Awards Breakfast, which is coming up, and I hope you all have your tickets, which celebrates outstanding business contributions, our schools, the Executive Council fosters meaningful engagement between education and industry.

[02:14:13] Since the launch of the Virginia School Board Association, better known as VSBA, business honor roll, the executive council has proudly nominated businesses that go above and beyond to support the division's mission, earning them statewide recognition as valued education partners.

[02:14:33] Here you'll see that the Virginia School Board Association business honor roll helps divisions say thank you to businesses for their vital contributions. VSBA business honor roll is a way for local school divisions to recognize local businesses for their support.

[02:14:51] Businesses, large and small, corporate-owned or family-run, play a key role in supporting our communities and local schools. They contribute to our school divisions in many ways, including helping schools with in-kind or financial contributions, donating to scholarship programs, supporting extracurricular activities, offering internships, volunteering in the schools, sponsoring field trips. This type of support is invaluable. The SBP Executive Council Nomination Committee reviewed submissions either this year, earlier this year, my apologies, for schools

[02:15:29] selected in these three business and community partners to be the 2025-2026 school year nominees. This evening, I'll be sharing the nominees with their corresponding educational partners. We will present each a plaque and have a chance for a picture with the board in front of the desk in the school board so first we will talk about Luck Stone and at the end of the presentation I will have each of them come up to the front and take the photos so Luck Stone has provided meaningful and generous support to all the elementary school and many other elementary

[02:16:05] schools across Loudoun County public schools with a focus on academic enrichment community engagement and workforce development in addition to their support in schools Luck Stone also participates in the division's Job for a Day program, welcoming students to learn firsthand about careers in their industry and the important role they play in our community. In support of student learning, Luck Stone is sponsoring and organizing an in-all school field trip to all the elementary students this spring, carefully aligned with the science standards of learning, SOLs, for every grade level

[02:16:42] from kindergarten through fifth grade. This experience ensures that students have equitable access to high-quality, real-world learning opportunity that connects classroom instruction with hands-on

exploration. Luckstone has also partnered with the schools to explore and support the development of an outdoor learning space, helping expand opportunities for students to engage with science and nature in meaningful ways.

[02:17:10] Beyond academics, Luckstone has played an important role in strengthening school culture and supporting the Aldi Elementary community. Through their participation in school events, support of fundraising efforts, and ongoing appreciation for educators and staff at Aldi, and a host of other elementary schools, Luckstone demonstrates a genuine commitment to well-being of the entire school community.

[02:17:37] Their engagement reflects a partnership that extends beyond the classroom and contributes to a positive and connected school environment. Their dedication to academic enrichment, community engagement, and workforce development makes Luckstone a deserving recipient, recognizing their outstanding contributions to student learning and educational excellence.

[02:18:03] Next up, we have Ashby Ponds, is a valued and longstanding partner of the Loudoun County Public Schools and the Community and Schools Together program, also known as CAST. This partnership represents a community-centered initiative that provides meaningful workforce development and transition opportunities for Loudoun County Public Schools students.

[02:18:26] Through this collaboration, Ashby Ponds hosts student internships across several functional areas of its community, including housekeeping, culinary services, clerical services, and fitness and wellness. These experiences allow students to participate in hands-on learning that builds confidence, independence, and career readiness.

[02:18:47] Students also develop important social skills and gain a strong sense of belonging while working alongside professionals in a supportive environment. The partnership is dedicated to creating meaningful workplace workforce pathways that have direct and lasting impact on students and post-secondary outcomes.

[02:19:06] Their dedication to academic enrichment, community engagement, and workforce development makes Ashby Ponds a deserving recipient of the Virginia School Boards Association Business Honor Roll, recognizing their outstanding contributions to student learning and educational excellence.

[02:19:25] Here we have Lone Stone Farm, and they have developed a strong and meaningful partnership with Lovitzville Elementary School and various other schools in the western Loudoun area, supporting both the school's instructional goals and the broader efforts of the school community.

[02:19:46] Through their partnership with the school's parent-teacher organization, Lone Stone Farm has played an important role in strengthening community engagement and supporting school fundraising efforts. By contributing resources, hosting opportunities, and helping create meaningful experiences for families, the farm has helped support important school initiatives while the broader school community, bringing the broader school together.

[02:20:13] Longstone Farm has also supported school-wide initiatives that encourage student participation and excitement around learning, including sponsorship for the school's read-a-thon fundraiser for two consecutive years, helping create memorable moments that engage students and families alike.

[02:20:31] Beyond these events, Longstone Farm has actively supported the school's educational mission. The farm participated in Career Day, bringing a piece of the farm directly to students and sharing insights about agriculture and animal care.

[02:20:47] Their work with students has also supported instruction in sustainable agriculture, environmental stewardship directly connecting to and strengthening the school's green team composting program their dedication to academic enrichment community engagement and workforce development makes Longstone Farm a deserving recipient of the Virginia School Boards Association business honor roll recognizing their outstanding contributions to student learning and educational excellence so as we bring this presentation to a close we want to

[02:21:23] take a moment to reflect on the true power of partnership. The work of LCPS, School Business Partnership Executive Council, is not just about programs of recognition. It's about shared community, commitment, and investing to the future of our students, our schools, and our community.

[02:21:41] To our 2026 VSBA Business Honor Roll nominees, Ashby Ponds, Luckstone, and Longstone Farm, your dedication to education is more than just support. It's a testament to what happens when businesses and schools come together with a common purpose.

[02:21:58] You're not only shaping today's classrooms, but you're also inspiring the leaders, innovators, and changemakers of tomorrow. Thank you for your unwavering commitment to Loudoun students, for your belief in the power of education, for standing with us in important work.

[02:22:14] Together, we are not just building partnerships. We are building a legacy of opportunity, excellence, and hope. Thank you all for your time this evening, and this concludes our presentation. So we're going to have Ashby Ponds come up first for your pictures with the board.

[02:26:14] I'll just say to all of our honorees tonight, thank you so much for everything that you do to support our schools and our students. Your work really means the world. And with that, we are delighted to welcome two student school board representatives tonight.

[02:26:30] First up, we have Solene Harry from Tuscarora High School. Solene Harry is a senior at Tuscarora High School. She loves spending time with friends and being outdoors. Solene has been a member of the varsity track team all four years of high school, and she plans to study broadcast journalism after high school.

[02:26:49] Welcome, Solene, the floor is yours. Thank you, Madam Chair, and good evening. My name is Solene Harry, and I'm honored to represent Tuscarora High School tonight. I'd like to start off by recognizing my principal, Mr. Bonner. For many people, change can be difficult, especially in a school community, and that's something I understand personally.

[02:27:09] When I transferred to Tuscarora my freshman year, I had to learn how to adjust and deal with change myself. Because of that, I can really appreciate the kind of environment Mr. Bonner has helped create. Since joining Tuscarora, he has made it a more welcoming and inclusive place where students feel supported.

[02:27:24] Every morning, Mr. Bonner announces to the school, we are glad you're here, you belong here, and we're going to have an incredible day together, which has now become a new normal since he's been

here. His presence at both academic and athletic events shows how involved and committed he is, and that's something students genuinely notice and appreciate.

[02:27:43] Personally, his leadership has inspired me to become more involved in my school community. Through my involvement in student council, Pierre, being a leader of Tuskegee Terror, competing for four years on the varsity track team, I've been able to step outside my comfort zone and take on new opportunities, which has made my high school experience even more meaningful.

[02:28:02] This year, Tusker continues to show excellence across academics, fine arts, athletics, and student involvement, and I'm excited to share a few highlights. Our fine arts program has had an especially strong year. Our theater program earned both district and state championships and will be competing at an international festival this summer, while our orchestra program earned superior ratings and regional recognition.

[02:28:25] We've also continued to grow our inclusive programs like Unified PE and Unified Theater, which help create a more connected and supportive school environment. In my high school career, our band has expanded from 15 to 55 students, and they are two-time VMBC state champions.

[02:28:43] Academically, our academic team won regional championships for the first time in school history, which is a huge accomplishment. In visual arts, students created over 60 pieces that are now displayed in a gallery wall in our school. Programs like AVID continue to make a big impact as well.

[02:28:59] As the only AVID program in the county, it helps prepare students for college and future success. This year, student years have already earned over 40 college acceptances and approximately \$1.5 million in scholarships. In addition, our peer program has helped build connections beyond our own school.

[02:29:18] Students work closely with Sparta Middle School to create a positive and welcoming environment for younger students, helping ease the transition to high school and strengthen our community. Our athletic programs have also had an outstanding year. Our softball team became region and state champions, led by Player of the Year, Chloe Wolves and Coach of the Year Bridget Kemp. In track and field, Sebastian Pla earned state titles in both triple and long jump, setting a new state meet record, while Catherine Mosher placed fourth at the state cross-country meet and continued to excel across seasons. We also saw strong performances across many programs, including a regional runner-up finish in the girls' swim and a school record in the 400-meter relay. Altogether, our athletes earned numerous

[02:29:57] district, regional, and state honors, reflecting their dedication and pride representing Tuscarora. I'd also like to recognize our teachers and staff, especially my student council advisor, Ms. Crawford, whose support and commitment has made all of these accomplishments possible to play a huge role in creating such a positive and supportive environment for students.

[02:30:17] As an older sister with siblings who will one day attend Tuscarora High School, I'm excited for future generations to experience all of the opportunities that this school has to offer with support, with such strong leadership. If I could, I would go back and do it all over again. Tuscaro's success comes from the strength of our community.

[02:30:35] I'm proud to be a part of a school that values hard work, involvement, and supporting one another. Thank you for your time, and have a great evening. Thank you so much for your comments.

[02:30:51] And next up, we have Jitsu Marupudi, who is a senior at Thomas Jefferson High School of Science and Technology. Throughout his time at TJ, Jitsu has developed many ways to give back to the school and the community. He is currently the treasurer for underwater robotics, chapter founder of Teens with Heart Songs, and a consistent member in the Model UN.

[02:31:14] He also gives back to his local community by coaching flag football for kids and tutoring some of his neighbors. Outside of school, he enjoys watching football and playing basketball. In the future, he aims to pursue a career as a physician researcher and hopes to make a change in health care policy.

[02:31:32] Jitsu looks forward to making a positive impact on his peers and contribute to the school board. Welcome. The floor is yours. Thank you so much. Good evening. My name is Jitsu Marputi, and I'm a senior at Thomas Jefferson High School for Science and Technology. First, I would like to thank the school board for the opportunity to speak today, as well as TJ's principal, Mr. Mukai, and my assistant principal, Ms. Crane.

[02:31:54] As the 2025-2026 school year comes to a close, I want to take a moment to reflect not just on what TJ's students have accomplished, but on the environment that makes these accomplishments possible. Just this past weekend, TJ hosted TechOne, our student-run Model United Nations Conference, the largest of its kind on the East Coast.

[02:32:11] Students from across the region came together to debate global issues and collaborate on solutions. What stands out is not just the scale of the event, but the fact that it's entirely organized and led by students. Despite the competition only lasting two days, over 200-plus students are involved in making it possible through the support of staff and administration.

[02:32:31] That same culture is evident in HackTJ, one of the largest high school hackathons in the world. What makes HackTJ impactful is the level of external support it receives, including sponsorships from organizations such as Jane Street, a leading quantitative trading firm, along with other companies that help provide mentorship and resources.

[02:32:51] Winners of individual categories win a range of prizes, such as a year's worth of Chipotle, Nintendo Switches, and MacBooks. Despite the surplus of competitions taking place, students have many opportunities to demonstrate their own interests and backgrounds. One of the clearest examples of this is I-Night, or International Night, where students share their cultures through performances, food, and traditions.

[02:33:14] It is more than just a celebration. It is a reminder that the strength of our school comes from the different perspectives that students bring with them. This balance between innovation and community continues in TJ's senior research program. Seniors come up with a years long of a research project in one of TJ's nine senior research labs, where they spend the entire year planning, researching, and developing their projects.

[02:33:36] Through these projects, students implement all of their knowledge from their research into a final presentation at TJ's very own research symposium. Also, every Wednesday and Friday, students are able to participate in TJ's vast eighth period system. In this time, students can participate in the offerings of 130 clubs, all supported by a student-run intranet, ION.

[02:33:58] Through this time, students are given the flexibility to explore their interests, whether that be learning about financial literacy at Investment Club or going outdoors to sit in the sun. The uniqueness of

this program gives the students the ability to take ownership of their experience, letting them explore what they truly want.

[02:34:14] Not only in school, students are also exploring their interests outside of school. This year, we had nine students named Regeneron Top 300 Scholars, with one advancing to finalist status. We had 113 seniors named National Merit Semi-Finalists, our chess team winning a state title, multiple sports teams being named district champions, and plenty of students winning awards in their own respective fields.

[02:34:36] But more important than any single achievement is what they represent. TJ gives the ability for many students to follow their passion, initiate leadership, and grow, not just as a student, but as a person as well. Even though I feel like freshman year was only yesterday, I'm grateful to have been part of a community that not only challenges students to succeed, but also supports them in discovering who they want to become.

[02:34:56] I would like to thank LCPS for allowing students from the county to attend TJ and allowing students to pursue their passion of STEM. Thank you for your time and your continued support of TJ. Thank you. Thank you both so much for providing your updates. It's always such a delight to hear what's happening with our students and our schools.

[02:35:19] And it was very meaningful to hear of your experiences, so thank you. With that, we will now move on to our superintendent's report, which will be presented tonight by our Chief of Staff, Dr. Bergen, serving as Dr. Spence's designee. Thank you, Madam Chair.

[02:35:39] To begin, Ashley Sinclair has been named the next principal of William Obadiah Robey High School. Most recently, Mr. Sinclair served as the principal of Alexandria City High School, and he previously held roles as director of developing teacher support and assistant principal at the District of Columbia International School.

[02:36:13] Mr. Sinclair began his career in New York City Public Schools, first as an English teacher, and later as an assistant principal at John Dewey High School in Brooklyn. We are pleased to welcome Mr. Sinclair to LCPS. He will begin his new role on July 1. Congratulations, Mr. Sinclair.

[02:36:37] More than 300 LCPS high school students participated in the 44th annual regional science and engineering fair held on March 11 and 12 at Tuscarora High School. These students presented original research projects that were evaluated by community judges who provided valuable feedback and support.

[02:36:57] Of the participating students, eight were selected as student finalists to compete in the Regeneron International Science and Engineering Fair in Phoenix in May. In addition to the finalists, Abdullah Abu-Jadeh, a 12th grader at Potomac Falls High School, received the annual Willowcroft Science Scholarship.

[02:37:22] Willowcroft Farm Vineyards also recognized Mario Savendra, a science teacher at Potomac Falls High School with a matching scholarship for his work with students in science. Congratulations to all of our participating students, and thank you to all of our educators, judges, sponsors who made the experience possible. We would also like to recognize the incredible students who competed in this year's Loudoun County Regional Spelling Bee, which was held on Thursday, March 12 at Rockridge High School. Congratulations to Vikyath Tanamala from Belmont

[02:38:00] Ridge Middle School, our 2026 Spelling Bee Champion, who secured the top spot by correctly spelling peccant, meaning guilty of moral offense. We also applaud runner-up Dia Sudaka, a sixth grader from Gumspring Middle School, for an outstanding final round. Both students will now advance to the Scripps National Spelling Bee, which will take place in late May at the DAR Constitution Hall in Washington, D.C. Congratulations again to all of our students who participated in

[02:38:38] this event. More than 600 students from 24 high schools representing multiple Virginia school divisions converged at George Mason University on the 10th of March for Cyber Slam 2026, a high-energy, hands-on cybersecurity experience designed to prepare students for the rapidly evolving digital landscape. Hosted by Loudoun County Public Schools in partnership with George Mason University. Cyberslam has grown into one of the region's premier student cybersecurity events.

[02:39:14] Students traveled from across the Commonwealth, including Fairfax County, Newport News, and Sponsylvania to immerse themselves in real-world simulations, advanced technologies, and direct engagement with industry leaders. Heritage High School recently encountered living history when Holocaust survivor Frank Cohn, who turned 100 years old in August 2025, visited the school to share his life story. Mr. Cohn shared about his childhood experiences

[02:39:51] under Nazi rule, his family's escape from Europe, his service in the U.S. Army during World War II, and hearing these firsthand stories helped students to connect classroom learning to real human experiences and deepen their understanding of history and its impacts. Many thanks to the teachers and staff who made this event possible and for bringing history to life for our LCPS students. LCPS families and staff came together for the annual Better Together Community Dinner

[02:40:27] hosted by the Minority Student Achievement Advisory Committee and the Division of Diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility. The event was held on Wednesday, March 18, to celebrate community, culture, and connection. Families brought dishes to share, creating a vibrant communal meal that highlighted the diversity of LCPS. Students showcased their talents through artwork and cultural performances, and the night wrapped up with a lively dance party, leaving everyone with full plates, full hearts, and a renewed sense of togetherness.

[02:41:09] And finally this evening, we would like to congratulate Sue Carlson, a transportation supervisor, on being named this month's Shine Award winner. Sue was nominated by one of her LCPS colleagues for her unwavering dedication to our students, including her commitment to ensuring transportation is not only provided but also thoughtfully scheduled and fully individualized to meet each student's needs. As a SHINE Award recipient, Ms. Carlson received a gift coordinated by the Loudoun Education Foundation and sponsored by

[02:41:45] Atlantic Union Bank. SHINE, which stands for Spotlighting Heroes in Education, is a joint LEF and LCPS initiative that celebrates staff who go above and beyond for students and the community. Madam Chair, that concludes the superintendent's report. Thank you, Dr. Bergen.

[02:42:06] That brings us to item number 11, our public comment. Here are the procedures for public comment. Thank you for engaging with the school board through the public comment process. The school board welcomes comments from Loudoun County residents and believes that strong community engagement and outreach are important components of a successful school system speakers must limit comments to the time allotted based on the number of speakers and the agenda this evening all speakers

have been allotted one minute each for public comment please be advised that speakers who miss their time slot will not be called at a later time decorum and civility all audience members

[02:42:44] shall maintain civility decorum and respect for the functioning and dignity of the school board at all times please remain seated unless arriving departing speaking at the podium or during a break violations of civility decorum and respect include shouting heckling jeering applause and other noise which disrupts or delays the meeting obstructing speakers from being able to see the school board and vice versa interrupting speakers attempting to speak when not called to do so by the chair and approaching a speaker or otherwise attempting to intimidate,

[02:43:19] disparage, or distract a speaker, staff member, or other meeting attendee. Speakers should refrain from vulgarity, obscenities, defamation, profanity, and other like breaches of respect, nor may speakers target, criticize, or attack individual students and/or individual division employees during public comment.

[02:43:38] As a reminder, School Board Policy 2520 states, speakers may not target, criticize, or attack individual students during public comment. Speakers should communicate those concerns to their school principal or an appropriate school official. The school board requests that comments on an individual student or employee related matter not be shared at public meetings where the disclosure could violate applicable confidentiality requirements. I do want to take a moment to clarify a few things. As has been explained previously, speakers can personally identify a student or employee without stating a student's or an

[02:44:14] employee's names. That is, personally identifiable information is any information that a reasonable person can link together to pinpoint an individual student or employee, and where that individual student or employee is known to others in their school and surrounding community based on the context that is shared. The school board welcomes you to share your concerns, but as to the extent you have prepared remarks that target criticize or attack any individual students or employees you generalize such remarks to ensure compliance with board policy for example comments that target criticize or attack a student or

[02:44:52] an employee or a student or an employee from a specific named school or a student or an employee with any characteristics where the information would personally identify that student or employee to others in the school or broader LCPS community would violate school board policy. However, comments that discuss general concerns with students or employees at schools and do not target, criticize, or attack an individual, identifiable student or employee are permissible. Under school board policy, I, as the school board chair, am charged with the responsibility to maintain order during school board meetings.

[02:45:32] Accordingly, when reasonable, I will warn of breaches of decorum, civility, and respect and ask speakers to redirect their comments prior to possibly discontinuing individual speaking privileges or taking other actions to preserve the civility decorum and orderly conduct of the meeting such action includes calling a recess in order to maintain and or restore order if speakers fail to comply with board policy regarding public participation you will receive a warning and a request to redirect or generalize your comments should you fail to redirect or generalize your comments after that warning you may be asked to yield the microphone at which time you should

[02:46:10] yield the microphone as well as the floor and take your seat and i will call the next speaker to the extent necessary i will also warn of breaches of decorum civility and respect from attendees prior to taking other actions to preserve the orderly conduct of the meeting speakers should face the dais and direct their comments to the school board per school board policy 2520 members of the school board will not answer questions or direct respond directly to the public during the public comment period violations of decorum or civility by any meeting attendee may result in the chair directing staff to remove the attendee for the remainder of the meeting

[02:46:50] repeated or persistent violations of decorum or civility by the audience may result in on the decision of the chair public comment being tabled until a later point in the evening's agenda, limiting the number of attendees in the meeting room during public comment for safety reasons, or public comment period ending for the evening. Distribution of materials to school board members. Copies of materials for board members should be given to the public information officer in the media box at the back of the boardroom before the start of the meeting. Please provide 12 copies of materials. Under no circumstance may a speaker approach the

[02:47:26] dais. The public is reminded that access to school board meetings is available through LCPS TV on Comcast Channel 18 and 1070 HD and Verizon Fios Channel 43. The live stream of the meeting may be viewed on the website. We look forward to hearing your comments. We will now start with our virtual public comment. Our first speaker is Lauren Triplett followed by Harish Badali.

[02:47:52] Good evening. Thank you to the board and transportation committee for adjusting Stuart Weller's proposed start time to 745 next year. We do appreciate the effort. However, a 15-minute shift is not a meaningful solution for our elementary families. Many of our children will still be boarding buses by at least 715. That remains very early for young students. It continues to impact sleep, readiness to learn, and overall well-being. So while this is a step, it doesn't

[02:48:31] actually solve the problem. What's harder to reconcile is the inconsistency. Selden's Landing has had an 8 a.m. start time for years while our community is being asked to accept significantly earlier mornings despite feeding into this same middle school. At a certain point, this stops feeling like a logistics issue and starts feeling like an equity issue. If just one additional bus could make an 8 a.m. start time possible, we respectfully ask that the board take another look at the budget to prioritize that solution. Thank you. Thank you. Harish Vidali, followed by

[02:49:06] Patusha Mangamuri. Good evening, school board members. I'm the parent of a rising student at Lansford Middle School, and I'm here to express my concern about the proposed changes to bus service, specifically the increased walk radius. For many families like ours, this change would require children to walk close to 40 minutes each way. During colder months and in poor weather conditions, this is not just inconvenient. It raises serious safety concerns. Over the

[02:49:45] course of this cool year, students would be expected to cross busy, unsupervised intersections hundreds of times. Each crossing adds risk and collectively this significantly increases the chances of an accident. What is especially concerning is that this decision appears to have been made without a thorough safety assessment. Before reducing transportation services, there should be a clear evidence that student safety has been fully evaluated and protected. Currently, in some areas, there isn't even a continuous sidewalk. Thank you. Pratyusha Mangamuri,

[02:50:24] followed by Krishna Adumala. We do not have a virtual public speaker by that name. Krishna Adumala, followed by Nupur Singh. We do not have a virtual public speaker by that name.

[02:50:42] Nupur Singh, followed by Emma Johnson.

[02:50:56] Good evening, board members. I'm a parent of a Lunsford Middle School student who currently cycles to school. Even for an active, independent kid like mine, their routes are simply not safe. One route takes him past Cardinal Ridge Elementary, where he must navigate a busy, unsupervised stop sign during peak morning traffic with no crossing guard and no protection.

[02:51:21] The only alternative is through a community with no sidewalk and speeding cars, forcing kids to share the road with fast-moving traffic. If it's not safe to cycle, it certainly isn't safe to walk. Cutting bus service without first addressing these hazards puts every child at risk.

[02:51:41] I urge the board to ensure safe routes exist before removing any transportation options. Thank you. Thank you. Emma Johnson, followed by Sachin Bhattra. Good evening.

[02:52:03] My name is Emma Johnson, and I'm a parent of Stuart Weller students. I'm here to respectfully request that Stuart Weller start time be moved to 8 a.m. For the past four years, Weller families have carried the earliest elementary school start time. We really appreciate the effort to move the bell to 745, but we are still asking for an 8 a.m. start time.

[02:52:22] The early start creates real challenges, early bedtimes, stressful mornings, and additional childcare required for working parents. It is not just about convenience, it is about fairness. If it is not feasible to add one more bus to make the 8 a.m. start time possible, then please rotate or switch start times with another school, such as Seldon's Landing, so that one community is not carrying this burden year after year.

[02:52:44] I respectfully ask the committee to move the Stuart Weller to an 8 a.m. start time. Thank you for your time and consideration. Thank you. Thank you. Sachin Bhutra, followed by Ananthra Padmanabhan. We do not have a virtual public speaker by that name.

[02:53:03] Ananthra Padmanabhan, followed by Harishni Gad. Good evening, everyone. Good evening, board and good evening, chair. Thank you for the opportunity. I am a proud parent of a seventh grader at Lunsford Middle School.

[02:53:22] I wanted to express my concerns over the board's decision to cut the bus service to our area, Valiant Drive, intersection of Donovan. I understand that there were some savings in this, which is great, but our area is close to a dangerous intersection of Braddock Road and Donovan.

[02:53:41] The kids are very playful while walking and crossing this intersection, which poses a great imminent danger. I have been driving my son to school, but it causes traffic and congestion in the area.

[02:53:57] And given the rising gas prices these days, it is not an economical solution. So I request, I kindly request the Board to reconsider the decision to start the bus service two-hour year. Thank you so much for your time. Thank you. Hiroshni God, followed by Priscilla Turkson.

[02:54:17] We do not have a virtual public speaker by that name. Priscilla Turkson, followed by Mayor Patel. Hi, can you all hear? Okay, there we go.

[02:54:34] Hi, good evening. I am the parent of two students at Lunsford Middle School, and I am here to ask to please reconsider the transportation decision, not just for my children, but for all children in our neighborhood facing the same situation. Our home is 1.3 miles from the school, and it's not just about distance.

[02:54:51] It's about what that walk actually looks like for a young child. There are areas without sidewalks. There are no crossing guards anywhere, and traffic can be unpredictable. I have personally seen drivers distracted, and that is very hard to ignore as a parent. And like many families, I can't help but think about the tragic situation where an LCPS student was killed while walking to school.

[02:55:13] That stays with you, and it makes this very real for us. I am simply asking that this be looked at not just as a number, but as a real-world situation affecting young children in our community. We all want the same thing, a safe, reasonable way for our children to get to school.

[02:55:31] That is not too much to ask for. Thank you for your time. Thank you. Mayur Patel, followed by Trenton Snowdey. Good evening, school board members. I am a parent of a rising Lunsford Middle School student.

[02:55:50] I am also concerned about removing the school bus services by increasing the walk zone radius. For our kids, this would mean nearly a 40-minute one-way walk each way. Often in winter weathers, over the school year, this adds up to roughly 360 crossings of dangerous, unsupervised intersections, which greatly increases the likelihood of an accident.

[02:56:11] Before making such a drastic decision to cut bus services, proper studies and assessments of student safety and well-being should have been conducted. At a minimum, Transportation Department should have ensured appropriate safety measures are in place like crossing guards, clearly marked school zones, reduced speeds, signs, and visible enforcement such as police or traffic monitoring.

[02:56:32] Parents in our community are deeply concerned by this rushed decision, which ignores basic safety measure and creates a serious risk for our children. So I respectfully urge the board to reinstate the school bus services. Thank you for your time and consideration. Thank you.

[02:56:49] Trenton Snowdy, followed by Brittany Yeo. We do not have a virtual public speaker by that name. Brittany Yeo, followed by Lakshmi Lingutla. Hi, this is Brittany Yeo.

[02:57:07] I'm speaking in support of the Town of Levittsville resolution for the full-time SRO at Levittsville Elementary. Although we do have an unarmed security guard at school who is there to solely check people in and out of our building, in the unfortunate event of an intrusion, that security guard is going to call for the help that we could have already had on site by approving this resolution.

[02:57:29] I think asking our children to hide under a desk and waiting with the lights off and doors locked is a reactive measure that will not suffice in the critical moments before law enforcement can respond, potentially 18 to 23 minutes later at Lovettsville Elementary.

[02:57:45] The additional burden placed on our teachers and staff tasked with maintaining common order during such a crisis for children the ages of 4 to 12 must not be underestimated. Also cautioning that our youngest children don't even comprehend what 18 to 23 minutes truly is. Yet for teachers and parents as myself, each passing second will feel like an eternity.

[02:58:04] I please ask that you reconsider the safety measure. Thank you. Lakshmi Magodla, followed by Louise Burks. We do not have a virtual public speaker by that name. Our last virtual speaker is Louise Burks.

[02:58:27] Good evening. My name is Louise Burks. I'm here as a father because of what happened to my daughter in self-contained special education classroom in this district. Staff witnessed abuse and failed to report it as required by law. Instead, it was handled internally. We have emails, recordings, and proof. I'm going to read an email from a teacher.

[02:58:43] Hi, principal. I am hopeful for resolution regarding the child abuse at the school. I understand my testimony may not be seen convincing. However, I was informed that the TA also reported seeing the abuser harm multiple children. And this will be reported to the vice principal for my report.

[02:58:58] So I have to ask, what does this tell us? Do you believe it is safe for an abuser to continue working in the same classroom? After I submitted my reports, the abuser became aware of what I was doing. Since then, I have not been able to gather more information, but I know this behavior will continue only if, when, or will it happen.

[02:59:17] I cannot feel peaceful knowing children with autism are still being put in danger. I will not tolerate abuse. This is wrong. This is unethical. That teacher did her job. The system did not. We have to give every opportunity. Thank you. We will continue with our in-person public comment. Our first speaker is Mayor Christopher Hornbaker, followed by David Smith. Thank you very much, Madam Clerk, and distinguished members of the school board. I want to show you what I've been passing around Lovitzville for the last week. This has been supported by a petition of almost 500 individuals in a school of a little

[02:59:54] over 500 students, including more than 185 students, 185 parents of 225 of those current students, almost 150 parents of future students that exceed 210. It is a groundswell of support for a school resource officer at Lovetsville Elementary School. I join members of my town council and ask you are now the road is diverging we are asking you to move forward with enhanced

[03:00:33] protection if you don't move forward we're asking you to remove all firearms from this building because that is the only time you will see firearms protecting not by thank you thank you david smith followed by tom budnar good evening as a member of the lovetsville town council i'm here to speak in support of placing school resource officers in our elementary schools specifically Lovitzville Elementary School, not as a reaction rooted in fear, but as a proactive

[03:01:10] investment in safety and relationships. According to the National Center for Education Statistics, over 70 percent of public schools already have some form of sworn law enforcement presence. More importantly, studies show that when officers are properly trained and integrated, they reduce response times in emergencies and help deter potential threats before they escalate.

[03:01:31] But this isn't just about crisis response. In elementary settings, SROs build trust early. They become familiar, positive figures, mentors who teach safety, conflict resolution, and responsible decision-making. That kind of early connection can prevent problems later.

[03:01:49] This is about preparedness, prevention, and peace of mind for students, staff, and families. Thank you. Thank you. Tom Budnar, followed by Kristen Lloyd. Good evening. My name is Tom Budnar, Vice Mayor of Levitzville.

[03:02:09] On December 14, 2012, I was living in Connecticut. That morning, 20 children and six staff members were murdered at Sandy Hook Elementary School, which was the deadliest mass shooting at an elementary school in U.S. history. I remember that day with a pain that never fully leaves you.

[03:02:27] Levittsville is uniquely vulnerable. Our school sits 15 minutes from the nearest sheriff's office and 10 miles from the nearest SRO. In an emergency, geography should not determine whether a child comes home. The Levittsville community is united on this issue, and we're asking you to be united with us.

[03:02:44] We don't want to look back after a tragedy and wish we had acted sooner. You hold the safety of our little ones in your hands. Let's work together to ensure that no parent in Levittsville ever asked us why we didn't take immediate action when we understood the risk. Please consider our request for an SRO and join us in making Levittsville Elementary School a place where our children can feel safe.

[03:03:06] Thank you. Thank you. Kristen Lloyd followed by Rafale Morfin.

[03:03:19] Hi, I'm here regarding the Stuart Weller Bell schedule, which will be addressed later tonight. I appreciate the proposal to shift Stuart Weller to a 7.45 a.m. start and don't want to seem ungrateful, but this is not a fair solution.

[03:03:38] Stuart Weller families ask for the opportunity to shift to an 8 a.m. start. The majority of LCPS elementary schools begin at 8 a.m. If we cannot all start at that time, it is most fair to impose a multi-year rotation, not an annual bell flip as outlined in the upcoming presentation.

[03:03:57] Based on the F&O discussion last week, only one more bus is needed to make the 8 a.m. schedule happen. Mr. Lewis, please review bus loads, budget, or extend the well or walk zones to find one more bus and give our families reprieve. We are tired of carrying the burden of a problem that should be shared by all LCPS elementary families.

[03:04:18] We ask for fair treatment. Special thanks also to Mr. Svensson and Mr. Pepper for your time and attention on this matter. Thank you. Raphael Morphin followed by Lisa McHugh. Lisa McHugh

[03:04:38] followed by Stuart Stahl. Stuart Stahl followed by Dominic Lombardi.

[03:04:59] My name is Stuart Stahl. I am a Lovettsville Town Council member here tonight in support of the Lovettsville Resolution for full-time SRO at the Lovettsville Elementary School. More than 20 percent of all school shootings happen in elementary schools with some of the deadliest shootings such as Sandy Hook and Rob Elementary, both of which did not have an SRO dedicated to their school. A few weeks ago in a suburb of Detroit, Michigan and another elementary school in Houston, Texas, there were an attempt

[03:05:33] of shootings both resulted in no injuries because they had security on premises. The closest SRO to Lovettsville Elementary is 25 minutes away. I strongly urge the board to place an SRO at Lovettsville Elementary. Elementary schools need the same protection that all are already offered at middle schools and high schools. Thank you. Thank you. Dominic Lombardi

[03:06:03] followed by Victor Block. Victor Block followed by Andrea Weiskopf.

[03:06:24] Good morning or good evening board member. My name is Victor Block. I'm the president of Loudoun Valley Estates Homeowners Association and a parent of one current and one former LCPS student. I'm speaking to you about Dominion's proposed Golden Lamar's high voltage lines. I've reached out to a few of you and emailed you additional information but would love to speak with all of you in more detail. I want to thank this board for standing with our community. You're supporting underground and

opposing above ground transmission on school property has been consistent and meaningful. Given time I want to make sure you know a small tidbit about how far Dominion is willing to go to get their way. Their representatives

[03:07:02] reached out to me multiple times over the last year for the last year and a half asking me to organize our community to pressure you to get you the school board to accept routes three and four in order for us not to get route 3a and Loudoun County Parkway. Those that were on the board last year know that we did exactly the opposite but I also want to flag concern with your closing brief you filed with the sec which i will not have time to do today but i thank you thank you thank you

[03:07:30] our final speaker tonight is andrea weiskopf long before ray tedra mark and aaron eric williams presented vision 2020 his all new and improved mission statement it was in 2015 i know i was here. While you, the school board, worried about infinity and beyond, educators were doing the work.

[03:08:05] While the admin was spending hours almost giddy over the mission name, Life Ready, Community Strong, I was teaching juniors to write a thesis statement. Don't let your discussion of the mission. Get in the way of the mission. With or without a title, educators are already doing it.

[03:08:30] Black Lives Matter. Thank you. Thank you for coming out today and for providing your public comment. With that, our public comment period has ended. We will move on now to item number 12, our action items. Our first item is 12.01 minutes of the March 5th, 2026 special school board meeting. Ms. Riccardi, do you have a motion? I do, Madam Chair. Thank you so much. I actually have seven amendments to the minutes, and I wanted just to ask you, I know we're also looking at

[03:09:07] 730, so I wanted to ask you a couple of questions about how you wanted to proceed. I'll take your advice on however you want to do this. I have seven separate amendments. We can do them one at a time, or I can work my way through them. Just as a methodology, I'll tell you, I went back through and captured the meeting minutes from the video that's that LCPS posted with the time stamps and provided all of the the narrative that I have as far as amendments to go into the meeting minutes do you want to go one at a time do you want to do all of them how would you like to proceed with that let's go

[03:09:46] one at a time all right then my first madam chair I move to amend the minutes to note the public comment was received on the general topic of school safety and SROs, and that the specific motion language voted upon at this meeting was not available to the public or to all board members prior to the public comment period. So my proposed amendment text reads as follows, add the following to the public comment section after the list of speakers, quote, public comment was received on the general subject of safety and security measures for

[03:10:23] elementary schools. The specific motion language that was subsequently introduced and voted upon during the action item had not been posted on board docs included in the agenda or otherwise made available to the public or to all board members prior to the public comment period yes um miss labelle i second the motion all right um miss ricardi would you like to speak to your motion it's pretty just pretty straightforward for those of you who are here at the public comment special session on march 5th to discuss sros there was there was a the action item on there

[03:11:02] was specific about a discussion. There was nothing about action. And subsequently, there was information that was provided in the form of a motion that was given to perhaps five of us, but not all nine of us. And so I just want that reflected in the record. Thank you. Is there any discussion?

[03:11:25] Mr. Stinson. Thank you, Madam Chair. I don't know if it's customary practice to editorialize in the meeting minutes. So I'll be voting no on this just because I don't think this is the appropriate use of meeting minutes. Thank you. Mr. Pepper.

[03:11:44] Point of information, Madam Chair, thank you. - Yes. - I believe this might be directed more towards the parliamentarian, if you will, so maybe Mr. Allen can help me with this. Is it necessary for all motions raised to be listed prior to a meeting?

[03:12:06] - Thank you, Mr. Pepper. Traditionally and historically, as was mentioned at the March 5th meeting, I believe there's typically a recommendation that is reflected on board docs that provides a general base motion or general item for discussion as an action item.

[03:12:35] So it gives some degree of information as to what action the board might take. But certainly there's flexibility within Robert's rules to make incidental motions pertaining to the recommendation which typically informs the base motion that the board makes.

[03:12:58] - Thank you. - Vice Chair Donahue. - Thank you Madam Chair. I'm curious from Ms. Riccardi, you said you have seven proposed motions or amendments. I'm curious if you asked for any of them to be posted on board docs or if you circulated them to any of us.

[03:13:18] - Thanks for the question, it's really great. So to be honest with you, I receive the meeting minutes as we all do as the pre-draft to take a look at them. It's taken quite a while to go back through and look at the video and gather all of this information.

[03:13:34] And according to Robert's rules, the process is to make those amendments at a meeting. So that's what I'm doing, thank you.

[03:13:50] - Any further discussion? Seeing no further discussion, let's take a vote on this motion. Ms. Riccardi, could you please reread your motion? - Yes, Madam Chair. Public comment was received on the general subject of safety and security measures for elementary schools.

[03:14:09] The specific motion language that was subsequently introduced and voted upon during the action item had not been posted on board docs, included in the agenda, or otherwise made available to the public or to all board members prior to the public comment period.

[03:14:27] - Thank you, Ms. Riccardi has made a motion which was properly seconded by Ms. LaBelle. Clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please record your vote. Clerk, please close and display the vote.

[03:14:45] That motion fails with six school board members voting no, including Mr. Svensson, Ms. Chernoff, myself, Vice Chair Donahue, Mr. Pepper, and Dr. Rasheed, and three school board members voting yes, including Ms. Riccardi, Mrs. Griffiths, and Ms. LaBelle.

[03:15:02] All right, Ms. Riccardi, would you like to go on with your second one? - Yes, thank you, Madam Chair. I move to amend the minutes of the March 5th, 2026 special school board meeting to add a complete record of the point of order I raised following the introduction and seconding of Mr. Svensson's motion consistent with my other on-the-record requests that my objection be reflected in the minutes. So the proposed amendment reads to add the following after the sentence recording and second of Mr. Svensson's motion and before the vote entries and it says immediately following the seconding of Mr. Svensson's

[03:15:39] motion, Ms. Riccardi raised a point of order, citing Virginia Code section 2.2-3707 and board policy 2430 on the grounds that the special meeting notice authorized only deliberation and did not authorize a binding vote, and that policy 2430 requires items subject to a vote to be placed on the agenda at the following regularly scheduled business meeting.

[03:16:05] Ms. Riccardi requested that board counsel provide an opinion on whether the motion could be properly brought. Board Counsel Allen requested a recess to review the question. The chair recessed the board at approximately 6.55 p.m. Following the recess, Board Counsel Allen advised that because the item had been posted as an action item on board docs, the board could proceed to vote, citing Virginia Code section 22.1-72 and policy 2210 subsection C. Ms. Riccardi then stated directly to board counsel that the recommend recommended action in the

[03:16:42] notice authorization only deliberation not a vote and that standard LCPS action item language was absent. Board counsel Allen maintained his position. Ms. Riccardi then formally noted her objection for the record stated that she believed the action exceeded the scope of the special meeting notice that the action may be subject to legal challenge and requested that her objection be reflected in the minutes. The chair did not issue a formal ruling sustaining or overruling the point of order at any stage of this exchange right miss Riccardi has made a motion is

[03:17:15] there a second second thank you mrs. Griffiths miss Riccardi would you like to speak to your motion just simply the fact that I just want to make sure that we're reflecting this I had asked this to be reflected in the minutes at the time of the meeting and it wasn't so this is just the outline of what happened thank you is there any discussion yes mrs. Griffiths I think with these amendments. I personally think that we should revise the minutes if there are items missing from that meeting. It should be clear and concise. Thank you. Thank you. Mr. Pepper. And once again,

[03:17:54] a question perhaps for our parliamentarian. Thank you, Madam Chair. Do we normally, because when I read the minutes, I don't normally see a play-by-play of the entire discussion. Is that common practice for meeting minutes? Thank you, Mr. Pepper. What I can say is pursuant to board policy 2450, which is entitled board minutes, that sets forth the contents of the minutes. There's eight items there, and I won't read those, but as to subsection B, it's entitled form.

[03:18:33] It says the minutes should contain a record of what was done at the meeting and shall otherwise be brief and simple as possible so it's within the board's purview as to how fulsome the board would like their minutes to be and it's for the board's consideration. Thank you. Mr. Pepper please. Madam Chair thank you. Do recesses and I'm looking at the policy right now Mr. Parliamentarian

[03:19:02] but do recesses need to be included in the minutes? Thank you. I don't readily see that is required by policy but I would think the the board clerk has at times noted a recess in the meeting particularly when meetings extend to another date that is reflected but without putting the board clerk on the spot that's the the best response I can give and as to my recollection

[03:19:44] Thank you. Ms. LaBelle. As this was a special meeting, not a regularly scheduled board meeting, I think that it needs to be perfectly clear what was covered at the meeting and what was not. So I think that all of this information that Ms. Riccardi is presenting needs to be included for that reason. Thank you.

[03:20:09] Thank you. Ms. Riccardi. Just as a point of clarification, I did, specifically in the meeting, when I made this request, asked for it to be on the record and is not reflected on the record. So I made that very, very clear when I made this original motion and we went into that piece of this. It was clearly stated.

[03:20:30] Thank you. I took some time to look at policy 2450. I notice in A7, it says a record of the votes taken on any motion, including the names of each member casting a vote, whether such member voted A or nay, or the name of each member who abstains from voting, and the name of each member not present at the time the vote was taken.

[03:20:54] B1, the minute should contain a record of what was done at the meeting and shall otherwise be brief and simple as possible. let's see that would be B5 minutes including draft minutes and all other records of open meetings including the audio and audio visual records shall be deemed public records and subject to the Virginia Information Act all records including the minutes and the draft minutes must be maintained permanently as required by the retention schedules for the Library of Virginia and by the

[03:21:27] Virginia Public Records Act and then Mr. Allen so according to our policy all all of our recorded meetings are actually part of the public record, correct? Thank you, Chair Chandler. That is correct.

[03:21:43] Thank you. Any further discussion? Yes, Mr. Riccardi. And I would argue that if you take a look at our meeting minutes, they're woefully insufficient for a public body's meeting minutes. There are many times when I've gone back through to look at meeting minutes that are absolutely missing discussions who raise the issues, even just sometimes broad brush things.

[03:22:08] And so I want to make sure as a special session, as Ms. LaBelle pointed out, that we are accurately reflecting that. And again, I made a request for this to be entered into the minutes, and it wasn't. And if it's going to be a thing where we, you know, we ask for things to be put in the minutes and they're just not going to be put in there, then I think this public body should know that.

[03:22:29] But understand that does violate Robert's rules quite clearly. Thank you. Mrs. Griffiths. I just want to add to that. I agree with Ms. LaBelle and Ms. Riccardi. for transparency uh to go back and look at the minutes and not have to look at videos i think it should be uh written in the minutes and we should be updating the minutes if something if items are missing it was a special meeting um so i think i'm not saying it's a special case but

[03:23:02] i think it all these items should be reflected in the minutes thank you thank you any further discussion. All right. Ms. Riccardi, I'll ask you to please read your motion again. Oh, I'm sorry. Are you sure? No, please. All right. To add the following after the sentence recording, the seconding of the Svensson motion and before the vote entries. Immediately following the seconding of Mr.

[03:23:29] Svensson's motion, Ms. Riccardi raised a point of order citing Virginia Code section 2.2-3707 and board policy 2430 on the grounds that the special meeting notice authorized only deliberation and did not authorize a binding vote, and that policy 2430 requires items subject to a vote to be placed on the agenda at the following regularly scheduled business meeting.

[03:23:55] Ms. Riccardi requested the board counsel provide an opinion on whether the motion could be properly brought. Board counsel Allen requested a recess to review the question. The chair recessed the board at approximately 6.55 p.m. Following the recess, board counsel Allen advised that because the item had been posted as an action item on board docs, the board could proceed to vote, citing Virginia Code

section 22.1-72 and policy 2210, subsection C. Ms. Riccardi then stated directly to the board council that the recommended action in the notice authorized only deliberation,

[03:24:32] not a vote, and that standard LCPS action item language was absent. Board counsel Allen maintained his position. Ms. Riccardi then formally noted her objection for the record and stated that she believed the action exceeded the scope of the special meeting notice, that the action may be subject to legal challenge, and requested that her objection be reflected in the minutes. The Chair did not issue a formal ruling sustaining or overruling the point of order at any stage of this exchange.

[03:25:03] Thank you. It has been properly moved by Ms. Riccardi and seconded by Mrs. Griffiths. Clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please record your vote. Clerk, please close and display the vote.

[03:25:22] That motion fails with six school board members voting no, including Mr. Svensson, Ms. Chernoff, myself, Vice Chair Donahue, Mr. Pepper, and Dr. Rasheed, and three school board members voting yes, including Ms. Riccardi, Mrs. Griffiths, and Ms. LaBelle. Next up.

[03:25:40] Okay, thank you. Madam Chair, I move to amend the minutes to correct a sequencing error in the order of votes section. I'm asking to reorder the votes in the order of the vote section as follows. Again, this follows the video. Point number one, that motion by Mr. Svensson introduced and seconded as currently recorded.

[03:25:59] Number two, the point of order raised by Mrs. Riccardi immediately followed the seconding of Mr. Svensson's motion per amendment to above. This exchange included the recess and board council opinion occurred before Ms. Chernoff's substitute motion was introduced.

[03:26:16] Substitute motion by Ms. Chernoff introduced and seconded as currently recorded. Number four, motion by Ms. Donoghue to call the question on Ms. Chernoff's substitute motion requires a two-thirds vote. It was seconded by Ms. Chernoff. The motion passed 7-2, with Mrs. Griffiths and Mrs. LaBelle opposed.

[03:26:37] Number five, Chernoff's substitute vote was time-stamped at 2 hours and 15 minutes. In the video, the motion failed 3-5-1, with Mrs. Riccardi abstaining. Number six, the motion by Mrs. LaBelle to suspend the rules.

[03:26:53] The motion failed one to seven to one with Mrs. Riccardi abstaining. Number seven, the base motion by Mr. Svensson passed five to three to one with Mrs. Riccardi abstaining. Number seven, the motion by Mrs. Chandler was introduced.

[03:27:11] Number nine, a second point of order was raised by Mrs. Riccardi on the same procedural grounds as her earlier objection. And number 10, that Mrs. Chandler withdrew her motion. Ms. LaBelle. I second the motion.

[03:27:28] Thank you. Ms. Riccardi, would you like to speak to your motion? It's just a matter of making sure we've got the right order of the actions that happened in the meeting. Thank you. Board members, is there any discussion? Ms. Griffiths. With all these amendments, I want to point out the minutes should be accurate and have transparency.

[03:27:51] And everybody here should want that. We should have it documented accurately. Thank you. Thank you. Mr. Pepper. Thank you, Madam Chair. I do actually believe that some of these are out of order.

[03:28:09] The motion to call the question on Ms. Chernoff's by Ms. Donahue did actually occur before the vote on Ms. Chernoff's motion. So I do believe those are out of order.

[03:28:24] But I also believe that Mr. Cardi might incorrect, and maybe you can help me answer this. Are you adding additional information in your amendment? Yes, I am, because my motions were not reflected in the minutes. So I added mine in there as well. Can you, you're going to restate it anyway.

[03:28:42] I'm sure, I'm sure. So I'll wait to hear those again when you restate your motion before we vote. But I do believe these are out of order, actually. Thank you. Any further discussion?

[03:28:59] Ms. Riccardi, could you please reread your amendment? Yes, Madam Chair. So we're reordering the votes so that, one, the motion by Mr. Spenson introduced and seconded as currently recorded. The point of order raised by Ms. Riccardi immediately following the seconding of Mr.

[03:29:14] Svensson's motion per Amendment 2 above, this exchange included the recess and Board Council's opinion occurred before Ms. Chernoff's substitute motion was introduced. Number three, that the substitute motion by Ms. Chernoff was introduced and seconded, and that's as currently recorded.

[03:29:32] The motion by Ms. Donahue to call the question on Ms. Chernoff's substitute motion happened. It was seconded by Ms. Chernoff, and the motion passed 7 to 2 with Ms. Griffins and Mrs. LaBelle opposed. Number five, the Chernoff substitute was voted and it failed three to five to one with Ms. Riccardi abstaining. Then the motion by Ms. LaBelle to suspend the rules and the motion failed seven to one to one with Ms. Riccardi abstaining. Then the base motion by Mr.

[03:30:04] Svensson was voted on and passed five to three to one with Ms. Riccardi abstaining. Then the motion by Ms. Chandler was introduced and then the second point of order was raised by Ms. Riccardi on the same procedural grounds as her earlier objection and the Mrs. Chandler withdrew her motion. Thank you. The motion has been properly made and seconded by Ms. LaBelle. Clerk please open the vote. School

[03:30:35] board members please record your vote.

[03:30:52] Clerk please close and display the vote. Okay the motion passes with five members voting yes including Ms. Riccardi, Ms. Chernoff, Mrs. Griffiths, Mr. Pepper and Ms. LaBelle and four board members voting no including Mr. Svensson, myself, Vice Chair Donahue and Dr.

[03:31:11] rasheed all right next up thank you madam chair I move to amend the minutes to add the stated grounds for my abstentions on the three substantive votes which I stated on the record at the meeting and it just simply reads for each of the three abstention entries the Chernoff substitute LaBelle suspension and Svensson main motion add the following clause and mrs. Riccardi abstained on the stated grounds that the proceedings exceeded the scope of the special meeting notice and were procedurally invalid I'm sorry I'm sorry

[03:31:45] did I interrupt you no no you're good thank you miss LaBelle I second the motion thank you miss Riccardi would you like to speak further to your motion just that I wanted to make sure that this is put on the record that you know as I clearly say it's a simple statement thank you thank you any discussion all right clerk please open the vote board members please record your vote clerk please close and display the vote that motion fails with six school board

[03:32:25] members voting no including mr. Svensson ms. Chernoff myself vice chair Donahue, Mr. Pepper and Dr. Rasheed and three school board members voting yes including Ms. Riccardi, Mrs. Griffiths

and Ms. LaBelle. Thank you. We'll move on. Could you, are you at number six? This will be number five. Thank you. Yep. Thank you, Madam Chair. I move to amend the minutes to include my on the record statement made between the suspension vote and the main motion vote regarding the pre-distribution of the motion language to read and to be added at the following between the suspension vote entry and the main motion vote entry it

[03:33:01] says prior to the vote on the base motion Ms. Riccardi stated on the record that the motion had clearly been crafted and made available to at least some board members before the meeting that it had not been provided to all members for consideration in advance that this represented pre-planning by at least some portion of the board without the full board's knowledge and that the motion text should have been shared with all nine members and posted as part of the noticed agenda item. Ms. LaBelle. I second the motion. Thank you. Ms. Riccardi, would you like to speak

[03:33:39] further to your motion? This is just an addition of my objection to the fact that you know five of you had access to this motion clearly before all nine of us did and even after the meeting I still didn't have a hard copy of it so I'm just trying to make sure that that's entered in the record.

[03:33:55] Thank you. Any discussion? Vice Chair Donohue. Thank you, Madam Chair. To Mrs. Bricardi's last point, I don't appreciate you making assertions like that on the dais. Vice Chair, I would just ask you please to speak to the issues and not to the person. I just want to be cautious as we maintain decorum in the meeting. Thank you, Madam Chair. Noted. I did not have a copy of any motions from the March 5th meeting in advance and I feel like I must point out the

[03:34:33] irony of Miss Riccardi who is clearly reading from advanced written-out prepared motions that also have not been shared or circulated. Thank you. Thank you, Miss Riccardi. I'll just point out again that Roberts rules of order doesn't require that meeting minute changes be shared or documented or presented beforehand. I had a chance to go through and prepare my notes because in fact fixing meeting minutes at the meeting is exactly what you're supposed

[03:35:07] to do per Roberts rules. Thank you. Thank you. Mr. Svensson. I would just like to note for the record that Ms. Riccardi has introduced motions and made requests to staff that would require speaking to other board members without showing me a motion and without asking me to join in a request to staff. This is and this is something that's commonly done so I would just say this is not out of the That someone would not have shown every single member of the school board the motion that they were contemplating for a discussion.

[03:35:42] Thank you. Miss LaBelle. Thank you, Madam Chair. I would like to state that I have absolutely no knowledge of what motions Miss McCarty was making, but I do believe that an actual accurate reflection of what was said and passed at that meeting is very important.

[03:36:06] it was a special meeting there was no time to discuss anything and yet here we are I want all of that documented that's my stake in this thank you any further discussion all right clerk please open the vote board members please record your vote clerk please close and display the vote

[03:36:37] that motion fails with six board members voting no including Mr. Svensson Ms. Chernoff myself Vice-Chair Donahue, Mr. Pepper, and Dr. Rasheed, and three school board members voting yes, including Ms. Riccardi, Mrs. Griffiths, and Ms. LaBelle.

[03:36:56] Ms. Riccardi, please continue. Great, thank you. This would be amendment number six. Madam Chair, I move to amend the minutes as read. Add the following between the entry recording Ms. Chandler's motion and the entry recording her withdrawal. And it says, immediately following the introduction of Ms. Chandler's motion, Ms. Riccardi raised a point of order on the same procedural grounds as her earlier objection that the special meeting notice authorized only deliberation and did not authorize binding action on any motion at this meeting. The chair did not issue a formal ruling sustaining or overruling

[03:37:32] this point of order. Second. Thank you. Ms. Riccardi would you like to speak to your motion further? No ma'am I think it's pretty straightforward. Is there any discussion? The motion was made by miss Riccardi and seconded by mrs. Griffiths clerk please open the vote board members please record your vote clerk please close and display the vote

[03:38:11] that motion fails with six school board members voting no including mr. Svensson miss Chernoff myself vice chair Donahue mr. Pepper and dr. Rasheed and three school board members voting yes including mr. Riccardi mrs. Griffiths and miss LaBelle and please mr. Riccardi last one I move to amend the minutes to reflect the following to replace miss Chandler withdrew her motion with following a point of order raised by miss Riccardi on the same procedural grounds as her earlier objection that the special meeting

[03:38:46] notice did not authorize binding action and miss Chandler withdrew her emotion thank you second thank you it has been seconded by mrs. Griffiths mr. Riccardi would you like to speak to your motion any further no I'm good thank you. Thank you. Any discussion? All right, board members. Clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please record your vote. Clerk, please close and display the vote. Motion fails with six

[03:39:25] school board members voting no, including Mr. Svensson, Ms. Chernoff, myself, Vice Chair Donohue, Mr. Pepper, Dr. Rasheed, and three school board members voting yes, including Ms. Riccardi, Mrs. Griffiths, and Ms. LaBelle. Thank you, and seeing no further, we're all set. I hate to say this. I think that was number six. I thought you said seven. I did say seven, but I think I just missed one. One more. This is the last one for sure. Thank you. I'm sorry for getting these out of order. Madam Chair, I ask to make the following amendment to add the following between the entry recording of Ms. Chandler's motion and the entry recording her withdrawal. Quote, immediately

[03:40:02] following the introduction of Ms. Chandler's motion, Ms. Riccardi raised a point of order on the same procedural grounds as her earlier objection that the special meeting notice authorized only deliberation did not author I think I just read that one I think we're good sorry about that thank you I think we're good okay um I appreciate that clarification thank you for that um with that we will move on to our action item number 12.02 specialized programs and centers committee the Middleburg Community Charter School 2026-2027 school calendar Ms. Chernoff do you

[03:40:38] have a motion thank you Madam Chair I move that the Loudoun County School Board approve the Middleburg Community Charter School's proposed 2026-2027 school calendar. Second. Thank you, Vice Chair Donahue, for seconding that motion.

[03:40:56] Ms. Chernoff, would you like to speak to your motion? Thank you, Madam Chair. As was presented last meeting, the Middleburg Community Charter School uses a slightly different calendar than

LCPS, and it is presented to us each year for approval. As noted in the meeting last time, the calendar did have a couple of edits as it was brought and to look in closer alignment with how our LCPS calendars work.

[03:41:22] Thank you. Is there any board members? Do you have any discussion? Yes, Vice Chair Donohue. Thank you, Madam Chair. I raised this in the Specialized Programs and Centers Committee meeting because I did notice that this proposed calendar does not observe certain holidays that LCPS does observe, which I understand is permissible under our agreement with Middleburg.

[03:41:51] And I'm not going to gum up the works about it right now, but I would be interested in digging into that more in the future. Thank you. Any further discussion?

[03:42:08] All right. Seeing no further discussion, it has been properly moved by Ms. Chernoff and seconded by Vice Chair Donohue. Clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please record your vote. Clerk, please close and display the vote.

[03:42:28] That motion passes unanimously with all nine school board members present. Mr. Slevin, if you would please offer me just a point of privilege at this time, I would like to ask our parliamentarian, Mr. Allen, is it necessary after the vote on the minutes to actually take a vote on the minutes?

[03:42:53] Because I believe the minutes can be considered completed otherwise. - That's correct, Chair Chandler. Pursuant to Robert's rules, it does state that the board needn't approve, if you can just bear with me here.

[03:43:21] It's rule 41:10. The minutes are thus approved without any formal vote, even if a motion for their approval has been made. Although for clarity of the record, given the posture that the board typically does approve the minutes as part of the consent agenda for bell and suspenders, the board could, and it would be reasonable for the board to take a vote to approve the minutes as amended.

[03:43:55] - Well, I would, given that clarification, I do appreciate that it's not necessary, but I do think it would be good for the record for us to take a vote, so I will ask. Ms. Riccardi has presented amendments to amend the minutes, And just to square our, what's your, yes, Mr. Swenson.

[03:44:20] - Point of information. So we had one amendment that passed to alter the order, but I think there were some new additional items that related to prior amendments that failed that were referenced in that reordering. So what will the minutes actually look like is my question.

[03:44:38] - Oh, that's a very good question. I wonder if we could not perhaps ask staff to go back and if that would be appropriate, make sure that the minutes reflect the votes and we could add it to the consent agenda at the next meeting if the board would be amenable to that.

[03:44:58] Yes, Ms. McCarty? Yeah, Madam Chair, I do not want it on the consent agenda. Okay, then let's take a vote now. The amended minutes. Okay, Mr. Pepper? Madam Chair, can we, I agree with my colleague, Mr. Svensson, I would love to see how it is actually written with the new things.

[03:45:19] Can we possibly wait until our April 14th meeting to vote on this as an action item if Ms. Riccardi is not amenable to putting it on the consent agenda? I will allow for this item to come back as an action item with corrected minutes at the next meeting in April.

[03:45:38] All right, thank you. And with that, thank you for your patience. We'll move on to item 12.03, Department of Teaching and Learning, Social Sciences, and Global Studies Instructional Resource Recommendation. Dr. Rasheed, do you have a motion? Yes, thank you, Chair. I move that the Loudoun

County School Board approve the recommended K-12, Social Science, and Global Studies Instructional Resources.

[03:46:01] Second. Thank you. Ms. Chernoff has seconded Dr. Rasheed's motion. Dr. Rasheed, would you like to speak to your motion? Thank you, Chair. Sure. The Department of Teaching and Learning issued an RFP conducted a review process that aligned with the video e timeline and the newly adopted standards of learning so based on the feedback from teachers and school leaders and community members the Department of Teaching Learning then shared those recommendations for primary instructional resources for social science and global studies courses and so hence here we are with those

[03:46:38] recommendations incorporated thank you thank you board members is there any discussion on the motion all right seeing no discussion we'll move forward with the vote it has been properly moved by Dr. Rasheed and seconded by Ms. Chernoff clerk please open the vote board members please record your vote yeah I'm not sure it's cleared actually all right thank you all right clerk

[03:47:17] please close and display the vote oh she's absent for the vote all right that motion passes with all eight school board members present and Mrs. Griffiths absent for the vote all right with that we will move on with our information items for tonight item 13.01 office of the superintendent student school calendar and staff calendar updates will be presented by miss Chernoff thank you madam chair tonight I'm bringing forward a proposed

[03:47:53] adjustment to the school calendar for this school year after hearing from members of our community and our schools due to a special election scheduled for April 21st 2026 there are safety and logistical concerns with students attending school that day as a result I'm proposing a change to make April 21st a student holiday with a staff workday which will be remote eligible. Additionally I have heard concerns about the school year ending on a Monday. The option I support for consideration would shift the last day of school for students to Friday June 12th, 2026 with Monday June 15th

[03:48:29] designated as a staff professional development day. Within board docs you'll see two calendar options the first one option one just has the April 21st date as a student holiday with a workday for staff option two has the two dates that I have just discussed and with your permission I would like to ask a couple of questions that arose through a very thorough feedback response on my social media after over 450 interactions and almost 400 comments with overwhelming

[03:49:07] support zero dislikes I would like to say there were a couple logistical concerns although people are overwhelmingly supportive so I just wanted to put some of those clarifications on the record so I will ask staff a couple of questions the first is the most overwhelming response from staff was why a professional learning day versus just a work day. So Dr. Ellis, would you be willing to speak to the reasoning behind a professional day on the 15th? Sure. And I'll ask my colleagues, Ms. Boland and Mr. Slevin and others to jump in if I miss anything. So currently

[03:49:45] the, and typically there are two teacher work days after the last day of school as part of the teacher contract those days are used for finalizing grades closing out the school year cleaning and packing up rooms sometimes particularly if there are construction projects in the building that summer etc so those those days are pretty full and that's standard each year a professional learning day would give an opportunity for principals and central office staff to work together to provide professional learning for teachers and staff to prepare

[03:50:22] for the coming school year we have fewer professional learning days at the beginning of August at the start at the start of the school year this coming year for the 26 27 school year so this additional day would balance out that reduction in professional learning in August thank you dr. Ellis I also had a question sure enough yes I'm sorry can I just add one additional name of course. While Dr. Ellis is 100% correct, we typically have two work days at the end of the

[03:50:59] school year for teachers. This year, we actually already have three, which is abnormal. So adding this day as just a work day would also be a fourth day. Thank you, Ms. Boland. I appreciate that.

[03:51:15] Another thing that I just wanted to put on the radar, sort of on the operational side, there were a couple of comments about the a day b day schedule and how that would be affected as well as testing dates that may have already been predetermined based off of those a day b day schedules so I don't think that's something we need to tackle that's I'm gonna put that on you guys but that was an awareness I'm happy to send those along and then a question came through today will graduations have to be altered and I believe the answer is no because they would not have been impacted by the school day anyway is

[03:51:50] that correct that's correct okay great and then just two small shout outs I'm sorry to the school that has a field trip planned on April 21st I hope I wish you well in rescheduling and to my friends at Evergreen Mill the PTA moms who had scheduled a fifth grade party on the last day of school and have a logistical nightmare on their hands with vendors I am grateful for chatting with you and understanding your concerns there is overwhelming support so I'm still going to support it but we appreciate all that you do for our kids to make these end-of-year celebrations and I know you're already working on it

[03:52:25] so shout out to my people in Leesburg I am sorry and with that I will I guess that's that's the info item thank you yes I will open the floor to board member questions vice-chair Donahue thank you madam chair I moved to suspend the rules oh thank you so vice-chair Donahue could you please speak to your suspension of the rules? Sure. I'm allowed to. I'm moving to suspend the rules to vote on the

[03:52:59] calendar option two. Okay. Thank you for clarifying what I was asking for, not because there's no discussion when you make a motion to suspend the rules, but just to make sure that everybody was clear on the motion that was on the floor. So to restate the motion, Vice Chair Donahue has made a motion to suspend the rules to take this up as an action item tonight so that we can vote specifically for calendar item number two. And a second. Oh, I'm sorry. So I hear a second by Mr.

[03:53:32] Svensson. Thank you so much. And then just the dates that are at the ask are April 21st, which is election day. And then Ms. Chernoff, I'll look to you. It's June 15th, 15th, which is the last day of school but that's on a Monday but that's a separate vote so really we're just taking an action I like we're voting to suspend the rules to take this up as an action item to then make a second motion on the decision okay so there's no further discussion school board members please record your vote on

[03:54:08] the motion to suspend the rules to make a decision today Clark please close and display the vote that motion passes unanimously with all nine school board members present voting yes um and with that are there any other motions okay um yes ms shirnoff thank you madam chair i move that the school board update the approved 2026 2027 school

[03:54:37] is that right 2526 sorry school calendar to change april 21st 2026 from a school day to a student holiday and a staff work day remote eligible and change the final day of school for students from june 15th

2026 to June 12, 2026, with June 15th being designated as a staff development day. Thank you. Second, uh, thank you. I hear a second by Vice Chair Donahue. Um, Ms. Chernoff, at this point, would you like to speak to your motion any further? No, um, is there any discussion, School Board members?

[03:55:15] Okay, seeing no discussion, uh, we have a motion on the floor that the Loudoun County School Board update the approved 2025-2026 school calendar to change April 21st, 2026, from a school day to a student holiday and a staff workday, remote eligible, and change the final day of school for students from June 15th, 2026, to June 12th, 2026, with June 15th being designated as a staff development day. The motion was made by Ms. Chernoff and seconded by Vice Chair Donahue. Clerk, please open the vote. School Board members, please.

[03:55:53] Record your vote. Clerk, please close and display the vote, and that motion passes with all nine School Board members present voting yes. All right, thank you so much. With that, we will move on to item 13.02, Department of Support Services, mid-year transportation update, walk zone and school start time review. Tonight, this will be presented by Mr. Kevin Lewis, our Chief Operations Officer, and

[03:56:23] Miss Tisha Austin, Assistant Director of Transportation.

[03:56:48] - Thank you, Chair Chandler and members of the board. Tonight, as noted, we are providing our mid-year transportation update. To my immediate right is Tisha Austin, our Assistant Director of Transportation, and Mr. Davies, our director, to her right.

[03:57:09] So they're gonna help me through this process, and some of you have already seen it before. We gave the same presentation, a very similar presentation to the Finance and Operations Committee last week. I'll share that much of this work that is done is guided by or even directed by policy.

[03:57:25] And so one of the things that the policy offers is that every year we must provide notice to any parent whose child's eligibility for transportation changes from one year to the next. In other words, you're eligible for a bus this year, you become in a walk zone the next year.

[03:57:42] By June 1st, we are obligated by policy to give that notice, which is why we're here in March to try to work through this process so we can get those notices out. Miss Austin will go through. There's been many notices up to this point so that folks know this is happening so it's not a surprise to them as well.

[03:58:00] I will say that this is also guided by policy where the policy requires us to vet this information through the appropriate committee of the board, which is the Finance and Operations Committee, meaning it's an operational decision, so the Finance Committee does not vote on that, neither of this board, but we started coming to the board a couple years ago knowing how important this issue is to everyone and everyone has to do that so we're providing it through the board by pop or through the committee by policy and then the board here for everyone's awareness so they can do that. I'll note that in the past it's been strictly for walk zones and the walk zones are the only thing that's really mentioned in the policy that with those timelines I

[03:58:39] just mentioned but we added the start times this year as an additional part because as you know the board just voted on some changes to attendance, own policy or attendance zones that affected the student enrollment at 14 of our elementary schools.

[03:58:55] And so we've challenged the staff to go and look at each of those attendance zone changes to see if they affected that so that we can make changes to the start times as well. And so that work has been

done at the same time. I'll also say that we consider this a partnership between us and the board, but also with the parents.

[03:59:14] One of the things that is part of that policy is we expect that partnership and for parents to have the responsibility to evaluating the safety of their child from their home to either the bus stop or to the school through that walk zone.

[03:59:29] So we are looking at all the things for that path for students to walk with the distance that's happening, but we're not making those decisions for each parent. We're asking the parents to participate in that as well. It is a challenge to go through some of these things, and we know that this year, with the walk zones in particular, we have special interest in making sure that we're looking very clearly at all those things.

[03:59:56] We know that the tragic accident that happens is fresh on everyone's mind, including our own. And so as folks went out and did these assessments, we had that in the forefront of our minds as well. I think I do want to do a little bit of history on the start times.

[04:00:13] Those of you that were not here at the time, 2022, we made the changes from what we called a three-tier system where all the elementary schools started at the same time, all middle and all high school. At the time, all the elementary schools, with the exception of a couple, started at 8.50.

[04:00:31] And so we moved some of the schools to 8 o'clock, or 7.50, sorry. We moved some of the schools to 8 o'clock, so we made them 10 minutes later, and we moved some to 7.30, 20 minutes earlier. After that, we made some more adjustments and changed some to 7.45, so the schools that are now 7.45, including the ones we'll talk about tonight, are only five minutes away from where they were three years ago when we started the change from the three tiers to the five tiers.

[04:00:57] We did find that the five tiers was very, very necessary to help us get kids from school because we were not providing the level of service that was expected by our parents or by ourselves. We were struggling to have school students delivered on time because there just was not a time, enough time between the routes.

[04:01:16] And so moving to that five tiers gave us that time to do that. And we've had a much improved on time ratio since then. And I think it's been a better service to most. So I'll also say in discussions with Mr. Chernoff, ask us to bring back some information.

[04:01:34] In that 2024, we did a study and a survey of parents of things. so I wanted to just bring a few slides back to show the results of that and you'll see here one of the scenarios we create a single tier going back to the original 7.50 and to be able to do that so that all elementary schools started again on time it was going to cost us 117 more drivers and routes and that equated to you know 27 million dollars keep in mind that's in 2024 numbers so that's two years old so these are the part of the reasons we went to the three

[04:02:08] the five tiers and split the elementary schools to be able to address part of the attendance or the driver shortage but also our on-time ratio was just not where we wanted it to be and the change we made which allowed us to get better at that. The other thing we did was look at what happens if we change having the elementary schools early and having the high schools early and so that also required us to add additional drivers and routes to do that and then it also adds some additional challenges in the afternoon because right now the high schools are the latest ones to get out they

[04:02:44] go directly into after school activities where if we were to move them to be earlier in the day so some of the buses we're using now for activities would then be using for middle school and high school so we would that's why you see the addition of more buses to be able to manage that that change we also did that survey to say ask parents what their opinions were if those things were changed and you see there the majority of the parents surveyed 57% supported the elementary school being first you see the other the other different

[04:03:19] combinations we had there but just sharing that also from the 2024 survey that we provided this slide is just here for awareness everybody knows that we're having some real crisis in our fuel costs you can see there in the period from March 6 to March 13th prices of and I'll just focus on gasoline the gray line went up 50 cents a gallon typically what we do is mr. Davies provides me every week a status of where we are on our fuel projections on how many miles we're driving and how much budget we have for that and we were we

[04:03:56] were in the in the positive for quite a while and then two or three weeks ago he said we're going to break even and now if this continues we will be short on money by the end of the year so we're hoping for a turnaround for that but just for awareness purposes we wanted the board to be aware that our fuel budget is in jeopardy right now if the fuel costs continue to go up the last thing I do before I'll say before I turn it over to miss Austin is I want to clarify a couple things you heard from some of the speakers this evening that we're making a change at J. Michael Lunsford middle school we're not proposing a change at lunchford this year that change was made last year and

[04:04:34] so some of those comments about the change being done this year so you're not gonna see a slide in there thanks to mr. pepper he brought this to our attention as well and ask us to look at that I know I went down several members of our team went down we studied the intersection we are looking at that intersections is performing well the students were very very good when they went across we were following all the things and so we'll find an intersection like that one in many places around the county and so we're not proposing changes for that for this year but I just want to clarify that does not a change that is happening this year that happened last year so you're not going to hear us

[04:05:09] talking about that other than acknowledging and um the fact that we've had some parents talk about mr pepper and i've had a number of conversations that we always appreciate uh when board members reach out and make sure that we're aware of things so we can we can address those as we go forward okay so at this point i will turn to miss austin and let her tell you all about the changes in the walk zones in school times for this coming year good evening good evening and sorry i gotta turn this on good evening and thank you mr lewis and mr davis for this opportunity i'm going to apologize ahead of time. Spring has sprung. Allergies are affecting me, so if Mr. Davis has to jump in

[04:05:46] because I start coughing, but I apologize in advance. So starting in October of every school year, my team of over 40 transportation staff, including lead drivers, area supervisors, coordinators, and our traffic and pedestrian specialists look at every walk zone. We apply school board policy 6210, where students at elementary schools may walk up to one mile, and secondary students may walk up to 1.25 miles.

[04:06:12] There is an exception of 0.1 and 0.2, respectfully, for those levels, and we have an example of that later in the presentation. We also communicate with our families on numerous occasions, letting them know the possible changes, and those dates are listed there.

[04:06:28] We also post our walk zone maps on the transportation website. All right, this table shows the results of our review. Cedar Lane will have 64 additional walkers due to an attendance zone change. Elaine Thompson will have 16 additional walkers because a path was built.

[04:06:49] Gum Spring will have 85 additional walkers due to an attendance zone change. Mill Run will also have 47 additional walkers due to an attendance zone change. And Madison's Trust will actually lose 248 walkers because of an attendance zone change. So once it all shakes out, we'll have about 36 additional students on buses next school year.

[04:07:10] All right, and this slide shows our crossing guards that we have at each level. As you can see, we have 42 crossing guards at 30 schools at the elementary level, 16 crossing guards at seven schools at the middle school level and none at the high school.

[04:07:28] Also, we have eight vacancies that are currently filled by the sheriff's deputies because those positions are so hard to fill. We are very grateful for the working relationship that we have with the manager of the crossing guard unit as well. She's very responsive to our request, and she's a pleasure to work with.

[04:07:48] All right, earlier I showed you a table of the effects of our review. This is Cedar Lane, and the yellow highlighted area will now walk to Cedar Lane. This is due to an attendance zone change. Next map is Elaine Thompson.

[04:08:06] The yellow highlighted area will walk to Elaine Thompson. That is due to a path, and there is a picture of the path down there on the left. Gum Spring Middle School, the yellow highlighted area will now walk to Gum Spring.

[04:08:24] This is the example of the exception. Just past the 1.25, we have two areas there circled. There's about five houses in those two circled areas. This is an example of the exception where we're capturing just a few houses at the end of a road or a cul-de-sac and incorporating them into the walk zone.

[04:08:41] And Mr. Pepper brought to our attention that there's possible construction in that area coming soon, so we are keeping an eye out on that. And if necessary, temporary bus stops may be necessary if construction is inhibiting walking to school. All right, this is Madison's Trust.

[04:09:01] The circled area used to walk or does walk to Madison's Trust this year. Next year they will not. They will be bused to Legacy. This is due to an attendance zone change. And Mill Run finally has an additional walk zone there, highlighted in yellow, and those students will walk to Mill Run.

[04:09:18] This is due to an attendance zone change. And just for reference, students will be using a tunnel, but there is the path there as well that shows getting them to the school. Switching gears to bell times. So we evaluated the start times of our elementary schools recently, rezoned, to see if we could push those bell times later and what impact that would have on our resources.

[04:09:44] The question has also come up about rotating early and late elementary schools every other year or every couple of years to kind of spread out the early start times. We also looked at on-time performances. We're having an Eagle Ridge, and we'll go over our current driver shortage.

[04:10:01] So the good news, Cedar Lane can be moved to 745 start time with no impact on resources. Stuart Weller can be moved to 745 with only one additional bus needed there. And Watson Mountain and Eagle Ridge can swap bell times so that we can improve our on-time performance at Eagle Ridge.

[04:10:20] All righty, so what did we do? This table shows how many schools we currently have at each bell time. This year you'll see that we have 21 elementary schools at the 7.30 bell time. Next year it will be 19, and then you can go on down the chart, so on and so forth.

[04:10:39] But that's where you see the most change there. Our routing and operations teams looked at the rezoned elementary attendance zones. They adjusted the bell times. They recalculated the bus runs to confirm that those follow-on trips would still work or if additional resources would be needed.

[04:11:01] And we obviously found that additional resources are gonna be needed. This is an example of a time change that will work next year. This is Cedar Lane. For a bus to be on time to school, it must arrive between 20 and five minutes before the bell.

[04:11:21] This gives students time to eat breakfast, settle into their classrooms to start instruction, all before the bell ringing the blue box shows the length of the run so it's 6 50 this school this year students started getting on the bus and so this is a 20 minute bus run we arrive at the school around 7 10 we have about 36 minutes before we have to start the next run which is uh another this this actually was paired with an early middle school which is why there's so much time in between so we actually use these buses to help cover for call-outs on mornings where like last-minute call-outs they're able to kind of go and help us grab

[04:12:00] some kids get them to school if not on time then just a few minutes late in the second timeline there but we start Cedar Lane 15 minutes later students getting on the bus at 7:05 instead of 6:50 and you'll see that this shrinks our standby time so our buses won't be able to do as much covering for early or late last-minute call-outs, but it will give us some time to cover runs for last-minute call-outs.

[04:12:31] This slide is an example of a time change that will not work. Again, for bus runs to be on time, we need to arrive 20 to 5 minutes before the bell. So as you can see, this year we have 19 minutes between the early elementary school and the late elementary school. And as we all know, our experience has told us is that traffic congestion in and around school campuses really slow down travel and those 19 minutes are really dwindled down to just a few that's why it's working this year next next year next year or if we moved this this school by 15 minutes we only

[04:13:08] have four minutes between uh runs and on paper that looks like it might work but again traffic congestion in and around school campuses will just eat up all of that time we won't we will not we will be late this will not work all righty we have had on-time performance issues at eagle ridge The buses arriving late serve Watson Mountain first, and their traffic congestion as well is an issue.

[04:13:36] We've worked with VDOT on the traffic light to be adjusted as much as possible, but it's not solving the issue. So swapping start times between those two schools is essential to getting that on-time performance issue at Eagle Ridge to be fixed. The question has been asked, can we flip early and late elementary times typically every other year or every couple of years to kind of spread that around.

[04:14:04] Our concern is that it will affect parents and students. They get into routines just as we all do. Parent work schedules would be affected. Child and daycare would be affected. We found that we know that some daycares actually pair. They have a vehicle that goes to different schools and picks up kids, and they pair them just like we do with our buses, so that would not work anymore.

[04:14:25] Student sleep schedules would be disrupted, and we believe that overall there would be dissatisfaction with flipping bell times every year, every other year. As Mr. Lewis mentioned, in 2022, we

changed to a five-tier bell time, and this was to adjust on-time performance issues, massive second loads, and a driver shortage.

[04:14:50] So by adjusting to the five-tier, we decreased from 115-second loads to 8-second loads, and we decreased our requirement for drivers by 35. But we did go back and adjust some of our elementary school times to a little bit later, And that increased our driver need by 12.

[04:15:08] So if we continue to adjust fail times, our driver need will continue to increase. So by adjusting all six schools, we would need 11 drivers. And that 946,000 is a big number. Our driver statistics, as of today, we're actually back to 32.

[04:15:31] The other week we were 34. So we're back to 32 drivers short. So how do we fix that? our supervisors are driving, and they're driving almost every day to fill in that gap, which means they're not available to help our drivers when they're in need. This slide shows our new hires and resignations over the last four years. Some years have been trim years, some years have been a little better. In 22-23, you'll see that we hired 29 fewer than retired or left us.

[04:16:03] In 23-24, we broke even. In 24-25, we were doing a good job. We had 12 additional than left us, and this year is turning out to be a trim year right so far we've had we've hired seven fewer than have left us the lack of qualified school bus drivers is an industry-wide issue our recruitment and retention stats as you can see we had 391 applicants between october of 2024 september of 2025 which sounds like a lot but as as they work through the through the system and through the

[04:16:41] requirements. We only had 56 come out and take a bus run and also I want to bring to your attention during that same time frame we had 62 resignations or retires in that time frame or left us for some reason. Alrighty, so recruitment and retention. We are very grateful for the working relationship that we have with HRTD and DCE. HRTD works diligently to attend job fairs, host one-stop shops and stay in touch with our applicants. They work side-by-side our

[04:17:17] training department. DCE is advertised on every platform that we can think of and we greatly appreciate their time helping us find drivers. We offer a \$1,000 referral bonus to any LCPS employee that recommends a driver that is successful and we also have a \$2,500 sign-on bonus for any driver that is successful. School bus drivers have split shifts so they work a few hours to take a break and they work a few more hours so the responsibility of operating a 40 foot school bus in Loudoun County and all that entails is actually a huge deal. So the good news again, Cedar Lane can be moved to 745 with no impact on our

[04:17:55] resources. Stewart Weller can be moved to 745 with only one bus needed additional and Watson Mountain and Eagle Ridge we will swap through bell times to improve on-time performance at Eagle Ridge. And then one last thing a reminder which I don't need to remind you, attendance zones are always possibly changing. All secondary attendance zones and all their elementary school attendance zones will be reevaluated which could affect bell times and walk zones and then one other thing we've been working with the sheriff's office to get stop-arm cameras on school buses a local ordinance is needed for for drivers to be ticketed

[04:18:34] for running red lights on school buses and so that's still being worked on it right now and I'll add that last night we had a joint committee of the school board and board of supervisors and the sheriff's department came and gave us an update on that and they're they're working on that process and so we

have a true partner there and we're hoping that's going to be something we can get in place in the next short period of time I mean it's going to take a while we have 700 buses to add that equipment to so it take a while to do that but we're both committed to getting that work done the last thing I'll share is one of the reasons that I asked Ms. Austin to be here is some of you that visited over the transportation department

[04:19:13] I've often referred to the logistical wizards over there, and Ms. Alston is the ringleader of that with Mr. Davies' guidance and direction. And so one of the things I just wanted to be able to share is we really took that seriously.

[04:19:29] We looked at these school times as close as we possibly could with all the constraints we have, and we believe we have a plan. We're going to continue to work on that. As you all continue to make a sentence on changes, we'll be able to make changes with that. and one thing to keep in mind in the fall of 2028 when the new high school opens we're redoing all the secondary boundaries and so that will make a big change that'll be a huge change for them and so we're going to make incremental changes between now and then and then I think in that fall of 28 it'll give us an opportunity to really look at everything and make some more hopefully some more significant changes that that folks are able to support and so well like I said we're going to

[04:20:08] keep picking at it between now and then and then when that comes we'll have a pretty significant change I believe so with that we're happy to take any questions you may have and thank you so much to your team for the presentation this item is for information only so no action by the school board is required but board members is there any discussion or do you have any questions by sure Donahue thank you madam chair thank you mr. Lewis and miss Austin for the presentation and for everything that you do to support our students and our community um i i have i'm very appreciative of everything that all of y'all do i'm very

[04:20:48] appreciative of your team um but i i i have to again bring up the 7 30 start times um i have similar to ms chernoff i have been asking about the early start times for the entire two years i've been on the board and initially when i was asking two years ago how many schools are there how many people are affected by this, I was told it's only a handful of schools and it's only in Leesburg. And that is clearly not the case. It is 19, 21 schools, and they're in different parts

[04:21:26] of the county. So it does affect a significant number of families. When my 12-year-old started kindergarten before COVID, we were one of those families. Our school had a very, I know it was a different system then, but our school had a very early start time. I was getting my kid, waking him up before six o'clock every morning and putting him on the bus in the dark, like pretty much all school year. So I feel the pain of our families that are still struggling with those really early start times. And I, I'm not advocating for an annual flip one way or the other, but you

[04:22:01] know, we have, we've asked and asked and asked how we fix this. How do we get away from having any 7.30 start times. There has to be a way. I don't know if that's moving the entire schedule later so that no schools are starting before 8 a.m. or before 7.45 a.m. I don't know if that's keeping the five or seven tier system but starting with high school first which I understand was not the highest response getter in the survey from last year but it was 20 percent of your respondents and that is

[04:22:34] not an insignificant number of those respondents, and I'm not insensitive to the issues of driver shortages and logistics, but, and I am appreciative for the progress that you all have been working towards and making, but I am a little disappointed and frustrated that we are still having this conversation

ongoing um two years in where we're still talking about how do we provide relief to these families that have the 7 30 start times how are we going to fix this for them i don't

[04:23:12] necessarily expect you to have an answer right now uh because i know it's been an ongoing discussion um and i am grateful for everything you do thank you ms donahue i will say that that's one of the reasons and i appreciate ms shurnoff reminding us that that was something we could bring back when look at that in 2024 we solve that with 117 more drivers and so from a budgetary perspective if that's something the board wanted to provide guidance to do then we would have to add that to the budget and then try to find some way to do to hire 117 more drivers that number may slightly

[04:23:46] change this year based on those numbers but the or we go back to what we had before which was 115 i think the number was of second loads and that is just not a good level of service and everyone suffers from that and that's how we were managing that process in the past it's just not an acceptable way to do that and so that's a solution to do that it would require a pretty significant budget lift but then also how do we hire that many drivers as you saw we're already 34 short and last year was i think the first year we actually broke even for a while and we're fully

[04:24:21] staffed and every time we have um our lead drivers and our supervisors driving buses during the routes then they are not there to support others if we have a breakdown or an accident and those positions are critical to manage those types of things and so if those folks are driving a bus then they're not available to do that and so that gives us a great concern about safety with that as well so there are ways to do that unfortunately they cost a significant amount of money thank you um mrs

[04:24:54] griffiths um we all represent our different districts i've mentioned that before um my concern is only uh well i just want to confirm cedar lane you basically said that um these are adjustments so they were 650 pickup and now they're going to switch to 705 and after i i i think that's much better uh for the cedar lane group um so i just wanted to confirm that um I haven't heard anything, but I just wanted to confirm that that's where we are with Cedar Lane.

[04:25:30] Thank you. So I'll just clarify that they went from 7.30 start time to 7.45. The example we showed there of that one bus was one bus just to give the example. So not all those buses would start at 6.50 or 7.05. And so those routes will be all developed over the summer and rolled out this spring, I mean this fall, but it will be very close to what you just said.

[04:25:53] So it may not be exactly that. Thank you very much. Mr. Pepper. Thank you, Madam Chair. I'm going to say this just so it's out in public record. Based on policy 6210, the school board is not going to vote on these at all. They are just what you say goes. We have given you the authority of the purview to do these changes. I just want to make that very clear so that everyone knows that, even though we try to help as many people as we possibly can. And so I appreciate the work you guys, let me begin by saying I appreciate the work you guys does. This is a tremendous undertaking of logistics and timing and all all sorts of other things i want to clarify a few things that that were said tonight one um

[04:26:30] stewart weller i know we talked about this in finance and operations but just so everyone knows you did add one bus to stewart weller to make the times work is that correct and the only reason i believe i believe that they could not go to the eight o'clock was because we needed two additional buses in the afternoon is that yeah we're able to make it work for the morning but not for the afternoon okay so we're a few buses short on some of these schools um i i do have a couple concerns I said this as well but I

want everyone to know I appreciate you bringing up the concern about that one walk zone that was the new gum spring walk zone I actually walked it yesterday because I wanted to see what it was I

[04:27:04] may have had a dog with me but there I am concerned there's one side of destiny drive the sidewalk is not continuous so in order to actually walk it the students would either have to cut through a bunch of neighborhood streets that are town homey and very hard to see around bushes and corners if they do cross destiny there are absolutely no crosswalks until you get the intersection of Mineral Springs it's a very tough walk and also a very long walk for a lot of these people who have to go around the curb up the curb so I'm very concerned about that walk so and I'm going to reiterate that again and I also want to reiterate in addition I would love I know that Lunsford wasn't up for consideration but

[04:27:42] I appreciate and I want folks to know that you guys did come out all you drove it you looked at the intersections you saw what was happening I know it's never easy there are some hills and some crazy snakes through neighborhoods one of the other things I would really love and to advocate for and I drive Braddock Road every day because it is it is fast there is a school speed zone that is 25 it doesn't blink for very long and I will be lucky as finding a four-leaf clover if I can find someone who's actually going 25 in that school zone because I mean I I'm not gonna say anything but I'm probably guilty of not going 25 and I know

[04:28:21] better um but I always drive the speed limit um but um but we we really need to think about putting something in place like they have in the town of Leesburg or um Fairfax County has further down Braddock where if we had speed cameras I would feel a lot better about our students crossing um that road and that intersection particularly without a crossing I personally know they have to go through Cardinal Ridge if they go to the Donovan intersection so I am I do have my concerns about that as well um so just want to put that out there but also want to thank you I know

[04:28:52] You guys are trying your darndest and it is really hard to get bus drivers and I appreciate that reminder about the the traffic on Braddock Road We did last night that the Joint Committee the Sheriff's Department Is all in on partnership with this stop arm cameras, but they did also say that they were not at this point planning on Deploying the the speed zone cameras there But one of the things we can certainly reach out to them and let them know that we have concerns about the speed there and ask them to come down and do some traffic monitoring and help us with that.

[04:29:25] We can do that. Thank you. Dr. Rasheed. Thank you, Chair. Just, I forgot, I remember in 2024 we discussed some data about some of the buses we're sending out of Loudoun County. I just wanted to make sure that we know, are we increasing the number of buses?

[04:29:44] Or I think from the best of our conversation, the buses were staying, I think, stagnant every year. I didn't think we were increasing enrollment to going to TJ. so that was my only concern that we're just staying at one level we're not increasing buses to go there because we're not increasing enrollment I'm going to ask either this also or Mr. Davies to help me with that but over the past several years we've changed the number of buses that have been going to TJ based on the number of kids there or where they're located and where their hub stops are because we picked those students up at a hub at one of the high

[04:30:21] schools but I think maybe it went from six to eight over the last couple of years and so it hasn't been a big change but over the past couple years we've changed two of those there are a number of other buses that go out of the county for other special programs though is it 27 students to or to a bus or I forgot

how many students just for my own curiosity how many students go into one bus approximately each bus about is about 50 to 54 students right okay thank you mr. Spenson thanks madam chair and thank you for the presentation I really

[04:30:59] appreciate the work that you that clearly the amount of detail you all have to put into this um it's impressive um so i wanted to ask about um walk zones in terms of how are all the walk zones that you are able to implement put into place is there and and to the extent there's a neighborhood that is within the walk zone radius to a school and it's not a walk zone is that because there needs to be infrastructure improvements in order to make it walkable for for the students and I just wanted to understand a little bit more about how you all evaluate that process for each school just because we are short on bus

[04:31:36] drivers to minimize the amount of buses we need we want to be a maximizing the walk zones I'm just curious kind of what barriers there are for you all when maximizing the walk zones so yes sir and I may need a little bit help with this as well but generally speaking every year we start looking at every school again and look for opportunities to where we can expand that walk so one example tonight was we had a path going to Elaine Thompson so we were able to expand that walk so so miss Olsen and her team goes out and looks for opportunities like that in every place it includes looking at the infrastructure what is there what you know safety issues if there anything the

[04:32:15] construction if we have a construction project move in or or finish you know sometimes we provide buses until the construction is finished and we we put them in the walk zone because they're within that distance but we are looking every year to see what we can expand, and there's a myriad of things that keeps it from that.

[04:32:32] The regulation 6210 also shows some of that criteria, like what speed limit a student at elementary or secondary level could walk beside or walk across, and those types of things are there to give us guidance on how we come up with where those things can be. Thank you, that's helpful, and I know there's been a lot of development, you know, I'm thinking about Stuart Weller for instance, there's a lot of development in One Loudon and that area, and I imagine along with that development sometimes there are infrastructure improvements to make it possible for students to get around to to Stewart well or other other schools in the area so I'm curious have there been any improvements on that front and is

[04:33:10] there something that we as a school board can do to help you know communicate with the Board of Supervisors about particular projects that would not just at Stewart Weller but across the county are there places where hey if we could make this crosswalk or build this tunnel or do XYZ this would enable us to get 40 more 50 more kids to school via walking as opposed to a bus I'm just curious for that particular area if there's been improvements or if there are other places in the county where we could be helpful to you all in getting infrastructure improvements to expand walking yes sir that's an excellent

[04:33:48] question I appreciate the opportunity and we just had the board of supervisors school board joint committee meeting last night and that is one of the standing items on that agenda is looking for things and my staff works with the county staff who is tasked with building these infrastructure things and so we look for opportunities to do that so anybody that sees one that we may not have noticed let us know and we can add that to the list and have that be you know have asked that to be a part of the priority list for the county staff and their infrastructure projects Mr. Chernoff thank you madam chair and thank

[04:34:26] you team I appreciate you we've spent countless hours together behind the scenes meeting and going over this data and asking lots of questions and I really appreciate it I share Miss Donahue's

enthusiasm with continuing to tackle this I don't want this to be a period end of story I definitely want it to be a continued dialogue and that's going to be one of my questions at the end but I also through a lot of this work with you all I've come to some new understandings that brought me to a different place in terms of addressing

[04:35:00] some of the solutions and I think really for me what this boils down to is drivers I mean I feel like it's like call your friends call your friends friends fine go we have to go find some people to drive buses and we need to find people that can get us through the process when I see the number 391 with an outcome of negative six input output I mean the math is not good so that's a struggle so there's process things what's also come to my attention is just how much we're pulling from supervisors and things to drive buses which is

[04:35:38] something nobody sees and so all those loose ends of should something go wrong where those people would stand in the gap now we have gaps there and so I think think as a system right now until we get more drivers we're just not going to be able to solve it I personally am not a proponent of going back to second loads we heard constantly about behavior issues and inequities and teachers that had to manage those duties of second load and all the different things that went with that so I understand that that could be something we go back to but I don't know that that's viable and so and I I you know we've been hearing about this since we got

[04:36:16] on the board and we've made adjustments and I'm very grateful. When I hear people saying like well we just need one more bus to make our time work you really need one plus 32 because we're 32 short to even run the system right now. So I think like that's a lot of people and so I mean it's certainly a higher number than what we're we get a weekly update you know that's pretty high. So I just want to make sure that people understand we keep revisiting this we keep talking about it. I trust the team. I see the work, the logistics. I've seen as much data, I think, as one person possibly can

[04:36:51] see about trends and drivers and what we can do. And I know we're doing everything we can with HR, too. So I want to reassure the public, like, I actually think it's quite something that we're getting these changes that you're updating. And my families in Leesburg have been very pleased with the 745. I know that's not a consolation. I know 15 minutes doesn't feel like enough when eight o'clock exists for others I get it it was a huge struggle for our Catoctin families in Leesburg but they are very much appreciative of having that time back so I'm hopeful that we can

[04:37:27] continue to chip away on this my question is I know you do an update on walk zones would it be is it going to need to be school board initiated to continue to revisit these start time conversations or is that something that we could, as best practice, continue to have updates on?

[04:37:45] Because, I mean, certainly for me, I think others maybe share those views based off of what I've heard tonight. I appreciate you tucking it in tonight, but I would like to get regular updates on this just to have a pulse on where we're at and what we're trying, particularly in tandem with rezoning and with our CTE expansion, because I think that that's going to have impact on possible hub situations as well.

[04:38:07] So I feel like start times could be something that could would be beneficial to us as a board And maybe we have that conversation offline Later, but I would appreciate having more updates just so that it's in a consistent cycle Absolutely. We agree that it's something that's we are going to constantly address and the board needs to be updated So we would we would just assume to add those and have that That's one of

the reason we named it to the mid-year transportation update instead of walks in review because we want to make sure that the the citizens didn't look at that and not

[04:38:43] realize the walk zones and and the the school start times was a part of that and miss that opportunity to come and hear the conversation so we will definitely include it here moving forward every time we talk about the walk zones would we would do that as well yeah and I'd appreciate us circling back on it also through the budget process I mean that is a lever we can pull it's expensive I I know that, but it's at least still on my radar to consider if it's worth the investment to give our families some relief.

[04:39:12] Thank you. Ms. Riccardi. Thank you, Madam Chair. I think that if we were kind of just step back and look at this in a big picture strategic way, and I'm not going to say even pie in the sky, but if we were to look at this in a kind of a big picture or innovative way, are there things that you all have identified that we could do to help recruit more bus drivers that we're not doing now that would be either innovative or different or completely out of the box in order for us to help fill those gaps and then and if so how can we help support that i feel like this is one of those things that we need to you know like i've been pushing with the el teachers and title one teacher

[04:39:52] i feel like we need to do like a little bit of extra to time money energy effort whatever we've got to do to kind of get us over the hump to have not only all of our bus drivers but continually you know i'm sure you're continually recruiting but make sure that we've got that pipeline of people so that we're addressing the turnover numbers as well and getting ahead of this and so I guess I'd ask you guys is there something that we can do in an innovative way in order to kind of get ahead of that so we're always looking for those innovative ways and one of the things we did a few years ago and Miss Bolin and her team and HRTD provided us these one-stop shops where

[04:40:29] they come with us to our recruiting events so that we don't lose people in the I'm interested in being a bus driver and we never get their paperwork in the mail where they're able to do all that paperwork right there at that dock and so we don't lose track of those folks we do advertise for that we work with DCE and they help us a tremendous amount but you know one of the most effective things for just about anything like that is word of mouth so the more you talk about it the more we get that word out there Ms. Alston mentioned we have a driver recruitment bonus and so bus drivers talking to other folks they know and so you know teachers talking to people they know anybody in

[04:41:07] the system and can can get that word of mouth out there probably it would be as effective as anything are we paying a referral bonus for that yes how much are we paying thousand dollars can we increase that would that help that would be I mean we got permission from the board to do that so we can certainly propose that the drop in the bucket that an extra five hundred dollars in order to get I don't know what the number is right I don't know what the magic number is and I'm not suggesting it be enormous but we've got to do something to be able to get ahead of this and again we've been dealing with this issue for a long time so these for these really hard to recruit positions that are systemic

[04:41:45] that impact the system right just getting our kids to school I feel like we need to do something more and different and I don't know I mean I'm sure other districts across the country and divisions across the country have the same issues I'd be really curious and I'm sure you guys have done some research but I'd be really curious what innovative things are being done across the country to help close those gaps. If it's more money for bonuses, I mean, we have a pretty significant budget, but I don't know. I think there's

just, we need to take a really good look at that. And we're happy to dig into that and come back to the board with some ideas for moving

[04:42:18] forward with that. Ms. LaBelle. Thank you, Madam Chair. Mr. Lewis, do we do any sort of survey or have any information about why people leave, they start the program, and then they drop out? Because it always looks like we have more than enough when you first start your classes, and then the attrition just keeps going down.

[04:42:43] Has any research been done that way as to why they're leaving? Yes, we're currently reviewing that information with HRTD, and we'll provide some statistics when we get all that assembled. It is, it's not an easy job. And so it's a big piece of machinery that folks have to manage, and so sometimes that is more than what people want.

[04:43:05] a challenge to do those types of things and and it's a required split shift so you come in early and you have downtime in the middle of the day and then you have come back for the second half of the day and so there are challenges to that it makes it hard to recruit for but certainly we want to understand to why people leave us and so we're looking at that right now and we'll put that together with some more recruitment things and come back to the board with some data for that okay thank you yep this is Griffiths Thank you, Madam Chair.

[04:43:36] I forgot to ask you before, with Cedar Lane, you know, we had the rezoning with Sanders. So if you can just tell me real quick, are we providing buses to the ones that were redistricted for Cedar Lane? Or are they just walk-zoned?

[04:43:51] And if I missed it, forgive me. I was just trying to understand where Sanders would fall in these start times. I mean, the people that used to go to Sanders. If they weren't on the chart, then they're... getting bus service.

[04:44:07] - Oh, what page, what slide is that? - So I think to answer your question accurately, we're gonna have to look at the attendance zone change and see all the neighborhoods that were changed from one school to the other, and then which ones are in that walk zone. So what Ms. Austin was saying, if they're not in that yellow, they're getting bus service, but we can't answer your question right now as to how many of those, but we can certainly get that information and provide it.

[04:44:29] - Thank you very much. - Any further questions? All right, thank you so much for the presentation. All right, with that, we'll move on to our information item number 13.03, the creation of a select committee of the school board for the memorandum of understanding between LCPS, LCSO, and LPD.

[04:44:51] For this item I'll be presenting, I believe a select committee of the school board will help address the issue of safety and security within our schools by allowing the school board to engage in oversight of the MOU negotiations along and among LCPS, LCSO, and LPD to ensure a timely and transparent MOU process.

[04:45:14] I believe this is the logical continuation of the discussion to meet the requirements of the conversation and commitment that we made to the community. And I also want to sort of revisit, I know for myself, when the MOU came up last year as a school board member, I was surprised by the process.

[04:45:35] And when we put out the revisions for public feedback, we heard a great deal from the community. There was a lot of parent and parent committee and community feedback. And it's my hope that by engaging in a select committee and having the negotiations in an open meeting, that we can allow for more transparency in the process and better understanding within the community.

[04:46:02] So with that, this is an information item I hope-- my hope is to create a select committee that will work in some ways, like the select committee on retiree health benefits that occurred last year, and like the very early in our term committee on collective bargaining.

[04:46:19] So I would foresee four school board members as part of the negotiating team with LCPS and the negotiating teams from LCSO and LPD. So with that, I'll ask the board if you have any questions comments. Mr. Pepper? Thank you, Madam Chair. I do feel like this is a continuation of what we kind of set forth in our meeting. My question is, do you envision any other representatives from LCPS, such as members of MSAC or SEAC, as part of this team? Not initially, because I think we

[04:46:54] have the responsibility for negotiating the legal terms, but it would be an open meeting, so there would be public comment which would be a way that we could engage and I would also imagine that we would have the opportunity to ask for feedback in the same way that our other committees do thank you thank you Riccardi thank you madam chair I'd love to kind of hear your thoughts about a charter because one of the things I don't want to see is this you know I starting this you know we've had other initiatives where we wanted to do focus groups and other

[04:47:34] kinds of things and that they never you know were seen to fruition so I would love to see an actual charter the actual purpose of the group what the outcome is going to be a definitive timeline I'd like to see who the members are going to be on this committee I mean I think we need to give this select committee a very tight framework so that it's not you know super loose if we're gonna have public comment periods that's great I think it's a great way to hear from the community, but I think we've got to make sure that this is a very tightly crafted, and there's got to be some real, it's very tightly crafted, and it's very clear about what the purpose and

[04:48:12] outcomes are here, and not necessarily what they're going to, not the decisions they're going to come to, but that we've got to get this really clear. But I also have some concerns about the fact that, you know, the negotiating process is really between our administrative staff and the Sheriff's Office and the Leesburg Police Department, and I am really, I get really nervous about having, you know, political people involved in a what would normally be a professional contract negotiation. I mean, I think part of this is if they're not acting, working fast enough or whatever, I think that's a really clear purview for us. But I'm gonna tell you, I'm very skeptical of any of us getting

[04:48:52] involved in that negotiation piece from anything more than kind of an advisory perspective I get that maybe we want to have a clear understanding of what's going on and help move a timeline along perhaps but you're gonna have to really sell me on this one thank you madam chair I'm grateful to hear you say it would be more modeled similarly to the select committee we had for retiree benefits because similarly that was not really the school board's expertise and playground but we did want to know more we wanted to learn more we wanted to

[04:49:30] understand so that we could make more informed decisions and I would kind of view this similarly. I do think having sort of an outline or structure presented before we vote would probably be helpful in terms of what we want the scope to be. I think we promised a dialogue through the motion

that was voted on by a majority so I think this is a way to continue the dialogue. I hope that diverse perspectives will be represented and I hope that collaboration with the staff and with the sheriff's department and leesburg police will be involved in collaborating around what those topics might look like so I'm

[04:50:06] hopeful for a collaborative move forward I will likely be supporting the discussion to move forward but I don't think it would hurt it for us to kind of outline what we would like the scope to look like over the next year thank you any further discussion mr. Riccardi thank you so much so you know I'd also like to add to I mean it's we've gotten I've gotten a lot of feedback I've had a chance to talk to all my principals tons of parents in not only Sterling but around the county and we've seen kind of unofficial surveys there was one in

[04:50:44] loud and now there's a real strong support and we've you know we've got gentlemen here tonight from you know from our community that are you know really supporting this process so my hope would be that in this process whomever winds up sitting on this will really put aside their political interests and really focus on listening to the majority and the mainstream parts of our county and listen to what the public actually wants.

[04:51:14] So I would really encourage that whomever it is that's going to be on it, that makeup is made up of people that are really tuned in and dialed in to the community, not certain aspects of certain parts of our community, but the community as a whole, and/or that we perhaps start collecting some, doing a quick survey of our entire population, not just LCPS parents, but just the county as a whole.

[04:51:38] I think we've got to get some more data and more information, but I also am really concerned about making sure that this does not turn into a political circus and this is actually a representation of what the people in Loudoun County actually want. - Thank you. - Mrs. Griffiths.

[04:51:54] - Considering there have been conflicts of interest in the past with committees, and if this is community members, I personally am all for vetting anybody that goes on this committee, if they are community members, just to make sure there are no conflicts of interest because I am seeing that constantly.

[04:52:16] So I'm with Ms. Riccardi. I'd like to see a full charter. I'd like to see. I want to add vetting to people that go on these committees because I'm seeing a lot of people, the same people. It's been repetitive put on these committees, and I don't think a lot of them reflect the overall community.

[04:52:37] And that has been a problem for me, and I have voiced that here many times. Thank you. As a point of clarification at this time, I'm only discussing adding school board members to this committee. Mr. Pepper, any further discussion?

[04:52:57] Ms. LaBelle. How many board members would be on this committee? Four. Thank you. Dr. Rasheed. For the last MOU, I just wanted to ask what the process was, and was it similar like this?

[04:53:22] I would ask Ms. Mitchell if you would like to speak to the process or anyone else, Dr. Bergen. I'm going to have Ms. Boland because she actually did the last finalized draft of the MOU.

[04:53:40] Thank you, Ms. Mitchell. Thank you, Chair Chandler. The previous process, we worked with both LCSO and LPD. We had an internal committee where members from Loudoun County Public Schools, from the Sheriff's Office, and from Leesburg PD all came together at specific periods of time.

[04:54:08] We had a facilitator from the Department of Teaching and Learning come in so that each member could actively participate in the sessions. We had an agenda. We worked through them. The priority at the time for that MOU was adding Title IX investigations.

[04:54:30] So that was our primary focus in getting something into the MOU that would involve some type of coordination between the school system and law enforcement in regards to Title IX investigations and not re-traumatizing victims for interviews. Outside of that, the process really was we all had to come to agreeable terms.

[04:55:01] Once we came to an agreement, the MOU went before the superintendent for Loudoun County, and it went before chair chapman and i believe um and i don't remember his rank but uh it was brown for the leesburg pd chief brown thank you um and once everyone agreed upon it then it came before the school board but it wasn't a formal committee it came before the full school board for uh

[04:55:31] approval thank you for that clarification and miss ricardi thank you so much could um could somebody let me just let us know kind of where do we stand right now I know I was at a joint meeting in the fall with the Board of Supervisors and it was a pretty long meeting where we were talking about this where where do we stand right now and and I don't need you to get into this if there's confidential so I don't need to get into that stuff I just want to understand kind of where are we right now I know the last contract ended last year but we maintain it until we get a new one I think if somebody could just if I'm wrong please clarify but could somebody just clue me in on where we stand right

[04:56:11] now on that? I can answer that question, Ms. Riccardi. So after that, I believe it was November meeting, we got that feedback. We crossed referenced it with some of the other committee feedbacks such as MSAC and SEAC. We had a meeting on the 18th with representation from LCPS, LCSO, and LPD to discuss that feedback. We made corresponding edits to the MOU during that meeting, and we have one additional section to review so is that the 18th of this month yes ma'am okay so you just had

[04:56:50] it okay yes okay so there's just one more edit one more set of edits that you all need to make um we we made some edits to the document there's one more section that we did not get to um that we do have to review um that's probably a more substantive part of the mou um and then a few other pieces based on that joint committee feedback but in terms of the mou in and of itself there is a big section that we need to discuss so is it have to have another meeting okay so is it

[04:57:25] fair to say that by creating this select committee we're going to be coming in and kind of sticking our hand in a pot towards the end of the process well unless there could be members that want to look at the changes that have been made an opportunity to explain those changes what might be some feedback gathered so that we can explain what was incorporated why it can't be incorporated things of that nature could we ask for when we get when we do this at the next meeting can we ask for a kind of a status report on

[04:58:04] where we're at for the next board meeting yeah because well this I mean in theory this would in theory go to action if we choose to do so and it'd be really not. Here's the thing I don't want to have us to do. I don't want us mucking up a process when we're almost already done with it, right? It's one thing if we're coming in to a process and it's kind of towards the beginning of the process. It's a whole other thing if we're at the tail end and now you're going to stick four politicians in the mix. I'm sure there's a like a joke around that somewhere. I don't want us doing that. So I guess my question is is of a hundred percent complete, are we at 80? Are we at 60? Are we at 40? I mean

[04:58:41] Where do you think we are in that process already? Honestly, it's hard to say with a percentage where we are. I could provide, and that might be something we could maybe not do publicly just because of the information that's in the MOU, where we are as a result of the meeting on the 18th and what changes we discussed and incorporated and what we have left to do.

[04:59:13] But it's unsure to say because that additional part of it that we have to discuss, again, includes feedback from other stakeholders. And it could be that other members want to provide feedback.

[04:59:32] So it's hard to say, oh, we could get it done in one more meeting. I don't know the answer to that, how much we could get done at that time. because it still has to go through several approval steps. Yeah, I understand the approval steps, but I'm just talking about the negotiation process.

[04:59:51] I'm just trying to really kind of wrap my head around, you know, kind of of the timeline of the negotiation process. We're not at the beginning, but we're not done, so we're somewhere in the middle. And I'm not going to put you on the spot about kind of percentage-wise, but again, I'm going to get real nervous if we have a select committee.

[05:00:10] we've already negotiated all these things everybody's agreed to it and then we just drop four of us into this process towards the tail end and have it unravel the rest of it so I think that's just my my concern in the process and I just want to make sure that we're not doing that I'd rather us be looking at it at the end like we're supposed to as a board and approve it or discuss it and debate it whatever but I don't I'm just really nervous about you know as an executive I try really hard to stay out of my employees wheelhouses and not get in there especially at the end of it and drop bombs and that's my what my thing

[05:00:46] I'm trying to make sure we don't do thank you vice chair Donahue thank you madam chair I recall seeing a version of the MOU about this time last spring when it was in the process of being worked on and at that time my personal feeling not speaking for anyone else who is or was on this dais was there were a lot of terms that I had significant questions and or concerns about and I was able to discuss

[05:01:19] those in some meetings with some individuals and addressed some of my concerns but not others so I'm bringing this up in response to one of Ms. McCarty's points and encouraging you to consider looking at it from the other perspective which is that if the negotiators go to all this time an effort and get everyone else to agree on an agreement and bring it to us and there are provisions in it that are unacceptable to certain members of this board and it cannot get approval

[05:01:52] then we've wasted their time and I would like to avoid that. Thank you. Thank you. Ms. Riccardi. Thank you. I just kind of respond to that. I think the parties that are doing that my problem is with that premise is just the simple fact that we're now put that that's required what that does is it takes people that are doing the effort coming to an end game and then coming back to the board and for political reasons undoing the work of the staff and I'm just not going to do

[05:02:30] that these are the professionals that know what's going on and are the ones that are in the thick of what needs to happen and I'm not willing to turn the SRO issue into a political mess up here on the dais when they've already come to an agreement if you know if and when they do come to an agreement that they've that they've done so if if we want to share those viewpoints with the staff as they're negotiating that's one thing but i really do trust them to negotiate on our you know on our behalf and do what's in the best interest of lcps so that's i mean we may we may not like some of the aspects of it but at the end of the day we've also got to make sure that that we have what we need

[05:03:07] in order to keep our kids safe advice chair donahue thank you madam chair i just wanted to make a couple of responses first I take first the suggestion that anyone who wants to be involved with this process or does not support SROs is doing it for political reasons I take umbrage to I have been contacted by a number of people in the community who are opposed to SROs and a number of people who are in support of SROs as I'm sure colleagues on this board have been the

[05:03:44] same. Um, and I, I don't, uh, I don't think it's particularly fair or warranted to accuse any of us of political, or to accuse certain of us of political motivations because we happen to disagree. And I had another comment I wanted to make, but I've forgotten it. So thank you, Madam Chair. Dr. Rasheed. Thank you, Chair. I think we're getting into the thick of it. Um, I don't have a political agenda. I'd like to think none of us here have a political agenda because we're looking at the students overall I feel like this conversation is just getting

[05:04:23] deeper and deeper and we're just getting into the weeds of it and we're forgetting the essence of what we're here and what we're talking about for that reason I I really want to focus on the fact that I have to look at the students overall I have to look at their safety I also don't want to I guess nullify any of the work that the cabinet does and every and I'm just trying to look at the time frame here also when we see our aides back there working and and they work hard and a lot of money is going to them and it's per hour and I think it's important to recognize that so I'm just trying to get into the

[05:05:02] essence of it that if you want to think that if some people would like to think that this is a political agenda maybe it is out in the public but here on the dais? I'd like to think it's not. Thank you. Mrs. Griffiths. Thank you, Chair Chandler. Bottom line is this, having this committee is a delay. It is a delay where we may lose the funding for SROs or whatever, you know, this so-called committee is trying to do. It's a delay. We had a premature

[05:05:38] meeting before the Board of Supervisors. We should not have had it. We should have let them vote first and then had it come back to us. So it does come across political. And I totally get where Ms. Riccardi is. I don't want a circus, okay?

[05:05:54] I don't want conflicts of interest. And I'm seeing it constantly. And I do appreciate you clarifying for me it'll be board members and not committee members because community members. Because when it's community members, it's the same old crowd, the same cast of characters.

[05:06:10] It is political, okay? It's five to four here. It's a delay. And I don't even think this committee is a good idea. And that's my opinion. Thank you, Mr. Pepper. Thank you, Madam Chair. I just want to take a moment right now just to address something that should be a concern to every member of this community.

[05:06:29] And it's happening again tonight, but a couple weeks ago we had a presentation to the board that a parent wasn't treated in a way that didn't reflect the respect or appreciation that our parent volunteers deserve. and it goes back to this discussion too regardless of differing viewpoints or the topic being discussed anyone who steps forward to support our schools and to give themselves of us should feel should not feel dismissed or targeted or disrespectful so I really take offense what was just said because parent volunteers are the cornerstone of a thriving school community they give their time freely they're balancing work and family and other responsibilities only because they care about the students and all of us are here because

[05:07:09] we care about the students right the contributions of parents they're supporting classroom activities they're organizing events they're mentoring students they're bridging the gap between families and schools they are the fabric of what we do and we're here and yes we get paid but trust me and I'm telling this community it is not for the time that we put in and I think all of us on the board will readily agree with that our schools are better because of our volunteers when individuals choose to step forward and serve they do deserve gratitude. They deserve respect. And if we allow an environment to develop where volunteers feel they might be criticized or politicized or treated unfairly for participating, we risk losing the

[05:07:45] very people who help make our schools vibrant, who make our schools be successful. So since January, since I've been on this board, I've noticed a trend where staff members and now our parents, they're increasingly becoming targets. And disagreement, discussion, that's normal. It's part of the democratic process. But when we direct that conflict towards individuals and particularly our parents, that are dedicating their free time, their energy to support us.

[05:08:09] It's a dangerous and slope. So please, let's make sure that this discussion is on the criticism on ideas and not individuals. Let's do this with a collaborative spirit. So our community is the strongest when we come together with mutual respect, even if we disagree, okay?

[05:08:26] And so that's really important. Protecting that culture of respect while we disagree matters, not just for the adults, but for the kids in our system. So I really want to change that narrative, and I know my colleagues feel very strongly this is a delay.

[05:08:41] We set forth to get this right. This is the step one to getting this right. So let's stop beating around the bush. Let's talk about stop being this political. We are in this for the safety of our students. That is job one.

[05:08:57] Education is job 1A, but making sure our students are safe and supported is job one. So let's move forward in a way that gets this right and take our time to actually get this right to make sure our students are safe.

[05:09:14] Thank you. Vice Chair Donohue. Thank you, Madam Chair. I remember the other thing that I meant to say earlier, and I strongly applaud and second Mr. Pepper's comments that it's incredibly important to get this right for the safety of our students in our community.

[05:09:31] But the other thing I had meant to say earlier that I lost track of was that the negotiations that are occurring between our negotiating teams and the teams representing the other entities are all done in private behind closed doors. There is no public-facing aspect of this.

[05:09:47] And to me, I believe that that is one advantage of standing up a select committee because then we can have those conversations. To Ms. Riccardi's point, yes, I can have a closed door conversation with Ms. Mitchell or Mr. Allen or Ms. Boland or Dr. Spence or other people at LCPS to talk about my questions, thoughts, concerns about provisions of the MOU, but that is not transparent to our public and our community.

[05:10:09] So I think that this is an important measure for the public transparency. Thank you. Mrs. Griffiths. Thank you Madam Chair. As far as the people on this dais, some of us are new and they might not have context for the past three years as to volunteers versus activists. I just wanted to point that out that some of us have been dealing with activists for the past three years and that's

[05:10:44] what I'm trying to avoid. Thank you. I would like to come back and recenter this conversation. I really think it's important for us to take into account the fact that we are all duly elected officials. We are elected to represent our constituents.

[05:11:04] Each of us represents about 50 or 55,000 people. And Vice Chair Donahue represents about 400, I would guess we're getting close to 450,000 now.

[05:11:23] like or we could be getting close to half a million I don't know ultimately the MOU is between the school board as the organization it is our responsibility and it is our responsibility to work together and to work together in a tone of courtesy and respect and ultimately we may never agree on everything but each one of us has a right to be here and each one of us has a right to a perspective, and I think that we would be better served if we tried to listen and process the

[05:12:01] perspectives and make space for hearing the things that we don't necessarily agree with. People like to use the word political. People hate the word political, but ultimately everything is political, and it's not fair to just label something political if you like it or political if you don't like it like we are here we have been tasked to do a job and we have responsibilities to our constituents and I will leave it with that is there any further discussion all right let's

[05:12:40] move on to 13.04 the legislative and policy committee new policy 6330 distribution of information and posting within schools on school grounds or during school sponsored events presented by Mr. Svensson. Thank you, Madam Chair. I'm happy to dive into a super straightforward simple topic that's not related to politics at all. So the the board is well familiar with policy 6330. This governs the distribution and posting of materials at our schools and it was previously here before the board

[05:13:17] and then came back to committee where we made some substantial revisions and so for the benefit of the full board I wanted to walk through some of the changes that we made at the committee level first I and the changes we made at the committee level were made in response to public feedback that we had received we received comments from from students from parents from leaf representatives we had comments from principals comments from MSAC so this was a wide variety of voices and one of the first changes that we made was to

[05:13:55] add a purpose section at the beginning just to make clear that this is directed at minimizing intrusions on school operations by individuals that are not LCPS students or employees. There are other policies that govern student speech and expression and employees participation in political activities. So because we had some students who were concerned that this would infringe on their speech and expression, I wanted to make it clear by introducing an amendment that did pass through committee that this is about folks who are outside of that of that school community and their information

[05:14:32] that they are posting or distributing. There are a few more technical edits that were made that I that you can see reflected in the document. Another one that I wanted to highlight is that we made clear in the policy that requests that are received from the Loudoun Education Association are governed by the resolution provided for the collective bargaining and other collective bargaining agreements so this policy does not supersede what's already agreed to with LEA on on this topic I we also at the recommendation of

[05:15:06] MSAC added a disclosure requirement related to material that's generated by artificial intelligence, so that is made clear on materials that are distributed or posted. Miss Griffiths made a suggestion that we ultimately adopted the committee just to make clear that there's a reference to elected

officials coordinating with the government relations coordinator about visiting our schools and we made clear that's not referring to school board members that are elected we're referring to to other elected officials we also

[05:15:43] made a few clarifications on what constitutes a political cause because that could be quite broad that was at the suggestion of MSAC and then at the suggestion of multiple community members including principals and this is staff's original recommendation and also parents that we heard from we did remove what was previously section B3 that would allow for distribution of political materials at back-to-school nights and school open houses as it stands now coming to this full board political materials may be distributed on election

[05:16:18] day subject to certain parameters like 40 feet but we would not be permitting that distribution of political materials at other LCPS sponsored activities like a back-to-school night or school open house and I know this folks have differing opinions on this I think that ultimately you know our constituents the parents and students and community members LCPS that's who we we need to represent and the overwhelming feedback was that this is detracting from the back-to-school night purpose these are not public events that all community

[05:16:57] members are invited to this is parents are coming for their to come to their students classrooms to talk to their teacher and the political material distribution is interfering with that and I welcome folks to check out some of the public comments about how that's played out before but that is why we made a motion to strike that and with that explanation of some of the changes from you previously seeing it I will turn it back to you chair Chandler thank you mr. Spenton board members any questions mr. pepper

[05:17:26] Thank you, Madam Chair. First of all, I really want to thank the L&P committee, or L&P committee, now that we've moved the A, but I believe it started in L&P, for their hard work, because I know this is a pretty thorny policy, and you did a really good job kind of clearing it. My only concern with this is, and I agree completely with the non-election days, section B2, about, you know, parents don't want that, right? They don't want handing out the calendars or whatever the political organizations do.

[05:17:55] it's disruptive and my my concern continues to be um enforcement of this regulation um and would love um and maybe this is a discussion that we'd have to have i don't know with whom but um what the consequences are for individuals who just completely ignore this regulation um because i can envision you know a candidate who's unfamiliar with the regulations to come out and do this i know that we as candidates all got emails from the election office saying you know this is what you

[05:18:30] can do this is what you can't do. I really wish there were some teeth to the enforcement of this policy. That's all I'm going to say. Thank you. Ms. Chernoff. Thank you Madam Chair. I too am very appreciative of the work that you put into this. I felt like what you got out of it is a much cleaner version. It makes a lot of sense. I think the reordering makes sense. I think the clarifications make sense. I personally have voiced a struggle with sort of letting the back to school night piece go, but I feel confident that asking our administrators on one of the happiest times of coming back to school to manage

[05:19:07] this for our kids is the absolute not good thing we should do anymore. I do worry a little bit about some of the sneakiness about like it's a school calendar, it's this, it's that, so I think we'll still have some fringe things to deal with in terms of comms so batter up but I have one policy one little tweak I'm going to put together an amendment it really has it centers around one of the amendments you added at

line 99 and I know it's late but I'm just going to preview it for you so that everyone is looped in to what I'm thinking about but in mid that line it says this policy shall not be construed to prohibit the

[05:19:46] discussion and/or use of political or issue oriented materials as part of the classroom discussion project or school recognized public clubs and political clubs I know we have a lot of cross references in here but I do not think it would hurt to either add to that section or move that up to the header where you clarify the other exceptions that might make sense on line eight but I'll do that later but to cross reference policy 5420 that talks about teaching controversial and sensitive issues if we're going to make a comment about this wandering off into curriculum and to other areas I think that this should

[05:20:24] also be cross-referenced just as a safeguard to make sure that we have that provision there we have a great policy that we developed in that area so that's all I'll say I'll draft it I'll get it to you before at the next meeting thank you thank you Mrs. Griffiths can I ask Mr. Svensson to reread the what was the line as far as if students can post in their schools in you regarding students yes yes so I think the reference to students is at the very beginning of the policy we have just made clear that this policy does not relate to student

[05:21:03] speech and expression which continues to be governed by policy 8273 and it's accompanying regulation and there's another reference to students down on let's see page three line 94 it says that according staff shall not be permitted and students shall not be required to convey or deliver any material that advocates and so there's just a second reference of students they're saying they're not required to share political material but I think you may have been referring to the beginning part just the cross-reference

[05:21:40] to the student speech and expression policy any further discussion miss Riccardi thank you madam chair just as kind of the alternative voice this evening since that seems to be the thing I'm doing you know I back to so I went to every single back-to-school night for all of my schools and there were a lot of people there we had LEA people they are handing out stuff we had firefighter union people handing out stuff we had candidates handing out stuff we had you

[05:22:17] know issues people I think in a couple places that were handing us up and then some places we had nobody like it was just me in a couple places we have both parties we have independent candidates everybody is there it's one of the very very few opportunities especially if you're running for school board to actually meet parents especially if you're an independent candidate it makes it even even harder I think what's happening it's great for the nine of us because we can now go to back to school nights as the school board representative for our schools but if we you know but the people that are running that are new that are coming

[05:22:55] in in theory now cannot you know cannot be on the campus and neither can anyone else I think and and to add to that there are no teeth to this so candidates can still show up and they will people will still groups will still show up you know and do what they do there's really no way for us to really enforce this and And I get really hesitant about limiting.

[05:23:22] Look, I get both sides of it. I get the fact that after these events are done, people have stuff all over their campus, all these materials strewn all over. I understand very clearly what a lot of the issues were at a lot of these locations. I'm very sympathetic to that.

[05:23:38] I'm very sympathetic to the fact that your parents are walking up getting stuff shoved at them from lots of different people and lots of different entities. I get it. I think this has taken a different... This has gone, you know, where one extreme wasn't working.

[05:23:54] I think this is at the other end of it, too. And I feel like we need to really figure something in the middle that at least allows our candidates to be able to meet parents. And perhaps they don't give out materials. Perhaps it's just the candidates that are running. We've got to figure out a way to make that work.

[05:24:11] But I feel like it's... I had so many parents that saw me at a back-to-school night and then saw me at voting, they're like, oh, yeah, I met you at back-to-school night. It's great to see you again, or whatever. I think that's how we build community, and having exposure to parents in that environment is important.

[05:24:29] I get that the paper is a lot, and it's probably too much. But I feel like we might be able to find kind of a middle ground here where at least the candidates can be out there at least greeting as people are coming in. I think there's some real value to that, and I think that's good for our parents.

[05:24:47] it's good for our communities. And to completely erase, like go from one end to the other, I think it's a lot. And again, I think you're going to have a lot of problem enforcing it. I don't even know how that's going to play out, especially really busy back to school nights. But I just want to throw that out there as an option. Mr. Svensson. Thank you, Madam Chair. I just, on the enforcement piece, I understand the concern and perhaps Ms. Mitchell and Dr. Bergen can speak to this. You know, either we can chat about it afterwards about what would be the best practices for a school in terms of enforcement.

[05:25:22] I actually think enforcement is easier given the way we've developed this policy because I saw folks, SSOs, trying to enforce this or SROs trying to enforce this under the current system. And they're trying to tell people what's 40 feet, what's not. Here, it's a lot more straightforward. You can't do it.

[05:25:38] I mean, it's a lot easier to communicate that message as opposed to being patrolling around the school and making sure people aren't sneaking around and skipping that 40 feet. So I understand there are still enforcement concerns, but I think it's a lot easier to communicate what is and is not allowed under this revised policy.

[05:25:58] I also really enjoy going to back to school night and meeting parents. I just think that it's not the only opportunity that candidates running for political office have to engage with parents. There is the tried and true door knocking, phone calls, community events, but I hope in the absence of candidates coming to back to school nights, perhaps community groups will stand up forums where parents are opting in to getting that information from candidates and want to hear from them.

[05:26:25] It's just, I think it's about the appropriate setting and context and the back to school nights focused on parents getting into their students' classrooms and talking to the teacher and not on politics. But I totally agree that there should be opportunities for that engagement.

[05:26:41] I think there are other areas where that can happen and just not at the back to school night. - Thank you. I'm actually going to take a moment because I haven't spoken on this issue yet. Thank you. But then we'll come back. Ultimately, I hope that we will take a fulsome view on this issue.

[05:27:01] I can say with full veracity that every point that has been made for and against this, I've struggled with for two years. We certainly had it in front of our committee when I was LAMP chair.

[05:27:19] I recognize all the challenges there are about this. I certainly hope and invite parents and community members to offer us feedback on this issue. When I reflect on my time as a candidate, I didn't necessarily feel that my being there was welcomed by the community.

[05:27:44] And that was even when I was part of the community and a parent at the school and, you know, someone that knew lots of community members in the time. I think it's important for us to consider when our responsibility is to make sure that we're governing the school system.

[05:28:03] And we have an obligation to weigh all of these things and hopefully look out for what's best for the community and the parents. And with that, Ms. Riccardi. I just wanted to add to it a little bit of a different perspective you know and I keep saying like you Sterling's not like the rest of Loudoun and when I say that even in the campaigning process it's very different people do not open their doors you can't really go door knock and meet people because people don't open their doors ever like it's just not a thing the one place where people do show up are their kids schools and it is an opportunity to be able to have that you know have

[05:28:40] that interaction and again this is working I guess in theory against my best interest because if I decided to run again I want the other another candidate to be out there meeting parents I'm good with that because the public needs to have that access and in some of our communities the access that you're going to get is going to be at the school because people are working multiple jobs they're not home there you know it's just not there's just the accessibility issue is really you know it's a real thing and I know we're dealing with that in Sterling quite a bit so I appreciate the fact that that you suggest that there's other places to go but in some of our communities there

[05:29:19] really isn't much many other options because people aren't you know they're not at the neighborhood swimming pool because we don't really have a lot of neighborhood swimming pools in Sterling it's not a thing it's just a you know there's just a it's just more challenging and you know I'm I think we've really got to sit down and think about this a little bit more and think about how can we give our candidates the opportunity to meet but perhaps without quite so much noise and in a much less disruptive manner. I think that would be important and to be perfectly honest

[05:29:57] with you it's you know I love the fact that you know I love our LEA partners for sure but they endorse candidates too and so if they have access to our schools and they can put candidate logos on stuff that's handed out you know as we all did with calendars and whatnot it gives an unfair advantage to those specific you candidates too so we've got to really think about this because and again I don't think there's a it's bad to have at you know LEA or anybody else you know any of the other groups they're supporting who they're going to support but perhaps it's an issue more

[05:30:36] of not having all the paper flying about thanks thank you I'm Dr. Rasheed I just seem to be a little confused because here we were like 15 minutes 15 or 20 minutes ago talking about political avoidance and we were talking about the previous item which was I think it was 1303 but now if we have candidates come into the schools now we're bringing politics to the schools I understand having an elected official there but I'm just confused because we're talking about two different themes here we're talking about well we don't

[05:31:15] want, we don't want the other candidates to come, or we do want them. If we want them to come, then doesn't it turn into a political playground? And then if you have, we were talking about the MOU before, and then we were saying, well, we don't want, we don't want politics to get in the mix.

[05:31:30] So those are my thoughts. Just a little bit of confusion here. Thank you. Mrs. Griffiths. Thank you, Madam Chair. I think the bottom line is it hurts getting into the politics because we're elected officials. Democrats, Republicans, and Independents. It hurts all three. We are running for school board. What better way than to meet your constituents than going to a school? I am with Ms. Riccardi, and maybe just a candidate goes, maybe not all the literature, but I just

[05:32:08] want everybody to remember who it hurts when they are trying to campaign for school board. Democrats, Republicans and independents. Thank you. Thank you. Ms. LaBelle. Thank you, Madam Chair. Just as an alternative thought, I think what we are worried about or concerned about is, as Mr. Spenson said, the parents are there that night to make contact with teachers. The rest is a distraction. But I will say that that is one of the few places where parents can actually, the school is, where parents

[05:32:45] can actually meet the person that may become or currently is either way the their representative on this board if well thinking back I was invited by a group in Luckett's to come to the school with all the other candidates and be available to talk to parents we had a debate but it doesn't even have to be a formal debate it could be just meet the candidates night if the school would promote it you probably get more parents to come than just oh the candidates are

[05:33:24] going to be there and it could eliminate the problem of handing out papers you know people talking to you if you don't want them to talk to you leaving stuff on your car all of that would be eliminated if we had come meet your candidate night and and point out that these are the people that are going to be making decisions in the coming years about your child's school and their future and that might be something we should consider that's all I'm vice

[05:33:59] here Donahue thank you chair Chandler I just am surprised by the direction that our group conversation is going at this time only because this policy came to this board in a slightly different incarnation of the board in december having come out of the then la and p committee including an amendment to continue having literature handout at back school nights and the preference of the majority of this board including some members who are here

[05:34:35] tonight was to was not in support of that and to send it back to committee for some work sessions and some additional consideration and additional work and to bring it back again and now it's here and now LNP has done that work very admirably it seems collected additional feedback clearly thought very thoroughly and carefully about the issues here and is bringing this recommendation to the

[05:35:03] board. I spoke in, I wrote the amendment to keep it in previously. I'm not a person who has said like, we have to get rid of this. But at this point where we worked on it in committee last year for quite a while, it came here, it was sent back to committee. If my colleagues feel that strongly that they think that it should be in, then there is the option of proposing amendments in advance of our next meeting but I having seen seeing now that it is 10

[05:35:41] o'clock and we still have closed session I'm I'm I don't know encouraging my colleagues to think about tabling additional discussion for later Dr. Rasheen just want to piggyback off what Vice Chair

Donahue just said just to raise a question of privilege and refer to policy 2420 and if we could just get a temperature check to see if we could go to a closed meeting at this time

[05:36:06] All right. Our colleague has requested, since it's 10. 03, that we will take a temperature check to move forward with our closed session, which would mean we would not do the forecast, the second quarter forecast or school board member comments and committee reports.

[05:36:34] Would you like any advice, Chair Donahue? Thank you, Madam Chair. I was wondering if we could possibly get some information from Dr. Bergen. if you're the appropriate person regarding how long the second quarter forecast would take if we were to hear that and maybe forego board member comments and new business and go to closed

[05:36:58] 30 seconds okay okay given that a perfect response um board members please by show of thumbs up let me know if you would like to forgo board member comments and committee reports all right so thank you so much everyone we will move on to the last actual information item on our agenda which is

[05:37:32] 13.05 office of the superintendent second quarter forecast presented by dr bergen thank you madam chair board members the second quarter forecast is posted to this agenda item it is a summary of topics that the administration intends to bring forward under advisory updates work sessions and information items if you'd give it some careful review if you have any questions please feel free to contact me this is a working document we're just signaling to you what we intend to bring to the board in the months of april may and june thank you thank you board members is there any

[05:38:07] new business all right seeing no new business vice we'll move on to the motion to convene a a closed meeting. Vice Chair Donahue, do you have a motion? Yes, thank you, Madam Chair. I move that the Loudoun County School Board recess this public meeting and enter into a closed meeting pursuant to section 2.2-3712 of the Code of Virginia for the following. Consultation with legal counsel employed or retained by a public body and briefings by staff members pertaining to actual litigation where such consultation or briefing in open meeting would adversely affect the negotiating or litigating posture of the public body and requiring the provision of legal advice by such counsels authorized by sections 2.2-3711 sub-A sub-7 and 2.2-3711 sub-A sub-8 of the Code of Virginia.

[05:38:47] Discussion and consideration of the assignment of a specific public employee and consultation with legal counsel employed or retained by public bodies regarding specific legal matters requiring the provision of legal advice by such counsel is authorized by sections 2.2-3711 sub-A sub-1 and section 2.2-3711 sub-A sub-8 of the Code of Virginia. And discussion and consideration of the performance of a specific public employee is authorized by section 2.2-3711 sub a sub 1 of the code of virginia vice chair donahue has made a motion do i have a second uh thank you i have a second by dr rasheed it has been properly moved and seconded that the loudon county school board

[05:39:24] go into closed session is there any discussion seeing no discussion board members please uh clerk please open the vote board members please record your vote clerk please close and oh well Mr. Allen, would you advise us to wait for Mrs. Griffiths to come back to vote?

[05:39:55] Because ultimately, I believe the vote for the closed session needs to reflect. Yes, that would be the most cautious approach. Okay, thank you.

[05:41:10] Okay, clerk, please close and display the vote. The motion passes unanimously with all nine school board members present. The board is now in closed session.

[06:14:23] The board is now coming out of closed.

[06:20:16] Vice Chair Donahue, do you have a motion? Yes, thank you, Madam Chair. I move that the closed meeting be adjourned, that the Loudoun County School Board reconvene its public meeting, and that the minutes of the public meeting reflect that no formal action was taken in the closed meeting. Vice Chair Donohue has made a motion. Do I have a second?

[06:20:34] I have a second by Dr. Rasheed. It has been properly moved and seconded that the Loudoun County School Board adjourn the closed session. Is there any discussion? Seeing no discussion, clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please record your vote. Clerk, please close and display the vote. The motion passes unanimously with all nine school board members present by chair Donahue Do you have a motion? Yes, thank you madam chair I move that the following resolution certifying the closed meeting be adopted and reflected in the minutes of this public meeting Resolution number three four - two five slash two six

[06:21:13] Whereas the Loudoun County School Board has convened a closed meeting on this date pursuant to an affirmative recorded vote and in accordance with the provisions of the Virginia Freedom of Information Act and whereas Section 2.2-3712 sub D of the Code of Virginia requires a certification by the school board that such closed meeting was conducted in conformity with Virginia law.

[06:21:33] Now therefore, be it resolved, the Loudoun County School Board hereby certifies that, to the best of each member's knowledge, one, only public business matters lawfully exempted from open meeting requirements by Virginia law were discussed in the closed meeting to which this certification applies, and two, only such public business matters as were identified in the motion convening the closed meeting were heard, discussed, or considered by the Loudoun County School Board.

[06:21:54] Vice Chair Donahue has made a motion. Do I have a second? I have a second by Dr. Rasheed. It has been properly moved and seconded that the Loudoun County School Board certify the closed meeting. Is there any discussion? See none. Clerk, please open the vote. Board members, please record your vote. Clerk, please close and display the vote. That motion passes unanimously with all nine school board members present.

[06:22:24] Okay. Thank you so much. With that, that concludes our business this evening, and we can move on to adjournment. The March 24, 2026 school board meeting is adjourned. Thank you, and please drive home safely.

